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## BATTLE OF THE GALACTIC OVERLORDS

*By Josh Tyrangiel*

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**Cover Story**

- # Choose Your Overlord

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# Choose Your Overlord

**Musk vs. Bezos **

by Josh Tyrangiel

Tue, 13 Oct 2026



*Updated at 7:00 a.m. ET on October 14, 2026*

The Adriatic has been crossed by Odysseus and Caesar, by Venetian fleets and Napoleon's navy, by countless men bent on dominating the world. It has seen its share of courage and folly. But one day in June 2025, off the island of Cres, it witnessed something genuinely new: a man worth $240 billion standing waist-deep in bubbles on the deck of a $500 million yacht, wearing a white bucket hat.

The man is Jeff Bezos, and the woman photographed in the string bikini next to him—hugging him, rubbing him with bubbles—is his fiancée, Lauren Sánchez. Bezos is shirtless, and it must be said: He is ripped. His hairless torso is so buff, his expression so amused, that he looks more like a louche cartoon character—a Club Med Ninja Turtle—than a 61-year-old corporate executive. In the foreground, an anonymous crew member, his face hidden from

view and his thoughts forever unknown, mans a cannon blasting bubbles into the Croatian sky.

The foam party was a birthday celebration for Sánchez's 19-year-old son, a prelude to the Bezos-Sánchez wedding five days later in Venice—with 200 VIP guests, hundreds of protesters, and an estimated cost of $50 million. The wedding consumed the internet for a week and was treated as a self-contained cultural event, a thing worth interrogating or gawking at on its own terms.

In fact it was the culmination of one of the weirder decades that any American billionaire has ever had. The whole republic, to be fair, has been pretty nuts, and Bezos has been both caught up in the insanity and an agent of its acceleration.

In 2013, Bezos, who founded Amazon and still owns roughly 8 percent of the company, purchased *The Washington Post* for $250 million. Two years later, Donald Trump accused him of using the paper as a tax shelter, to which Bezos jokingly responded that Trump should be launched into space. Trump then said at a rally, "If I become president, oh, do they have problems." Trump became president, and the Pentagon steered a massive cloud-computing contract away from Amazon Web Services, while Trump repeatedly pressured the U.S. Postal Service to raise Amazon's shipping rates.

In 2019, Bezos and his wife, MacKenzie, announced their decision to divorce. A month later, Bezos accused the *National Enquirer*'s parent company of attempted extortion after he said it threatened to release intimate photos, including what its chief content officer described in an email as a "below the belt selfie—otherwise colloquially known as a 'd*ck pick.'" (The company said it had "acted lawfully" but would conduct its own investigation.) This is how much of the world learned about Lauren Sánchez, which was awkward because her brother Michael, a court later determined, had spoken with the tabloid about his sister's relationship and sold —for $200,000—information, text messages, and a number of

Bezos's "'racy,' 'explicit' photos." Bezos suggested, without evidence, that the plot had been instigated by the Trump administration and the Saudi government in retaliation for the *Post*'s reporting on the murder of its columnist Jamal Khashoggi by the Saudis.

That's already a lot, even by billionaire standards.

Bezos then stepped down as CEO of Amazon in 2021; went to space aboard a rocket built by Blue Origin, the aerospace company he'd quietly founded two decades earlier; and began devoting the majority of his time to the company. Over roughly the same period, he commissioned the world's largest sailing yacht and worked on building a 10,000-year clock inside a mountain. By the time of his second wedding, Bezos had transformed physically and politically—killing a *Post* endorsement of Kamala Harris for president, attending Donald Trump's second inauguration in a seat of honor, reorienting the paper's Opinion section around "personal liberties and free markets," cheerleading Amazon's reported $40 million deal for a documentary and future docuseries about Melania Trump.

People change. And if Bezos were just another middle-aged guy using his money to become unrecognizable to his former self—God bless. Enjoy the Met Gala.

But we live in a society where trivializing the actions of our wealthiest citizens is both unbeatable fun and a form of recklessness. For most of the past decade, the changes in Bezos that attracted attention were the meme-able ones: his body, his partner, his yacht. This made the transformation that mattered harder to see. We've been gawking at Bezos becoming a different kind of billionaire while missing his attempt to become a different kind of historical figure. The man who once rewired how the planet buys and sells everything has been chasing an even grander project—

creating the infrastructure for an off-world economy upon which human civilization might someday depend.

If this sounds implausible and potentially menacing, you will not be surprised to learn that the person standing between Bezos and his ambition is the implausible and menacing Elon Musk, who has spent the past two decades building a commanding lead in space while pursuing a different vision of where humanity should go once it gets there.

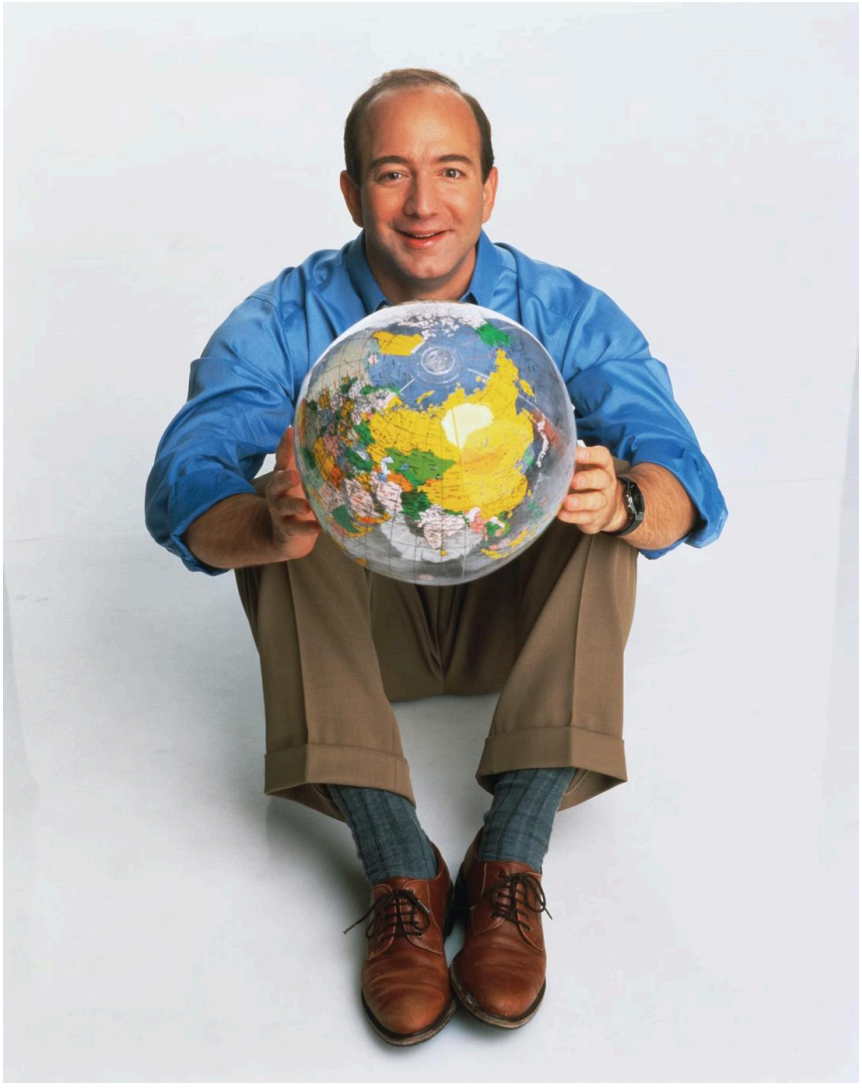
Together, in fierce competition, these two billionaires are in the early stages of a race to vertically integrate the galaxy—a process that involves rockets, moon landings, enormous satellite constellations, and space-based data centers running AI models fueled by computing power that no terrestrial supplier can match. Both say they hope to preserve human life from the specter of climate change and expand mankind's understanding of the universe. Both would also like to dominate a market that, unlike every other market they've previously conquered, has no ceiling and few established rules.

Whether any of this is wise is a question the rest of us are not really being asked. For most of human history, the power to decide where a civilization went next belonged to governments, monarchs, or despots. It's a measure of how much has changed that a retail executive from Seattle and a South African–born engineer are well positioned to exercise that power. Nobody voted for either of them. And they may be the only ones who can check the other's power. Jake Sullivan, Joe Biden's national security adviser, described this to me as "a very weird situation." You've got two men with unfathomable power and an unshakable faith that they're destined to shape the world. But neither of them is "actually Lex Luthor," Sullivan said.

" … Right?"

Perhaps not. But any answer requires a deeper understanding of the two men involved. Musk, typically, has overshared. Bezos has been more secretive. To reveal his character and intent, you first have to get past the foam.

In the 1990s, when reporters began tracing the origin story of the first king of e-commerce, they made their way to Miami, where Bezos grew up, and to Ursula Werner, his high-school girlfriend. They had listened to ABBA together and he'd made her adoring flyers for her birthday, and she told those reporters something about him that, for years, seemed like just another cute bit of color: "The reason he's earning so much money," Werner said, "is to get to outer space."



Jeff Bezos in 1999 (Chris Carroll / Getty)

In his high-school-valedictorian speech, Bezos quoted *Star Trek*—"Space, the final frontier"—and asked his audience to imagine vast orbital colonies where humanity could relocate Earth's most polluting industries, an idea cooked up by the Princeton physicist Gerard K. O'Neill in the 1970s. "The earth is finite," Bezos explained to a local reporter. "And if the world economy and population is to keep expanding, space is the only way to go."

All of this nerd enthusiasm was out in the open until 2000, when Bezos created Blue Origin Enterprises. He based the company a short commute from Amazon's Seattle headquarters and kept its existence a secret for three years, until *Newsweek* discovered it. This was not the only strange thing about Blue Origin.

For a while, the company's sole employee was the science-fiction writer Neal Stephenson, best known for *Snow Crash*, a 1992 novel set in a near-future America where the government has collapsed and corporations run everything. In a blog post, Stephenson wrote that his title at Blue Origin was "Member, Technical Staff," and that he "performed operations as prosaic as punching down Ethernet cable, operating a plate grinder, and passivating rocket parts."

But that was just part of the job. "The bulk of my efforts," Stephenson wrote, "were devoted to investigating possible alternatives to conventional rockets."

Bezos wanted to know if almost a century of rocket science had gotten the basic question wrong—whether there was a smarter way to get to space than attaching a tube to massive amounts of fuel and setting it all on fire. Stephenson and the handful of other employees who were eventually hired ran software simulations that would either validate the conventional approach or, Bezos hoped, find its replacement. This is a pretty wild way to spend your money.

Three years of experiments proved that Wernher von Braun and Robert Goddard hadn't missed anything. Only then did Bezos hire the former NASA engineer Rob Meyerson and buy 165,000 acres of Texas scrub brush where rocket prototypes might someday be launched without scrutiny.

Eventually Meyerson would be promoted to president—but of what, exactly? In the early years, Blue Origin had no customers or finished product, and little of what ordinarily makes a company a business. Bezos left the CEO job vacant and imposed no conventional timetable. It did have a tortoise mascot and a motto—"*Gradatim ferociter*" ("Step by step, ferociously")—that reinforced its commitment to getting to space slowly, secretly, and stubbornly. Employees were focused on whiteboarding a tourism rocket, but Bezos told Meyerson not to worry about sales or pitching government agencies; he didn't want to be held hostage by customers. It was "a science experiment for the first 15 years," Tom Jones, Blue Origin's vice president of human resources from 2016 to 2019, told me.

Contrast this with the hyper-logical way that Bezos had conceived Amazon. In an early interview, Bezos explained that the internet was growing at 2,300 percent a year; to capitalize on that growth, he needed a product category with more variety than any physical store could stock. There were more than 3 million active book titles worldwide. Therefore: books.

If Amazon was the company that Mr. Spock would create, Blue Origin was where Bezos got to lead with his heart and be Captain Kirk. He'd take days off from Amazon for field trips, packing Blue Origin employees onto his private plane and dropping in on companies with cultures or engineering accomplishments that he admired. Gradually, Bezos cleared all of his Wednesday afternoons and many of his Saturdays to work at the Blue Origin office. When Bezos wanted to learn about heat-transfer codes—software that models how heat moves through a rocket engine; the difference

between an engine that survives its own combustion and one that doesn't—Meyerson hired an employee to tutor him.

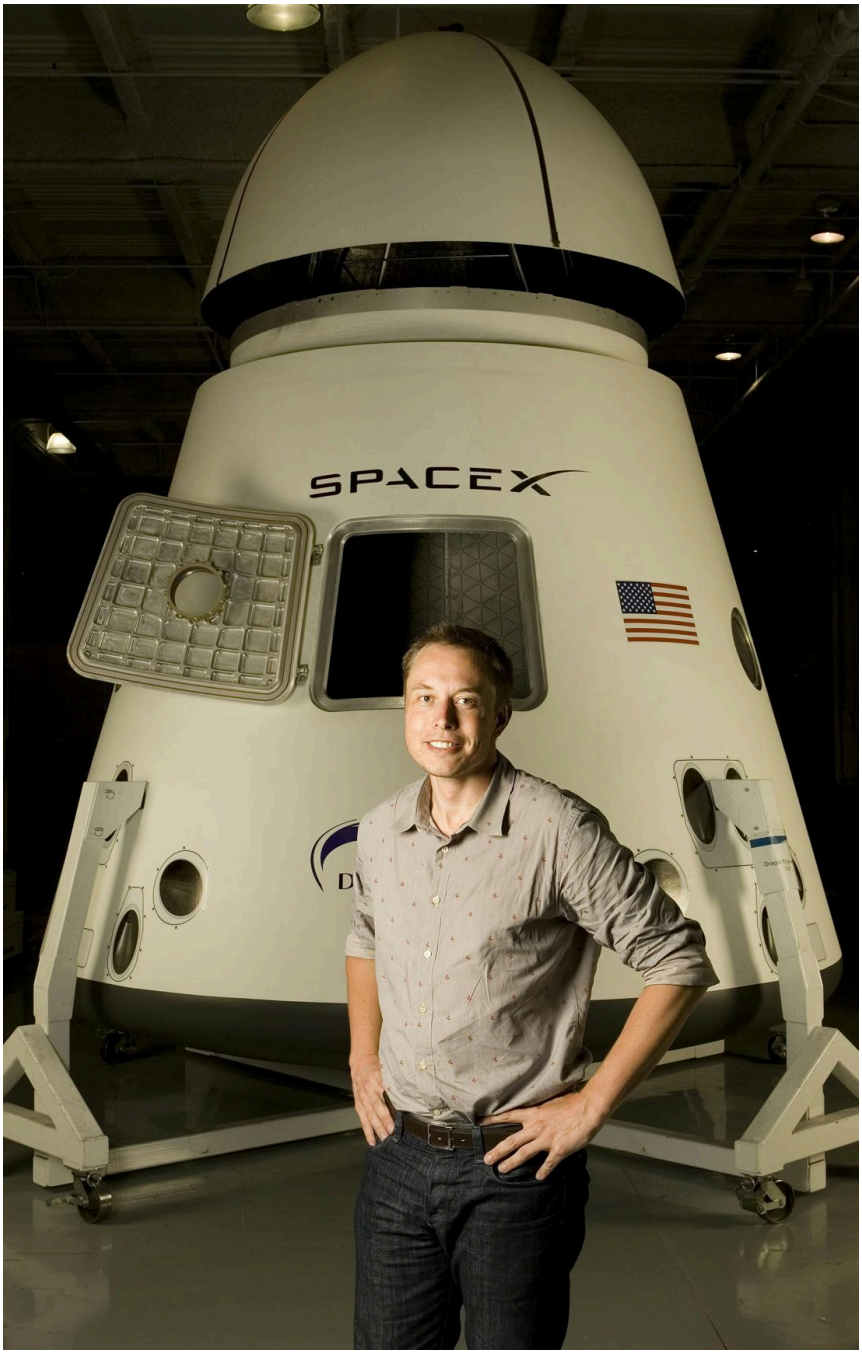
I asked Meyerson, who is now the CEO of Interlune, which aims to mine the moon for helium-3, if managing Bezos's enthusiasm ever got in the way of accelerating Blue Origin's progress. "My job was to do both," he said. "The time that he put into Blue was a gift to us, because the more he understood, the more he was willing to support what was needed for the long run."

And yet, when it came to money, the accountant overruled the dreamer. Bezos was rich—*Forbes*'s 100th-wealthiest American—but not send-my-money-to-the-moon rich. He didn't want "to spend the kind of money he's spending today," Meyerson said. Blue Origin would work through simulations, models, and small prototypes—staying within its means until Bezos was ready to scale up.

This would have been fine if Blue Origin were operating in a vacuum. But two years after Bezos founded his dream company, someone else started a company with a dream just as large. And he was not interested in moving slowly.

Impatience is part of Elon Musk's mystique. So is an eagerness to break and remake things: the economics of car buying (Tesla), the operations of the federal government (DOGE), the last remaining norms of social media (X—now a platform for disturbing racial theories).

But Musk didn't set out to revolutionize aerospace and become the world's most successful rocket builder. Originally he just wanted to be a rocket buyer.




Elon Musk in 2008 with an early model of SpaceX's Dragon capsule, designed to carry a crew or cargo into space atop a rocket (Dan Tuffs / Getty)

In 2001, Musk announced that he would send a robotic greenhouse into space, scoop up some Martian soil, and use it to grow a plant. This scientific publicity stunt may not go down as Musk's best idea, but his attempt to buy refurbished intercontinental ballistic missiles for the Martian-soil gambit led him to Moscow, where, according to Ashlee Vance's biography, *Elon Musk*, a Russian

engineer spat on him (literally) and his PayPal millions. Flying back from a second unsuccessful trip, Musk opened a spreadsheet and realized that he could build a rocket for less than the $8 million the Russians wanted to charge him to buy one—and for less than anyone had ever built a rocket before. He founded SpaceX a month later.

It's easy in hindsight, and with this year's $1.8 trillion SpaceX IPO, to say that Musk had a better plan than Bezos to get to space. What's inarguable is that Musk had a faster plan. He staffed up by cold-calling college aerospace students and handing them ludicrous deadlines—the first launch was scheduled for 15 months after the company was created. Speed gave SpaceX swagger, and that swagger gave its young employees faith. But the company's most important virtue was thrift. Not as a means of preserving Musk's wealth, but because lowering costs was the entire point of the business.

For decades, getting a person or a satellite into orbit was so expensive that only governments and the largest defense contractors could afford it. Musk believed that this had little to do with physics; unlike Bezos, he spent no time wondering whether there might be a fundamentally different way to get to space. Instead, he looked at launch costs the way a deregulator might have looked at long-distance telephone rates in the 1970s: not as a law of nature, but as the product of the people who had gotten there first and decided what to charge.

If SpaceX could create a reusable rocket capable of driving launch costs down far enough, it wouldn't just swallow all the existing demand—it would transform space from a cartel into a free market. Satellite builders, scientists, start-ups, and, eventually, anyone with a payload and a business case could participate. Access to space would become as abundant as telephony. And then all sorts of innovation might happen.

Bezos had a similar vision, and both men believed that reusable rockets were the key to making space affordable. But while Blue Origin was moving step by step, SpaceX skipped every step it could. Employees were celebrated for outrageous hacks, such as figuring out that off-the-shelf car-wash valves worked just fine for rockets if you swapped their seals. All of that ingenuity led to Musk's promise that SpaceX's first rocket, Falcon 1, would carry a 1,400-pound payload into orbit for $6.9 million—75 percent less than any competitor.

He nearly went bankrupt doing it. The first three Falcon launches failed. By 2008, SpaceX and Tesla were burning cash. Musk was barely solvent enough to make one more launch attempt. On September 28, Falcon 1 reached orbit, making SpaceX the first privately funded company to launch a liquid-fueled rocket into space. The timing was exquisite. Three months later, as the global financial system teetered and Musk was days away from missing payroll, NASA awarded SpaceX a $1.6 billion contract to resupply the International Space Station. The company had gone from near death to indispensable in a single quarter.

A former senior NASA official who visited both companies in their early years described Blue Origin to me as an academic lab and SpaceX as a pirate ship. "SpaceX was scrappy," the official said. "I went to the Blue factories in Kent, Washington, and they were these beautiful, massive buildings with the world's best 3-D printers. And I was like, *Where are the people?* Then you go to SpaceX in Hawthorne, and there's these young people running around; everybody's greasy."

The differences were hardly lost on the people watching from Blue Origin. SpaceX had taken Amazon's "get big fast" playbook and applied it to rockets—staffing up, sprinting to deadlines, and treating its failures as content rather than embarrassment. The launch explosions and misfires it shared on social media didn't make SpaceX look reckless; they made it look humble. At Blue

Origin, the contrast was unmistakable: SpaceX seemed to be having more fun.

SpaceX soon proved that it could reuse rocket boosters—the bottom part where the flames shoot out. Its first reusable rocket, Falcon 9, launched and landed in 2015. By May 2016, SpaceX was on its way to becoming the UPS of low Earth orbit. Satellite customers could buy launches at published prices, and Falcon 9 was beginning to fly on something approaching a regular schedule. NASA was already relying on SpaceX to shuttle cargo to the International Space Station; the Air Force had certified Falcon 9 for national-security missions and had just awarded the company its first military-launch contract.

In West Texas, Blue Origin was completing the first takeoffs and landings of its New Shepard tourism rocket. Those missions were uncrewed and suborbital—which is to say, the rocket went to space the way a ball tossed upward in a backyard goes above the roofline: fleetingly. On Twitter, Musk pointed out how far ahead SpaceX was, beginning a series of exchanges in which two of the world's richest men engaged in public rocket-measuring contests. Musk won most of these, which makes sense, because Musk was winning.

People who have worked closely with Bezos bring up two defining characteristics. The first is a comfort, bordering on delight, at being misunderstood. "I think he enjoys it," a former Amazon senior executive told me. "You have no idea how stubborn he can be in defense of an idea only he believes. And of course a lot of times he's right." The second is that Bezos does not like multitasking. He's told audiences that as a little kid in Montessori school, he was so resistant to leaving things undone that he had to be picked up in his chair and moved to the next activity. Bezos prefers to direct his focus, as intensely as possible, on one problem at a time. As long as he remained the CEO of Amazon, that problem was Amazon. For

the first 15 years of Blue Origin's existence, the company had to accommodate that reality.

Whether it was Musk's taunts or the unignorable fact that SpaceX was racing ahead, Bezos finally changed course in 2016. During one of his regular Saturday meetings at Blue Origin, he asked a question that nobody in the room wanted to answer honestly: Why hadn't Blue Origin directly bid on an Air Force contract for rocket-engine development that had just gone to SpaceX? The answer: *Because you've always told us not to*.

Bezos delivered a new mandate to Meyerson: "From now on, we go after everything that SpaceX bids on."

When people in aerospace talk about SpaceX's advantages, they nod to Musk's maniacal expectations, his engineering instincts, and the particular quality of his attention. But Musk's attention has at times been distributed across Tesla, X, the neurotechnology company Neuralink, the tunnel start-up the Boring Company, the federal government, and 14 children by four women.

Musk's life is a browser with too many tabs. X is the tab that's always open. It's where he challenged Mark Zuckerberg to a cage match, offered to give Taylor Swift a child and guard her cats "with my life," and feuded with (partial list) Kanye West, the British government, the Australian government, the Brazilian supreme court, and a cave diver in Thailand he called a "pedo guy"—leading to a defamation lawsuit that Musk won after his legal team argued that the phrase was a generic insult. It's also where he regularly posts memes and has promoted anti-Semitic content that makes him, justifiably, a pariah among people who believe society is plenty coarse enough without him. (SpaceX did not respond to interview requests for this story.)

The point is, Musk is no more focused than Bezos. The difference is that he's never needed to be. This is because, in 2002, he had a

three-minute conversation with Gwynne Shotwell. Shotwell is 62, and remarkable in several ways—a woman in a male-dominated field, a proud former high-school cheerleader with degrees in mechanical engineering and applied mathematics. But her unique gift is the ability to read her boss's mind while ignoring his id. "I like his in-person self better than his Twitter self," Shotwell said in a 2022 talk at Stanford.

Shotwell is self-aware and funny. Not aerospace funny—actually funny. She grew up in the "boonies" north of Chicago and was a sophomore in high school when her mother dropped her off at a Society of Women Engineers event. She decided to become a mechanical engineer that day in part because one of the presenters "had the best suit on, and she had great shoes, and her bag matched her shoes," Shotwell told a podcast interviewer with delight.

Shotwell was in the middle of a career in traditional aerospace when she went to lunch with a former co-worker who had been poached by SpaceX. She was introduced to Musk on a tour of the office, and received a job offer to be vice president of business development that afternoon. For weeks she hesitated before pulling over on the Los Angeles freeway, calling Musk, and telling him that she was an "effing idiot" for not accepting sooner. He laughed and welcomed her to the team.

Since then, Shotwell and Musk have built one of the most drama-free partnerships in 21st-century business. He oversees engineering and technology while she takes care of everything else—sales, operations, manufacturing, workforce vibes. While Musk was supervising the 2008 do-or-die Falcon-rocket launch, Shotwell was at an industry conference in Glasgow, watching the livestream at 2 a.m. in her hotel room while writing the company's bid to resupply the International Space Station. When the rocket reached orbit, she ran down the hallway to rouse her colleagues and broke into the hotel bar to drink warm champagne.

In 2015, having proved that SpaceX could reliably deliver payloads to space, Musk announced plans for a constellation of thousands of satellites, now known as Starlink. The pitch had a noble dimension—SpaceX would bring high-speed internet to parts of the world that fiber-optic cables had left behind. But this disguised its real purpose. SpaceX's first act—flying rockets for hire—was not profitable enough. Getting in on boring old telecommunications would give the company a way to monetize its own launch capability. Starlink was created to be the thing that would pay for everything else.

The following year, Musk revealed the full scope of his plan: SpaceX would build a fully reusable two-stage rocket and spacecraft standing just over 400 feet tall and powered by 42 engines, with a capsule—the top part—capable of carrying 100 people to Mars (or 60 Starlink satellites into orbit). "The objective is to become a spacefaring civilization and a multiplanet species," Musk said at the time. "The main reason I'm personally accumulating assets is to fund this."

Previous spacecraft carried only what they needed for a mission. This would be like launching a Costco.

Scale is the great paradox of rocket science. A rocket twice as large as its predecessor isn't just twice as hard to build; as the rocket grows, so do the forces trying to tear it apart. At the size Musk envisioned, the fully fueled vehicle would weigh more than 10 million pounds, more than one and a half times the weight of the Saturn V, which carried astronauts to the moon. Lifting it would require engines more powerful than anything SpaceX had built before, with roughly three times the pressure of the engines powering its Falcon rockets—conditions so extreme that SpaceX would need to invent new manufacturing techniques simply to build the combustion chamber. And Musk intended to reuse everything: Both the giant booster and the spacecraft above it would return to Earth and fly again.

The design would change repeatedly—first landing legs, then enormous mechanical arms—but the economic premise remained the same. If full and rapid reuse worked, Musk believed that the cost of reaching orbit could eventually fall below $100 a kilogram, which would make the things that had always died on a spreadsheet—lunar bases, enormous satellite constellations, perhaps even human flights to Mars—possible. The architecture was elegant in its circularity. Starship, as the giant rocket and spaceship would come to be known, would make Starlink, the satellite array, far cheaper to deploy. Starlink would then generate revenue to pay for a fleet of Starships. And Starships, eventually, would get humans to Mars. Engineering, commerce, and Musk's interplanetary ambition, all stacked inside the same rocket.

People at Blue Origin first noticed the woman around 2018. She was seen at the Cedarbrook Lodge near the Seattle airport, a few minutes before Bezos arrived for drinks with executives. In West Texas, she began showing up as a contractor on the helicopter video team that documented New Shepard launches.

Lauren Sánchez Bezos is impossible not to notice because her lifelong goal, exuberantly pursued, is to be noticed. Sánchez Bezos grew up in New Mexico, learned she was dyslexic in community college, hustled her way into the University of Southern California, and for several years proceeded through the carnival of gigs (local news, *Extra*, *So You Think You Can Dance*) available to attractive and relentless people who want to be on television. She had a child with the former NFL tight end Tony Gonzalez before marrying Patrick Whitesell, the Hollywood agent and power broker, with whom she had two more children. In 2016, she got her helicopter pilot's license and started an aerial-production company.

The first public encounter between Bezos and Lauren Sánchez was at a December 2016 Amazon Studios party for the grim kids-die-in-a-fire movie *Manchester by the Sea*. It must have been like meeting Jayne Mansfield at a shiva. Both were married at the time, and

what happened next seems clear enough, even without the benefit of any photos from the *National Enquirer*. “Wonderful madness” is how Barry Diller, the media mogul and Bezos’s close friend, describes the relationship.

Understanding the force and fury of the response to the couple requires some unpacking, and it starts with the woman Bezos left. MacKenzie Scott studied creative writing at Princeton under Toni Morrison, did Amazon’s early bookkeeping out of Bezos’s garage, and has spent the years since their 2019 divorce giving away her share of the proceeds—more than $26 billion to more than 2,000 organizations—while largely erasing any evidence of her generosity. In August, she released a complicated third novel on Substack.

“I have great respect for and fondness for MacKenzie,” Diller told me. “You can see how she’s conducting her charitable work, which is remarkable—but it’s all quiet and private. And that’s MacKenzie.”

Lauren Sánchez Bezos enjoys being photographed at parties and events, and her picture is prominent on the website for the Bezos Earth Fund, a $10 billion investment in protecting “the best planet in this solar system,” where she’s vice chair. She’s written three children’s books—*The Fly Who Flew to Space*, *The Fly Who Flew Under the Sea*, and *The Fly Who Flew to the North Pole*—and if a brick wall were the only thing standing between her and the best-seller list, you wouldn’t want to be the wall.

“People assume she’s going to be Cruella, and she’s not,” a woman who’s been friends with Sánchez Bezos for a decade told me. “She’s smart and kind, and she has real accomplishments. But it’s confusing because snobby people look at her big, vulgar boobs, and she’s like, *Yeah! Look at ’em!* She likes being sexy. She just wants everyone to have a good time, and she doesn’t mind *being* the good time.”

Bezos and Sánchez Bezos make each other happy. This is not nothing, but the wonderful madness has had its costs. There was an alleged blackmail attempt to manage, a 25-year marriage to unwind, and a company that still depended on Bezos's attention. The scandal "had a huge impact at Blue Origin," Alexandra Abrams, the former head of employee communications, told me. (Abrams, who was fired in 2019, later went public with complaints about flight safety and criticized leadership, Bezos included, for what she described as a "toxic" culture; in response, the company said it had no tolerance for discrimination or harassment and stood by its safety record.) Abrams said that the news of Bezos's relationship with Sánchez "started to break the goodwill of a lot of the senior employees at the company. They were shocked that Jeff would comport himself in that way."

Only Bezos can say how much of his transformation has been driven or enabled by his new wife, and how much was always there, waiting for permission. And Bezos, who declined multiple requests for an interview, isn't talking.

A few weeks after the *Manchester by the Sea* party, Trump's NASA transition team invited Blue Origin to a meeting. With Bezos's decree to start competing, Bretton Alexander, the director of business development and strategy, scrambled to prepare.

Mike Pence was passionate about space. Trump understood the MAGA value of rockets and astronauts. So, the transition team asked: What big idea could Blue Origin offer that would be ready by the electorally convenient date of 2020?

"I didn't see the question coming," Alexander told me. But he blurted out, "We've landed New Shepard in the desert five times in the last year. We can land something on the moon, because we have the engines and we have the technology."

The last person to walk on the moon was the Apollo 17 commander, Gene Cernan, who let a crewmate climb the ladder before him so that he could utter the following: “We leave as we came and, God willing, as we shall return, with peace and hope for all mankind.” That was in 1972.

There’s no single explanation for why America hasn’t returned, but there are several timely reasons to go back. The moon is the most convenient place in the cosmos: three days away, without the communication lags that make deep-space operations so complicated. It has water-ice deposits, which theoretically could sustain human life and be split into hydrogen and oxygen, also known as rocket fuel. And because the moon’s gravity is one-sixth of Earth’s, less fuel is required to launch from its surface and explore the rest of the solar system. For 4.5 billion years, celestial objects have used the moon as target practice, enriching the lunar soil with most every rare mineral the solar system has produced. Half its face is shielded from Earth’s electromagnetic noise, which makes it valuable for radio telescopes and, as national-security officials will warn in varying degrees of specificity, potentially useful to America’s adversaries. The Chinese have committed to landing astronauts on the moon by 2030.

For all of these reasons, Alexander’s pitch appealed to the transition team. That it nudged federal space policy toward the moon—elevating Bezos’s high-school dreams while usurping Musk, who hoped the Trump administration would back a Mars mission—was, for Blue Origin, the chef’s kiss. Alexander called Rob Meyerson right away. “I said, ‘Oh shit, I just created a program.’”

Greg Autry, who now leads international space policy at the State Department, was on the transition team. “We knew they didn’t really have this thing in their garage,” Autry told me. The company had announced New Glenn, its first orbital rocket, earlier that year, but the new rocket had not even carried a commercial payload, let

alone human beings. But Blue Origin had “what appeared to be a simple and relatively quick way to get there, with a reusable system.” NASA, perhaps, was also beginning to realize that having a single dominant space-launch provider might in itself be a risk.

Animosity continued between Trump and Bezos, who remained publicly critical of the president’s immigration policies. The Pentagon awarded a cloud-computing contract worth up to $10 billion to Microsoft when Amazon Web Services was the undisputed market leader. Amazon sued—and asked for Trump to be deposed, arguing that the president’s dislike of Bezos had corrupted the bidding process. (The Pentagon’s Office of Inspector General found no direct evidence of White House interference but noted that it could not complete its assessment, because senior officials had asserted “presidential communications privilege.” The suit was thrown out in 2021 when a new contract was awarded to both Amazon and Microsoft.)

But meaningful friction appears to have stopped at Blue Origin’s door. A few months after Alexander’s meeting, Bezos flew to Washington to personally present his company’s proposal to the transition team. “That didn’t necessarily happen with the other companies,” Autry said. “You didn’t see their CEO or funder take the time to do that.” So began a drip of white papers and study contracts that, over several years, led to $592 million in government funding. Other than a 2019 meeting where Pence’s chief of staff told a Blue Origin executive that the company had a “*Washington Post* problem”—a detail later reported in *The Washington Post*—no one I spoke with could recall an instance when the Trump administration’s hostility toward Bezos translated into prejudice against Blue Origin.

There was plenty of turbulence at Blue Origin during this period, but it was self-inflicted, and well overdue.

At a Saturday leadership-team meeting in 2017, Bezos was presented with a memo outlining Blue Origin's annual budget request. Senior leadership wanted more than $1 billion, double the current budget. All of which would come out of Bezos's pocket.

When Bezos finished reading the memo, "he walks out, doesn't say a word," Tom Jones, Blue Origin's former vice president of human resources, told me. "About 15 minutes later, he walks in and he says, 'Why did I not know that you were going to be making a request this large until today?'" Jones described Bezos as calm, even affectionate; Bezos said that he loved the people in the room but that the request was "craziness," and wildly disproportionate to their achievements. The company had convinced Washington to take its lunar ambitions seriously, but it had yet to put anything into orbit. "It's probably one of the things that might have led to him thinking, like, *Okay, I've got to make a change here*."

Bezos responded by bringing in Bob Smith, a veteran of the aerospace company Honeywell, as Blue Origin's first CEO in September 2017. Smith told me he arrived at a company with no steady revenue stream and no supply chain: "Engineers would design a part, put the order out, and then it'd show up by mail back on their desk." It was essentially "a prototype shop."

Blue Origin might not have had a supply chain, but it did have a cosmology. Bezos "is God at Blue Origin," Alexandra Abrams said. "Jeff's big message was that it's too late for climate-change efforts on Earth, and we need to be able to leave. We need to sustainably go into space and build resources, have a base on the moon, which would act as a gas station to the rest of the solar system. At the company, everyone felt like we were saving humanity." (After publication of this story, Bezos said, through a spokesman, that he does not believe that it is too late for Earth.)

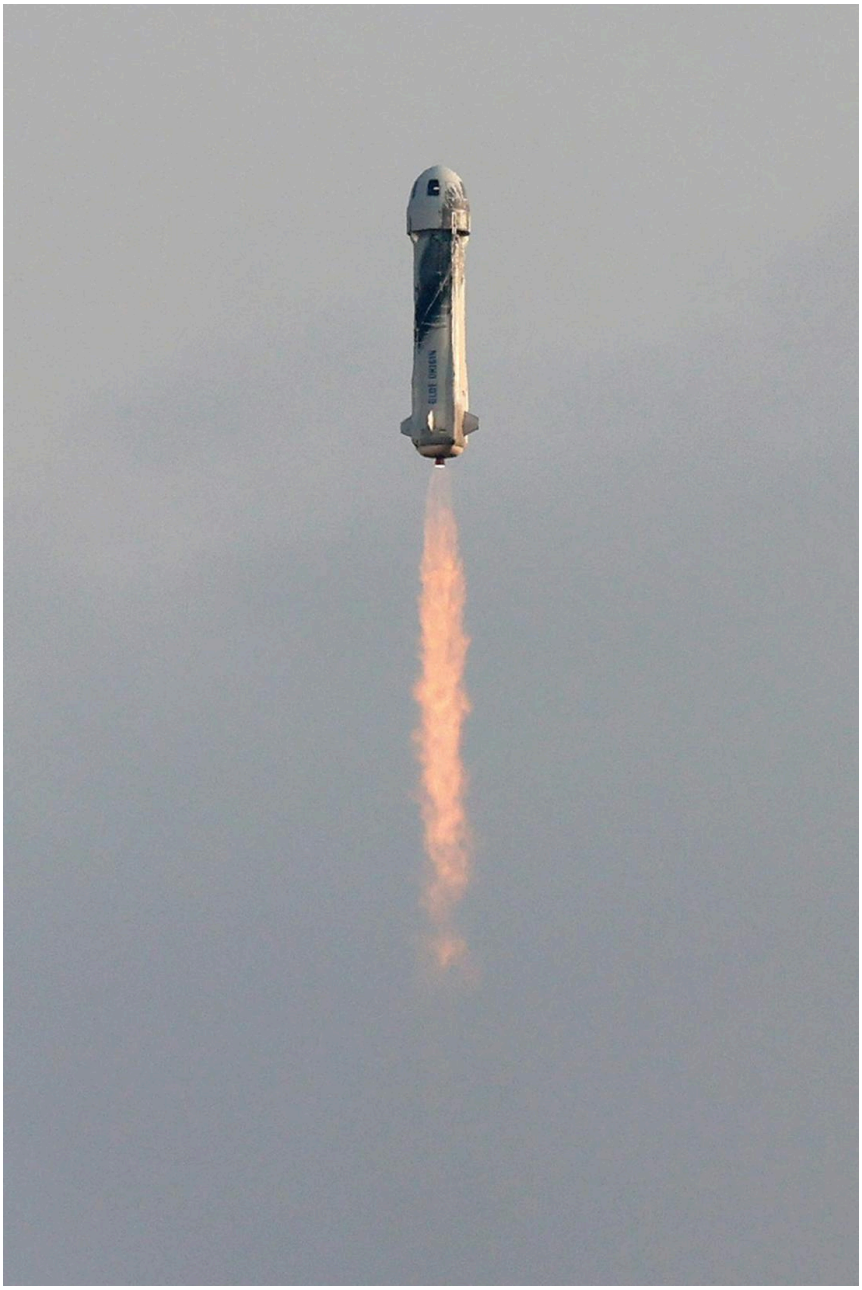
But God remained an intermittent presence. Bezos had tried to extract himself from Amazon for years—installing deputies,

restructuring leadership. COVID wrecked that project; Amazon's logistics network buckled in the spring of 2020, and Bezos had no choice but to dive back in. Meanwhile, Blue Origin was in the middle of a significant expansion. Bezos had authorized Smith to make thousands of new hires and build new factories, a transformation that required exactly the kind of consistent attention he couldn't provide. Bezos had made himself indispensable by being the only person who knew exactly what he wanted. He had never found his Gwynne Shotwell—or perhaps he'd never believed the job could be done by someone who wasn't him. In his absence, Blue Origin was growing fast and bidding on everything, but it was still chronically late.

New Glenn, Blue Origin's version of the Falcon, still wasn't flying by the time SpaceX began developing Starship. SpaceX announced its Starlink constellation in 2015, put prototypes into orbit in 2018, and began deploying at scale in 2019—at which time Amazon had not yet launched a single prototype for Project Kuiper, its we-can-do-satellites-too Starlink competitor. Bezos wasn't chasing Musk so much as arriving at places Musk had already left.

The pattern held as SpaceX started flying astronauts to the International Space Station. Blue Origin's answer, when it finally came, was personal.

On July 5, 2021, Bezos vacated the CEO seat at Amazon. Two weeks later, he flew to space on New Shepard, the tourism rocket his company had spent years building, alongside his brother, Mark; the aviation pioneer Wally Funk; and an 18-year-old whose father, a Dutch financier, had bought him a ticket. Bezos stepped out of the capsule in the West Texas heat wearing a cowboy hat and declared it the best day ever.



Blue Origin’s New Shepard rocket lifting off in 2021, with Bezos aboard (Joe Raedle / Getty)

The Bezos who returned to Blue Origin was different. He seemed determined to run the company the way he had once run Amazon—present, demanding, involved in every significant decision.

Smith’s 2023 resignation took no one by surprise. He had grown Blue Origin from roughly 850 employees to more than 10,000, accumulated billions of dollars in customer orders, and built enormous manufacturing facilities in Huntsville, Alabama, and

Cape Canaveral, Florida. But New Glenn continued not to launch. And when NASA, under the Biden administration, finally awarded the contract for its Human Landing System—the moon lander that Bretton Alexander had improvised into existence—it did not go to Blue Origin. SpaceX, proposing a lunar lander based on its Starship architecture, undercut Blue Origin's $6 billion bid by more than half.

What followed was also personal—and a little embarrassing.

Blue Origin filed a protest, prompting Musk to tweet, "Can't get it up (to orbit) lol," and to offer Bezos some unsolicited management advice. "I think he needs to run BO full-time for it to be successful," Musk told *The Washington Post*. "Frankly, I hope he does." Bezos offered to cover $2 billion of the lunar-lander costs, then $3 billion. When NASA ignored Bezos, Blue Origin sued. Musk, again: "You cannot sue your way to the moon." The courts agreed. The saga ended when NASA, nudged by Senators Patty Murray and Maria Cantwell of Washington, awarded Blue Origin a $3.4 billion contract to build a competing lander.

Bezos decided that the next person to lead Blue Origin didn't need to understand rockets or politics; they needed to understand him. Dave Limp had run Amazon's consumer-devices business—Kindle, Echo, Alexa—for nearly 14 years. Limp had also overseen Project Kuiper, where he pushed to spread the risk among multiple launch providers rather than depend on Blue Origin alone. He even said Amazon would be "crazy" not to consider SpaceX, given its track record.

In his final interview before accepting the job, Limp asked a single question: Was Blue Origin a hobby or a business? Because if it was a hobby, he wasn't interested. Bezos told him, "It's obviously a business. It has to be a business or it's not going to work."

During the decade when Bezos was reorganizing his life around space, he walked away from a promise he'd made on the day he bought the *Post*: "The paper's duty will remain to its readers and not to the private interests of its owners."

The killing of the Harris endorsement, the subscriber cancellations, and the cascade of staff reductions—all of this has been well chronicled, because there's no beat that journalists swarm quite like a competitor's newsroom. But the core questions about Bezos and the *Post* remain: Why does he appear to have inverted his own promise? Was this an act of betrayal or of neglect? And, in the end, is there a difference?

When Bezos first showed up in Washington, the paper's circulation was plummeting. One former *Post* executive described Bezos's 2013 arrival to me as a kind of rapture. He was a forceful presence, respectful of the wall between the editorial and business sides, but relentless about improving the customer experience. Those first two years were "absolutely fucking magical," the former executive told me. The *Post* went on a sustained run of profitability, and subscriptions surged throughout the first Trump administration.

But traffic and urgency declined in the Biden years, while COVID and Bezos's other interests made him a phantom in Washington. He surfaced to participate in hiring Sally Buzbee to succeed Marty Baron as executive editor in 2021. In 2023, the *Post* lost $77 million. Bezos surfaced again, to replace the paper's longtime publisher with Will Lewis, a British-tabloid veteran.

There were other candidates—a person close to the hiring process told me that one of them found their conversation with Bezos baffling. The *Post*'s owner couldn't answer basic questions about the newspaper. Bezos seemed inattentive, and said that his priorities would not change: He was focused on Blue Origin and Lauren. Bezos appeared to think that his lack of involvement would be attractive; the next publisher would have free rein.

I was a columnist at the *Post* for a year, and had a few conversations with Lewis early in his tenure. He'd been a journalist before entering the wolf pack of Rupert Murdoch's executive program, and among his talents was an unusual ability to throw back pints with reporters while keeping the secrets of powerful men. I found him to be a delightful, charismatic scoundrel.

Many colleagues were charmed by Lewis. But within a few months, his fury over the newsroom's coverage of accusations that he'd helped conceal or destroy evidence while managing a scandal at Murdoch's News International—accusations he has denied—had soured the dynamic. Equally concerning was that Lewis barely demonstrated any interest in his job. The *Post* lost $100 million in his first year—and an astonishing 60 million monthly visitors from November 2020 to November 2024. But Bezos wasn't paying much attention to Lewis or the newsroom; he regularly canceled meetings with top editors.

Bezos seemed more interested in the Opinion section. He never forbade the editorial board from writing what it wanted, and seldom voiced strong feelings about politicians or parties. But his interests and ideology were evolving, and as the owner, he hoped the editorial board would move in step. Bezos seemed to enjoy speaking with the section's editor, David Shipley, about creating a forum for pragmatic ideas and policy solutions. Wonky centrist stuff.

That hands-off approach changed with the spiking of the Harris endorsement 11 days before the 2024 election—abruptly ending a half-century-long tradition and provoking 250,000 subscription cancellations. Those sympathetic to Bezos say that the last-minute timing wasn't his fault. Lewis had told the editorial board that he would handle getting Bezos's approval. But as the election drew closer, it clearly had not been handled—or was not handle-able. "The timing of their refusing to endorse was too close to the

election," Barry Diller told me. "If the *Post* had been his only job, he would have done that much earlier."

Lewis, who stepped aside in February 2026, did not respond to requests for comment. He certainly deserves blame for some of the destruction. But the most consequential decisions were not his. It was not Lewis who withheld the endorsement. It was not Lewis who complained to Trump about the "terrible" businesspeople at the *Post* shortly after Trump's reelection, according to Maggie Haberman and Jonathan Swan's *Regime Change*. It was not Lewis who dined with the president on the very day he announced that the Opinion section would focus exclusively on "personal liberties and free markets" (a decision that prompted Shipley's resignation).

Bezos has framed the changes at the *Post* as a matter of necessity and opportunity, writing in an op-ed that he wanted to reposition the paper for Middle America. Journalism isn't a charity, and Bezos's own politics have clearly shifted. He is, after all, the owner.




A rally outside *The Washington Post*'s headquarters in February after the company announced layoffs (Kent Nishimura / Bloomberg / Getty)

But Bezos plainly appears to have made a Faustian bargain. Just as Blue Origin was getting its act together, a second Trump presidency dawned, with Bezos's chief antagonist, Elon Musk, in a position of extraordinary influence. Musk had spent $288 million to help elect Trump and other Republicans. He was a senior adviser to the president. Amazon had fought the first Trump administration for more than a year over a cloud-computing contract. The administration had been lobbied hard by Oracle, Amazon's cloud competitor, whose co-founder had reportedly given about $45 million to a nonprofit supporting Trump's reelection. Oracle had also produced a docket of baseless conspiracies about Amazon that found its way to the president's desk.

Marty Baron was the executive editor of the *Post* from 2013 to 2021, a gilded era that produced 11 Pulitzer Prizes and vital reporting on Edward Snowden, the Trump *Access Hollywood* tape, and the Robert Mueller investigation. "Everything I saw in my years there was that he truly believed what he was saying about democracy and the press," Baron told me. "But I don't think he thinks these other businesses could survive unless he finds a way to successfully navigate through the Trump era. And if the *Post* is the thing that has to pay the price, then, well, that'll have to be the thing that pays the price."

Donald Trump is not a simple transactional figure. He gets what he wants, but he also warps reality in the process. Countless executives have learned that successfully dealing with him requires both capitulation and an insistence that no capitulation has occurred. If Bezos and Trump did come to an arrangement, it would make Bezos a hypocrite twice: once for breaking his promise to *Post* readers, and once for pretending he hadn't.

Jeff Bezos also tends to get what he wants—and unlike Trump, he's willing to wait years for it. He's comfortable with being misunderstood. Which is another way of saying that there's more

than one way to look at a Faustian bargain: not in terms of what must be sacrificed, but in terms of what might one day be gained.

“NG-3, baby!” whooped a man in a Titusville, Florida, 7-Eleven in April, shortly before flashing me his admittedly glorious NASA-logo calf tattoo. People who live along Florida’s 72-mile Space Coast rarely end up there by accident. Some work in aerospace; the rest seem to wish they did. They buy condos and arrange their schedules for optimal viewing of the rockets rising from the Kennedy Space Center. As subcultures go, they’re somewhere between Deadheads and bird-watchers: obsessive, migratory, and willing to wait a very long time for the thing they came to see.

I was in town at the invitation of Blue Origin to witness the third launch of New Glenn—NG-3. This would be the first time Blue Origin reused a booster from a previous launch, a crucial step. The nonreusable upper part of NG-3 would be carrying a large telecom satellite for AST SpaceMobile.

Dave Limp was in from Washington State to watch the launch and schmooze the satellite guys. Limp is 60, and in his sensible jeans, glasses, and Blue Origin three-quarter zip, he looks like the most reasonable man in every room he enters. When he started the job, he’d wondered if a consumer-electronics guy was the right fit for a rocket company, but he’d come around to Bezos’s diagnosis—that Blue Origin needed more disciplined decision making, more manufacturing expertise, and more Bezos. “Jeff can be annoying at times, but he’s right a lot,” Limp told me. “And he was right on this.”

The standard that Limp is being held to has a name: Gwynne Shotwell. Limp is an admirer, and has arranged his duties accordingly. “My job is to have Jeff live in the future,” Limp said. “So if he has to hear about an HR issue or a financial issue or a schedule issue, I have not done my job.”

His other job is to get rockets up, fast. The Federal Communications Commission requires satellite operators such as AST to put a certain percentage of their constellations in space by specific dates, or they risk losing authorization for the satellites they failed to deploy. Amazon was supposed to deploy half of its 3,236 satellites by July 2026. The FCC granted a waiver in June after Amazon explained that it was producing satellites faster than any of its launch providers—including Blue Origin—could get them into space.

A year earlier, the New Shepard tourism rocket had carried a team of six women, including Lauren Sánchez and Katy Perry, into space. Now Limp put it on indefinite hiatus. All focus, he told me, was on the lunar lander and getting New Glenn rockets produced with assembly-line speed: “The ‘step by step’ component of our motto—let’s fast-walk it, you know?”

At 7:25 a.m. the next morning, NG-3 lifted off from Blue Origin’s launchpad at Cape Canaveral Space Force Station. It did not blast off like the rockets of old. Accelerometers and gyroscopes fed its position to the guidance system as computers continuously adjusted thrust and steering, making millions of pounds of rocket seem almost to levitate. When the rocket disappeared, it left behind a long, knobby cloud—a strangely beautiful albino Cheeto. Six minutes later, the booster landed a few hundred miles away in the Atlantic Ocean on the drone ship Jacklyn, named for Bezos’s late mother. Everyone went nuts.

I didn’t find out for a few hours that the mission had been a dud. One of NG-3’s engines had failed to produce enough thrust and dropped AST’s satellite in the wrong orbit, too low to be useful. AST had insurance, but the customer doesn’t care if you save money by reusing your booster; it cares that you get the job done. Blue Origin had not.

At 12:12 p.m., the day got a little worse: SpaceX announced that it had just landed its Falcon 9 booster for the 600th time.

A month later, a New Glenn rocket undergoing a static-fire test caused the largest explosion in the history of Cape Canaveral, badly damaging Blue Origin's only operational launchpad and temporarily grounding the program.

Only two people have the means and ambition to vertically integrate the galaxy, and one of them has the upper hand. In 2025, SpaceX launched 83 percent of the mass sent into orbit—about 10 times more than its nearest competitor, the Chinese government. Starlink's 11,000-plus satellites account for roughly two-thirds of all active spacecraft orbiting Earth.

Limp, at least, knows all of this. He acknowledged that SpaceX is "by far the leader." But, he said, "there's so much demand for space right now that if we get to the scale and the execution of SpaceX, the world will be a happy place. And that does not mean Gwynne and Elon have to fail."

The exact size of that demand is debatable. SpaceX and Blue Origin, along with a handful of smaller competitors, provide launch services to other companies and the federal government, but most of the demand comes from their own or affiliated satellite fleets. In finance, this is called captive demand, and it's generally regarded with suspicion. In commercial space, it's called vertical integration, and it's the whole point.

This is why the SpaceX prospectus reads like both a filing with the Securities and Exchange Commission and a transcript of an investment banker's weekend on mushrooms. "Our mission," it states, "is to build the systems and technologies necessary to make life multiplanetary, to understand the true nature of the universe, and to extend the light of consciousness to the stars." It then arrives at a number for a total addressable market that includes the light of

consciousness: $28.5 trillion. It must have been fun to sit in the room as that number got calculated.

Musk's mesmeric power over investors is well-known. Tesla earned just $3.8 billion in 2025 and is somehow one of the world's dozen most valuable companies. (Caterpillar, which makes backhoes, earned approximately $8.9 billion.) It's best to read the prospectus not as a ledger but as the blueprint for a future empire: the East India Company of space.

The business is a ladder that starts with rocket-launch capability. The next rung up is satellite arrays. This is a much more profitable business—Starlink really does pay for most everything at SpaceX—but it depends on launch capability. The third rung requires a leap of engineering faith: data centers in space. The fourth is the reason to build them—control over an off-world computing economy capable of training and running AI models at a scale that's hard to achieve on Earth. In January, SpaceX filed a proposal with the FCC to operate up to 1 million data-center satellites in orbit—describing the project, in the filing itself, as the "first step towards becoming a Kardashev II–level civilization." A Kardashev Type II civilization is one capable of harnessing the entire energy output of its star.

Does this sound crazy? If so, technology's biggest players are eager to break into the asylum. Space offers AI companies abundant solar energy available 24 hours a day, and freedom from the NIMBYism that makes earthbound data centers and power plants so contentious. "Should I make a rocket company?" OpenAI's CEO, Sam Altman, asked on a podcast in 2025. OpenAI subsequently tried, unsuccessfully, to take over Stoke Space, a reusable-rocket start-up founded by former Blue Origin employees. Alphabet's Google and the satellite operator Planet intend to launch two prototype satellites in early 2027 to test whether AI chips can operate effectively in orbit.

Google and OpenAI do not have their own ladders. Musk does, and he's already climbed the first two rungs; in August, he posted that SpaceX would put its first satellite data center in orbit by the end of next year. Bezos is in between—he has a ladder; it's just shorter and shakier. The question is how much the gap matters as the race moves upward, into new areas of engineering and imagination where no one—not even SpaceX—has a lead.

In late 2027, Blue Origin plans to deploy TeraWave, a constellation of 5,408 new satellites custom designed to provide data centers and governments with internet up to 6,000 times faster than Amazon's satellites. New Glenn is expected to place TeraWave into orbit.

John Couluris leads Blue Origin's lunar-permanence team, charged with creating the infrastructure for colonization. "Maybe seven years ago, people wouldn't have said, 'Well, we could do data centers on the moon,'" Couluris told me. Now he considers it complicated but more and more plausible. The challenges are real—chips fail, cosmic radiation is weird, and maintenance is essentially impossible. But if launch costs continue to drop, they'll offset the expense. Couluris said Blue Origin is already working on manufacturing solar cells directly from lunar soil. The chips would come from Earth; almost everything else could be made on-site.

The destination for all of this potential computing power has only recently become clear. In 2024, I heard rumors about Prometheus, a company whose plans were inscrutable even by the standards of AI start-ups. No one associated with Prometheus would confirm its existence. Given the history of Blue Origin, this should have been a tell.

What's now known is that Prometheus is trying to build something quite different from the generative-AI models that spit out text or code. The most complicated things that humans create—jet engines, drug molecules, semiconductors—live at the intersection of invention and engineering, where physical forces interact in

ways that are expensive to model and even more expensive to test. An engineer can sketch a thousand designs; each one still has to survive contact with physics. Prometheus is intended to compress that process—to create an artificial general engineer capable not merely of proposing designs, but, it seems, of simulating, testing, refining, and, eventually, helping manufacture them. The grandest possible outcome is a machine that makes machines.

There's an echo here for Bezos. Neal Stephenson and Blue Origin's other early employees spent years exploring engineering possibilities in slow motion while the competition raced ahead. An artificial general engineer could compress all of that painstaking discovery into rapid computation: a Neal Stephenson bot.

This could be useful to all humankind—and particularly useful to someone trying to build dexterous warehouse robots, cheaper rockets, and data centers on the moon. Whether any of this is possible, and on what timeline, is unknown. Large language models were jump-started by the availability (or theft) of trillions of words; there's less training data on the physical world. The models also have to understand multiple kinds of physics at once, account for uncertainty, and produce results trustworthy enough to bet hardware and human lives on. Those problems are very expensive to solve. At least for most people.

In November 2025, Prometheus's existence became public, along with the news that it had raised $6.2 billion, the largest chunk of which came from Bezos. He was also named co-CEO, his first operational role since Amazon. Prometheus has since hired 150 people, many from OpenAI and Google DeepMind. Dave told me that Bezos spends his days bouncing between Prometheus and Blue Origin. "But he multitasks very well. Well, he single-tasks in a multitask world very well."

Musk already has his own AI company, xAI, which he merged with SpaceX. His chatbot, Grok, has mostly distinguished itself through

creepiness and anti-Semitism, but Musk used $60 billion in stock from the IPO to buy Cursor, an AI-coding assistant that's one of the fastest-growing software companies. That leaves tens of billions more to spend on the most precious commodity in tech: margin for error.

It's not a coincidence that, a few weeks after the SpaceX IPO, Blue Origin said it had secured $10 billion in outside funding, the first non-Bezos money in the company's 26-year history. Limp called it a sign of confidence. It was also an acknowledgment of reality: Blue Origin is going to need more money. It has less margin, and more errors.



A SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket passes over Lower Manhattan in August. (Gary Hershorn / Getty)

SpaceX is winding down Falcon 9, the workhorse rocket that's served as the West's space-transportation system, in order to concentrate on Starship (as of this writing, the company was preparing for its 14th test flight—the first to attempt orbit). Other satellite companies have reported trouble buying Falcon launches beyond 2028. Starship will offer significantly more capacity—but SpaceX may use much of that capacity itself: Starlink and the orbital data centers it hopes to build are potentially far more lucrative than carrying other people's satellites. In other words, the

company that solved America's launch shortage may now be creating another one.

This is not just a business problem. It also matters to a sovereign nation that has recently discovered that one of its citizens possesses powers normally reserved for states. All of humanity may learn what it means to have its future built atop someone else's rocket.

In 2022, Ukraine asked Musk to extend Starlink coverage over Crimea so it could carry out military operations. Musk refused. General Mark Milley, then the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, and National Security Adviser Sullivan spoke with him about the decision. "And there wasn't much we could do about that, absent taking some very coercive measures," Sullivan told me—measures no one wants to take.

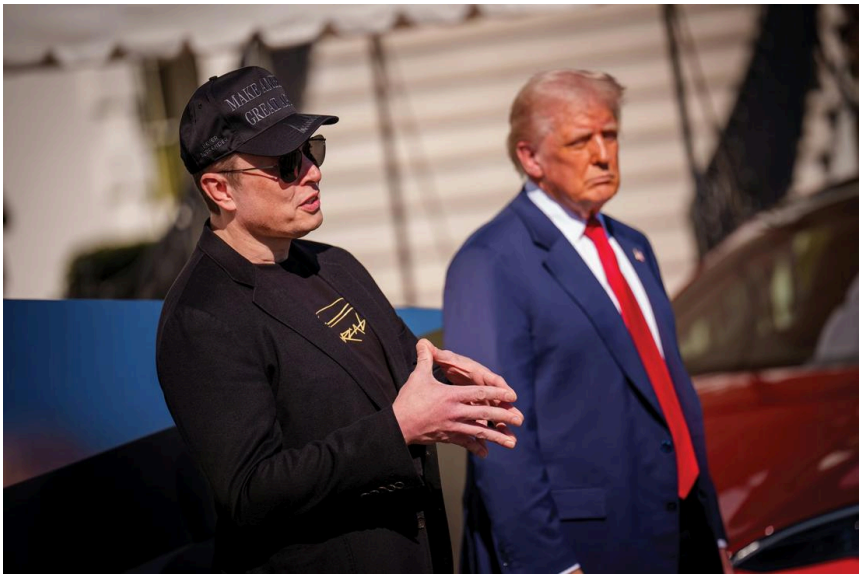
Three years later, during an X fight with Trump, Musk threatened to immediately decommission SpaceX's Dragon capsule, the only American vehicle capable of transporting astronauts to and from the International Space Station. Without it, NASA would have had to pay Russia $80 million a seat on Soyuz capsules. A few hours later, Musk backed down. "We absolutely need diversification on this," Sullivan said. "And what's challenging is that the most likely pathway to diversification lies through another mercurial billionaire."

That the republic finds itself needing Bezos's extraordinary concentration of private power to mitigate Musk's extraordinary concentration of private power is probably not what the Founders had in mind. I asked Senator Mark Kelly, a former astronaut, if he trusted either man completely. He replied, "Kind of a loaded question."

Kelly has met Bezos. His history with Musk dates back to at least 2012, when he joined SpaceX's human-spaceflight safety-advisory panel, consulting on the Dragon capsule that would eventually

make SpaceX indispensable to NASA. After Kelly, who serves on the Armed Services and Intelligence Committees, visited Ukraine in 2025, Musk called him a “traitor” on X. So it goes. But Kelly doesn’t begrudge SpaceX its dominance. “It’s not SpaceX’s fault, right?” Kelly said. “They got ahead. They do it well.” What he wants is for SpaceX to “continue to be a successful company because it is in our national-security interest that that’s the case. I also want to see Blue Origin be successful.”

The pragmatist’s position, shared by most of the national-security community, is that one company capable of getting you to space is better than none, and two is better than one. But even if Bezos is the less mercurial billionaire, Blue Origin is not yet a reliable substitute for SpaceX.



At the start of Trump’s second term, Elon Musk served as a senior adviser to the president and wielded extraordinary influence. (Andrew Harnik / Getty)

So the government can’t use Blue Origin as leverage. It can threaten to withhold contracts from SpaceX, but, as Trump discovered, Musk will respond by threatening to decommission the only American vehicle capable of reaching the space station. It can nationalize the companies, which would require a political

consensus that doesn't exist and a legal argument that hasn't been made. Kelly thinks campaign-finance reform would make it harder for the next Musk to buy his way into the center of government, or the next Bezos to buy his way back into its good graces. When I asked which is more likely to happen first—campaign-finance reform or data centers on the moon—Kelly laughed. "I hope it's campaign-finance reform."

The government is not negotiating from a position of strength, but Bezos and Musk have a shared vulnerability: Both say they would like to go to the moon—for their empires, for glory, and because their youthful love of space has never settled into something more rational. To put it in terms they and the president would all understand, the moon is leverage. If the people trying to bargain with Charles Foster Kane had known about Rosebud, they would have dangled a sled.

For all of the stated urgency of the 2016 Trump transition meeting, what's really happening with America's return to the moon is only just now coming into view. In February, Musk posted on X that SpaceX had shifted focus from Mars to building a "self-growing city on the Moon." The SpaceX prospectus has a section called "Establish the lunar economy," which includes a base supplied by a continuous flow of people and cargo, eventually capable of producing its own water, fuel, power, and manufactured goods. Moontown sounds great, but the engineering details are a kind of truth serum—revealing the distance between what Bezos and Musk say they want and where their priorities actually lie.

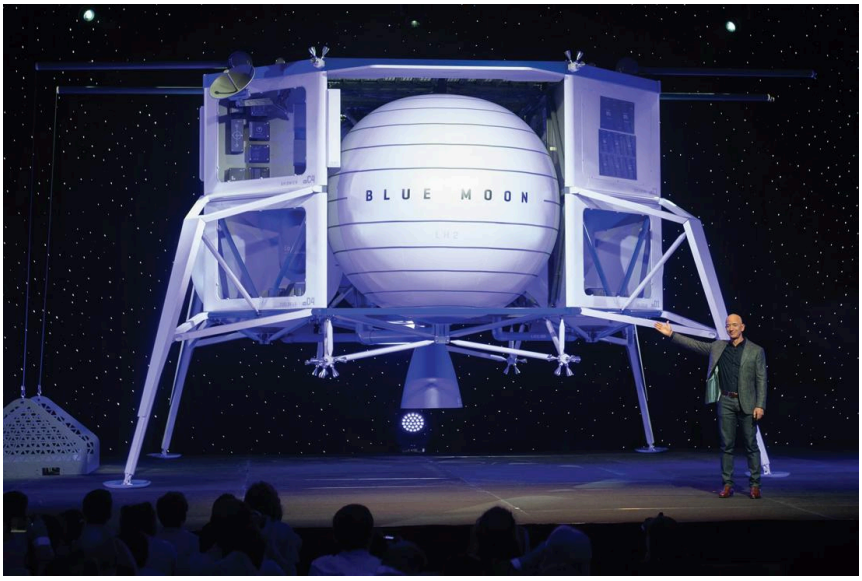
SpaceX's Starship cannot get to the moon without stopping for gas. The plan it sold NASA works roughly like this: SpaceX launches a Starship to serve as a fuel depot; then it launches a succession of tanker Starships to fill the depot; then it launches the lunar lander, which gasses up at the depot and departs for the moon. NASA's Office of Inspector General estimates that at least 15 Starship launches will be needed to deliver all the fuel. No spacecraft has

ever transferred ultracold methane and oxygen between vehicles in orbit.

In August, SpaceX committed $100 billion to build what Musk called “the biggest launch site on Earth” in Louisiana. This, along with its other facilities, should allow it, eventually, to launch multiple rockets a day. But even if SpaceX can get refueler rockets to the depot before the other rockets run out of gas, Doug Loverro, NASA’s former associate administrator for human exploration and operations, told me he’s skeptical of all the other things Starship has to prove: that it can reach orbit, keep astronauts alive, transfer fuel repeatedly in space, fly to the moon, land, and—crucially, if you’re an astronaut—take off again. His point is not that any single step is impossible. It’s the sheer number of steps that have to work in sequence. “Hurdle No. 1 is let’s get Starship to orbit,” Loverro said. “Which still hasn’t happened yet.”

Blue Origin’s route to the moon is complicated too: New Glenn first sends a transporter into low Earth orbit to be refueled. The lander, Blue Moon, launches separately, takes on fuel, and heads toward the moon, while the transporter climbs to a higher orbit for another fill. Near the moon, the two dock for one final transfer. Only then do the astronauts arrive and move into Blue Moon, which they use to descend to the surface and return to their spacecraft.

It’s an elaborate chain of rendezvous and refuelings, but the jobs are divided among purpose-built vehicles: New Glenn launches, the transporter carries fuel across deep space, and Blue Moon lands. SpaceX assigns nearly all of those jobs to variants of the same enormous Starship.




Jeff Bezos unveils Blue Moon, a lunar lander, in Washington, D.C., in 2019. (Saul Loeb / AFP / Getty)

Also, as NASA's Office of Inspector General has pointed out, Starship's lander is 171 feet tall—roughly the equivalent of a 14-story building—and its astronauts descend in an elevator that begins 115 feet up. There's no other way back into the vehicle if the elevator fails. Blue Moon is 52 feet, and its crew walks down a set of stairs that starts six feet off the ground.

If you're curious why, 60 years after Apollo, getting to the moon seems harder, part of the answer is that NASA has 60 years of pent-up expectations. The original astronauts flew in tin cans atop disposable rockets. A sustained presence on the moon will require more mass and more propellant.

Most people I spoke with have reached the same conclusion: On this, Blue Origin is ahead. It has completed thermal-vacuum testing on Blue Moon, and, as of August, its structure, propulsion, and avionics were fully assembled; it's already communicating with NASA's satellites and deep-space network. Even with the launchpad explosion, Blue Origin still plans to deliver an uncrewed test mission to the moon by early next year. That first flight will be

a chance to work out many of Blue Origin's hardest lunar-specific tasks on a single trip.

The crux of the difference is that Blue Origin—the smaller, slower company in need of a win—seems to have built a product to fit the brief, while Musk has built a giant rocket designed for his satellite business and his personal goal of deep-space travel to Mars. Making Starship work for the moon is like adapting a cargo ship to win a yacht race.

None of this guarantees that Blue Origin gets to the moon first. "I'm the first to say never count Elon out," Loverro told me. "He's a clever guy." It also doesn't really solve the mercurial-billionaire problem as much as shift it. But Loverro had a suggestion so simple and clever that it made me laugh out loud.

The Apollo missions also sprang from private industry, but NASA divided the work among contractors—Boeing, North American Aviation, IBM, and more. Different companies, different roles, forced into collaboration by NASA. Why not make Starship the refueling station for Blue Moon? SpaceX would have to reconfigure some of its designs, but "it only takes one Starship to fill up a Blue lander. It may take 10 or 15 Starships to fill up a Starship lander. If they work together, they could both get there sooner.

"We're individualistic in the United States," Loverro continued. "Every man for themselves. But that's not how we do great things. We do great things because we find the best of everything that we can bring to the table, and then we do it together. That's what NASA's job truly is—to organize that team. And they're failing to do so."

The person responsible for organizing that team is NASA's administrator, Jared Isaacman, a self-made billionaire who twice flew to space on SpaceX's Dragon capsule and performed the first

private spacewalk. His relationship with Musk complicated his confirmation. On his first day in the job, Isaacman said that whichever lander was ready first would get the mission. He declined an interview request for this story.

Isaacman may hold to his winner-take-all position. He may avoid angering two of America's most powerful men and hope their engineering successes or failures make the decision for him. But the Solomonic solution has a certain appeal: Force Musk and Bezos to work together, and test their willingness to share a win.

One small step toward reminding them that the nation is still king.

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# The Babies Left Behind in America

**The United States is deporting parents without their children, creating a whole new family-separation crisis.**

by Caitlin Dickerson

Mon, 28 Sep 2026



Estela Díaz picks up Eber, the 2-year-old son of a former co-worker, from day care.

Estela Díaz and 2-year-old Eber repeat their routine every morning: Around 8 a.m., he rustles her awake in the bed they share. She

picks him up, changes his diaper, and pulls out a fresh set of tiny clothes. While Estela dresses him, Eber coos, “Mama, mama.” She smiles and strokes his cheeks, trying to hide her sadness at his confusion. Estela is 50 and has three sons, but Eber is not one of them. She’s been caring for him because ICE deported his parents to Venezuela, despite his mother’s pleas to be reunited first.

Estela and her husband, Miguel, moved to Mobile, Alabama, 20 years ago to raise their own boys in a place that felt safe and had a slower rhythm than Las Vegas, where they’d met. Miguel works as a remodeling contractor. He spent years developing their four-acre property, building a wood shop, a chicken coop, and houses for two of their children (the third lives 15 minutes down the road). They bought peacocks as pets and planted bright perennial gardens, adorning them with stone fountains. By the driveway, they fly an American flag from an antique tractor. Over the years, their home evolved into a kind of retirement sanctuary—until this past winter, when it started to look like a day care.

A police officer pulled over Eber’s mother, Marlyn, last November and, without accusing her of an infraction, turned her over to ICE, despite her work permit and pending asylum application. Eber, who had just finished breastfeeding, and his 7-year-old brother, Isaac, had nowhere to go. Marlyn’s 23-year-old cousin took the boys briefly. Then two of Marlyn’s friends—both undocumented—agreed to take one child each. Eber was moved into a rusty trailer with no heat; the woman watching him put socks on his hands to keep him warm. He was sick, but she was too scared of ICE to take him to a doctor. Isaac’s caregiver worked nights. Sometimes he made it to school; sometimes he didn’t.

The boys needed a better home. Frantic phone calls among Marlyn’s friends and co-workers eventually led to Estela. They had all worked together at a plant nursery, and Estela was the only American citizen they knew. She agreed to take the boys and then return them to Marlyn, not knowing that doing the right thing

would go so wrong: that county officials would end up investigating her for trafficking; that her bank account would dwindle to almost nothing; that Eber would still be in her home, unable to remember his own mother, nearly a year after she was picked up.

“I’ve lost a lot of weight because it’s so stressful,” Estela told me, sitting in her living room. Eber was clinging to her, his face buried in her chest. “My family is like, ‘What have you done?’”

President Trump’s rush to deport as many immigrants as possible is creating a new family-separation crisis. Whereas his first administration took children from their parents at the border to deter illegal crossings, the second is separating families living in the United States as part of a purge. Like last time, Trump officials claim that this is untrue. But stories like Eber’s are not hard to find, as I learned this year while reporting on immigration enforcement in Alabama, California, Illinois, Missouri, and Texas.

From the September 2022 issue: Caitlin Dickerson on the secret history of family separation

As of April, the Brookings Institution put the total number of affected children at about 205,000—71 percent of whom are U.S. citizens. Most of those cases involve the loss of one parent, a devastating blow to families. But the Brookings researchers believe that more than 35,000 of the cases are like Eber’s, in which a child has been left with no parent at all.

Since the analysis was published, the pace of ICE arrests has increased. In July, the agency arrested a record 49,000 people, a majority of whom have no criminal record, according to a *New York Times* review of data obtained by the Deportation Data Project. Many of the people ICE is targeting entered the United States legally, through parole programs or by requesting asylum, and were in the process of working toward permanent legal

immigration status. (A Department of Homeland Security spokesperson told me the Deportation Data Project's numbers are "inaccurate" but did not correct them, adding that a pending application for legal status does not shield immigrants from arrest.)

In recent years, ICE policy required officers to either reunite detained parents with their children before deportation or confirm that the children had an official caregiver in their parents' absence. But in July 2025, DHS revised the policy, sprinkling it with caveats, such as "when operationally feasible," that appear to allow officers to prioritize the speed and volume of deportations over everything else—including the children whom deportees leave behind.



Estela talks with Eber's mother, Marlyn, who was deported to Venezuela in February, and the social worker Shaina Simenas on a video call. (Meridith Kohut for *The Atlantic*)

The result is tens of thousands of children being shuffled among the houses of anxious temporary caregivers. It can take months to procure the passports, visas, and other permissions necessary to transport children to their parents, many of whom have been deported to countries whose governments can't help, or won't. This past spring, the United Nations' International Organization for

Migration reunified 12 children with their deported families using funding from the U.S. State Department, according to a UN official, who added that the organization has received requests to help other children, but they lack the proper paperwork.

Some children end up with foster families after caregivers burn out, and some have landed in the homes of abusive relatives or acquaintances. In January, 2-year-old Orlin Hernandez Reyes was left with his aunt's ex-partner, who was known to be dangerous, when ICE detained his mother. She begged deportation officers to reunite her with Orlin before she was deported to Honduras, but that didn't happen. Soon after, Orlin's body was found with broken bones and signs of sexual abuse, and his caregiver was charged with murder. (He has pleaded not guilty.) Then–ICE Director Todd Lyons blamed his mother, saying that she "chose to leave her son here with a violent murderer who took his life."

Even children like Eber, who land in a safe place, are likely to experience long-term psychological harm from separation. "To have such a huge number of children forced into a traumatic situation because of some policy—it's really kind of unimaginable," Wendy Smith, a retired associate dean at the University of Southern California's school of social work and a co-founder of the nonprofit National Foster Youth Institute, told me. We are "creating a whole class of children who are going to grow up with all sorts of problems." (The DHS spokesperson said that the agency "does not separate families or deport U.S. citizens" and that, absent indications of abuse or neglect, parents "can choose to take their children with them.")

There are key differences between the family separations happening now and those of the first Trump administration. In 2017 and 2018, career bureaucrats worked from within the government to try to prevent separations, alert the press when they happened, and reunite families under court orders that high-level DHS officials were trying to defy. But many civil servants deemed

insufficiently loyal to Trump were fired en masse during the early months of his second term. Since then, the White House has sent a clear message that pushing back on mass deportation will cost you your job.

Also different: The separations of the first Trump administration were the result of a distinct policy (“Zero Tolerance”) that, once brought to light, could be challenged in federal court. Today, family separations appear to be incidental—the consequence of a ruthless effort to hit a quota, no matter the cost. And this time, people with firsthand knowledge of separations are keeping quiet. Many temporary caregivers are undocumented themselves or have relatives who are; they worry that drawing attention would put their own families at risk. Government and nonprofit workers are also scared to speak up. The White House has attacked organizations that oppose its goals by cutting funding, launching dubious criminal investigations, and issuing retaliatory executive orders.

“In a lot of jurisdictions, people don’t want to write anything down,” Maria Cancian, a Georgetown University economist who co-authored the Brookings study, told me. She and her colleagues spoke with caseworkers in more than half a dozen states who had assisted separated families; they agreed to communicate only because she did not plan to disclose their identities or locations in her report. “Why would you volunteer any information that makes you more of a target?” said Cancian, a former Obama appointee in the Department of Health and Human Services who helped oversee children in immigration custody.

Alabama, where Estela lives, has an estimated 70,000 undocumented immigrants. Many are concentrated near Mobile, where they work at plant nurseries, shipyards, construction sites, and fish-packing plants. On a visit there over the summer, I was barraged with stories of parents swept up in ICE raids, leaving children marooned with relatives or neighbors who were unprepared to care for them. These arrests were a constant topic of

discussion in churches, at dinner tables, during school drop-offs. Everywhere I went, cellphones buzzed with information about immigration checkpoints and intersections where local police seemed to be pulling over anyone who was visibly Latino.



Estela’s husband, Miguel, plays with Eber outside their home in Mobile, Alabama. (Meridith Kohut for *The Atlantic*)

A woman named Josefa told me that she and her relatives were taking turns caring for their nieces and nephews—ages 9, 7, and 1—because they could afford only a few days of diapers and extra food at a time. A 15-year-old girl was living alone in a squalid trailer because her father had been detained, and his last paycheck was running out. When Miguel, Estela’s husband, got home from work one evening, I asked if he would call around to co-workers and friends to see if they knew of any other displaced children. “Oh yeah,” the first man he called said. “My wife and I also have two little girls.”

The police officer did not tell Marlyn why he’d pulled her over on a grocery run outside Mobile—but he asked if she was in the United States illegally. She pulled out her phone to show him that she’d attended all her ICE check-ins, and that her asylum case was scheduled to be heard in June.

“The immigration judge wants to talk to you,” the officer said, as Marlyn recalled when I first spoke with her, earlier this summer.

“I don’t understand,” she replied. “I haven’t done anything wrong.”

“Don’t worry, they’re not going to deport you,” the officer said.

*Of course they are*, she thought.

Marlyn says she asked the officer if they could pick up her children because they were at home with a roommate who wasn’t prepared to care for them indefinitely. He refused. She spent about an hour in the Mobile County Metro Jail, followed by 10 days in an ICE detention center in Mississippi. Then she was transferred to the South Louisiana ICE Processing Center, a 1,000-bed facility 90 miles west of Baton Rouge.

Marlyn’s family had arrived at the southern border in May 2023, as Venezuela devolved into chaos under Nicolás Maduro’s regime. A friend had told them that there was work for new immigrants in Mobile. They rented a house and found jobs—Marlyn at the nursery and her husband, Jesus, at Walmart. In April 2024, Jesus got into an altercation with a co-worker, was charged with a misdemeanor for reckless endangerment, and was deported to Venezuela. With two young children to support, Marlyn leaned on other immigrant families for help. She felt adrift but was getting by, until five months later, when she was pulled over on the grocery run.

At the facility in Louisiana, she spoke with an immigration lawyer who told her that she had virtually no chance of getting out on bail under the Trump administration’s policies. The lawyer said she could spend up to two years detained while she waited for a decision in her case, which she was likely to lose anyway.

Marlyn had heard that people who agreed to be deported could request to be reunited with their children beforehand, so she decided to give up her asylum case. She started sending ICE officials three messages a day—the maximum allowed—asking to be deported with Eber and Isaac.

“I told them, ‘I have my two children. One is a little baby who was born here. I have no one to take care of them. They’re going to be left alone,’ ” she recalled, adding: “They just kept giving the same response—that they were going to work on it. But they never did anything.” (DHS did not comment on individual cases in this story.)

In detention, Marlyn worried about Isaac and Eber constantly. Eber was weak and small for his age; he’d been born with a cyst in his lung that still needed to be surgically removed. She would fear the worst anytime Estela didn’t answer the phone. “It’s agonizing not knowing about your children,” Marlyn said. She befriended other mothers in detention. Some had been there for many months. She saw them faint and have panic attacks. One told Marlyn she had been arrested while taking her 10-day-old baby to the doctor.

Early one morning in February, three months into her detention, a staff member woke Marlyn and said she was being deported. Her time had run out. She had to board a plane back to Venezuela, and leave her kids behind.

Trump’s immigration crackdown has sent countless families into crisis. Sharon Balmer Cartagena, a family lawyer in Los Angeles, has had to deliver bad news to parents over and over, with the help of her colleagues at Public Counsel, the largest pro bono law firm in the country. They told one mother, who’d tried to create an emergency plan in case she was detained, that she’d filed the wrong paperwork in court and accidentally given up her parental rights. They told another mother from Mexico, whose ex-wife had cut off contact as soon as she was deported, that the best she could hope

for was one or two weeks of court-ordered visitations a year. And they told a mother from Haiti—who was so scared of being deported that she preemptively moved to Mexico—that she may never see her child again; the estranged father had agreed to care for their 3-year-old temporarily, but then blocked the mother's phone number as soon as she arrived in Mexico. "We had to explain to her, 'There's nothing we can do. You have no viable pathway to regain any kind of contact with your child,'" Cartagena told me. "It was horrific."

From the April 2026 issue: Caitlin Dickerson on how the Cruz family decided to self-deport

These cases fall into a gray area between immigration law and family law. This means that many of the families ICE is separating will need not one but two lawyers to try to get their children back—and there isn't enough legal help to go around. Cartagena has tried to recruit more family lawyers to help with immigration cases, without much success. "I'm trying to be like, 'Everybody, there's a family-law emergency here!'" she said. "Everyone's busy."



Attorney Sharon Balmer Cartagena in her home office in L.A. (Meridith Kohut for *The Atlantic*)

Cartagena grew up in Reading, Pennsylvania, one of the poorest cities in America, and saw how much her classmates were traumatized when child-welfare agencies broke up their families—often because the adults were too poor to provide for their children, not because they were unfit parents. She went to law school hoping to help children in foster care. Her career has tracked a period of growing consensus that this kind of family separation often does more harm than good; foster-care systems around the country have

been shrinking and state agencies have been directed to keep children in their home whenever possible. But under the first and second Trump administrations, separations have become more common for parents who are detained by immigration authorities.

Cartagena first discovered how complicated these separations were in 2018, when she became a directing attorney at Public Counsel. Immigration lawyers started contacting her, asking for help with clients who had been separated from their children under the Zero Tolerance policy. The parents had been allowed to return to the United States under a federal-court settlement, but enough time had passed that some children had been deemed wards of the state, while others had new legal guardians. Family-court judges were blocking their reunifications. Cartagena explained that family courts exist to protect children whose parents have been accused of abuse or neglect; the system is not set up to deal with parents who face none of these allegations but lose custody because they have been deported. She helped one mother regain custody of her teenage daughter, but the process took more than a year. Others never had their parental rights restored.

When I first spoke with Cartagena this year, she was working with a mother named Magdalena Callejas, who had full custody of her 4- and 6-year-old children in March 2024, when she was arrested at a Border Patrol checkpoint in Texas. Magdalena had a pending visa application. Her ex-partner was undocumented, with multiple DUIs; Magdalena had a restraining order against him for abusing her and her son from a previous relationship. But after ICE detained her, he took the 4- and 6-year-old back. She was powerless to stop it.

Magdalena says she asked ICE officials to reunite her with her children but was told the agency “did not do that.” She agreed to leave the country voluntarily, hoping to get her children back as soon as she arrived in El Salvador. In the meantime, her ex filed for custody. An immigration lawyer who met Magdalena in detention

contacted Cartagena, who explained that because Magdalena was unavailable to care for the children, the father was within his rights. In court, Magdalena's ex argued that he was a changed man, and that unsafe conditions in El Salvador outweighed his criminal past. The trial dragged on for months. The judge ordered the children into the custody of a neutral caregiver; when she was no longer willing to help, the judge sent the children to another home. On video calls during the father's court-ordered visits, Magdalena's children used a shorthand to tell her that he was still drinking: "Dad went to get some juice."

Cartagena shared all of this with the court but still didn't know how the judge was going to rule. Most family-court judges aren't familiar with immigration law, or accustomed to granting custody to a parent in another country. The longer a separation lasts, the harder it is to reverse; Cartagena said that family-court judges often defer to the status quo rather than disrupt a child's living arrangements a second time—even if it means keeping them from their biological parent, or a parent who is more fit to care for them. Despite Magdalena's ex's history of abuse, Cartagena worried that she could still end up permanently separated from her children. "If she doesn't win," Cartagena said, "what do I tell everyone else?"

A judge eventually ordered that Magdalena's children be returned to her in El Salvador after a 30-day legal stay to allow her ex-husband to appeal. He had stopped submitting weekly alcohol tests, which Cartagena believes may have swayed the judge. But that same day, the children's caregiver said she was fed up. She was going to drop them off at a police station if no one retrieved them. So even though the judge renewed Magdalena's five-year restraining order against her ex, he also ordered the father to pick up and care for the children until Cartagena could raise money and find a volunteer to transport them to El Salvador. There was nowhere else for the children to go but back to their father.

Cartagena has a tattoo on her wrist of a mama bear and two cubs—one for each of her children, who are 11 and 14. “I couldn’t imagine if I couldn’t see my kids or I didn’t know where they were,” she said. Sometimes the best advice she can offer detained parents is to get their children out of the United States as quickly as possible, before anyone can intervene. She’s helped procure travel documents and recruit volunteers to shuttle children across borders to their deported parents, including an 18-month-old and a 3-year-old who were sent to Peru in May. She also ghostwrites emails to ICE on behalf of immigration lawyers who want to pressure the agency to reunify families before a parent is deported. Since Trump took office a second time, she has started waking up to answer emails at 5 a.m. instead of 6. She works every weekend. And she began raising money so that Public Counsel can start a five-person division focused on immigrant-family separations. “We’re all doing this on top of our regular work,” Cartagena said. (She recently became the executive director of LevittQuinn, another family-law legal-aid organization in L.A., but will continue partnering with Public Counsel in her work on immigrant-family separations.)

She and her colleagues have held dozens of trainings across Los Angeles for immigrant parents. I attended one at an elementary school in Boyle Heights, an immigrant enclave and a hot spot for ICE raids. A dozen people sat in plastic chairs, their eyes darting to the door each time someone entered. One of Cartagena’s colleagues told the group to be careful about paperwork; well-meaning immigration lawyers had been giving clients a “temporary guardianship” form, which isn’t valid in some states. She urged the parents to arrange a caregiver, a backup caregiver, and a backup for the backup. People burn out or give up, and if there is no plan, the children are left in limbo.

A mother raised her hand. “The only people I know are like me,” she said. “They’re also undocumented.” Another said: “I don’t have anyone. What do I do?”

I found a family with no backup plan in the spring, when I went to Honduras to interview deportees as they arrived by the planeful from ICE detention centers. A father named Edwin said that after three years of meticulously following the government's requests to further his family's asylum case, his wife, Sarah, was thinking about going into hiding; she didn't want to be picked up by ICE and have to leave her children alone.

Read: A new kind of family-separation crisis

When I went to visit Sarah in May, in a Dallas suburb, her 4-year-old son, Johnny, answered the door and asked me: "Do you know when my dad is coming home?"

Before I could answer, Johnny continued: "Do you know what happened to him?" He repeated versions of these questions over the two days of my visit. "Do you know where my dad is? Do you know if he's okay?"

When the questions would start, Johnny's 12-year-old sister, Katie, tried to distract him with coloring books and screens. Recently, he'd had an hours-long meltdown when Sarah tried to donate some of Edwin's work clothes that were crowding the closet. Every afternoon he sits at the front window waiting for his dad's truck to pull up outside.

While reporting this story, I talked with other families with credible asylum cases who were considering going underground to avoid being separated from their children, knowing that it would likely sabotage their chances of ever gaining legal status. This is the bracing irony of Trump's deportation campaign: Its goal is to crack down on lawbreaking, but its implementation is *encouraging* it. Immigrants who have complied with the law are being targeted, and they are choosing to hide, despite the fear and stress, because the alternatives are worse: abandoning their children, or being deported with them to dangerous places.

Sarah and Edwin have been running from MS-13 since 2013, when Sarah witnessed a murder in Honduras. Gang members wrongly assumed that she had testified against the killer and started threatening her. In 2022, they showed up at a relative's house and killed a young woman, likely mistaking her for Sarah. She and Edwin decided it was time to go. They requested asylum and were admitted across the border during the Biden administration and moved to the Dallas suburbs. Edwin started working in construction and Sarah worked nights as a janitor. They rarely saw each other, but their schedules ensured that one of them was always home with the kids. (I'm using pseudonyms for this family because of ongoing threats.)

In January, the four of them went to an ICE office for a routine check-in. Edwin was detained without explanation. Sarah and the kids were distraught, and hoped it was a mistake. She planned to sell their cars to cover the cost of Edwin's bond, but then he was transferred from a detention center in Texas to one in Mississippi. There, he checked the agency's online portal for detainees and saw that he was being deported for allegedly skipping a court appointment that he had not been given the chance to attend. (The DHS spokesperson said the agency affords immigrants due process.)

"If we hadn't gone to the check-in, my husband would be here," Sarah told me. "It would have been better if we did things the wrong way." Without Edwin, Sarah felt forced to take a series of risks. She didn't have a license but started driving herself to work, because she was now solely responsible for paying the bills. She skipped her next check-in with ICE and, knowing that officers might come looking for her, moved apartments without telling the government. She started leaving Katie in charge of her younger brother while she was at work. "My daughter's teacher said I shouldn't tell anyone, because they could be taken away from me," Sarah said.

Without child care, Sarah installed cameras in the apartment and watched the kids on her phone, in between cleaning toilets and vacuuming. Katie would fall asleep as soon as she left for work. Johnny, who was used to sleeping in his father's arms, would pace the house every night. One time, Sarah saw him jamming an air freshener into an electrical outlet, which started to spark and smoke. Katie slept through the sound of her mother's phone calls.



Johnny and Katie settle down for the night as their father, whose face has been blurred to protect his identity, watches via video call from Honduras. (Meridith Kohut for *The Atlantic*)

Sarah changed her schedule to work one overnight shift during the week and double shifts on Saturdays and Sundays. Edwin started watching the children on video calls from Honduras while she was gone. On the first evening that I visited, he called while she was making dinner. "Have you eaten, my love?" she asked him.

"Not yet. I'm still working," he said. Then he pointed the phone at a young man crouched on a hillside just outside the house, looking over the village below. "They're here watching."

"Put it down! Put it down!" Sarah told him. "Don't let him see you."

MS-13 patrols their community, setting curfews and extorting people. Sarah and Edwin weren't sure if the gang had realized that he was back. They were looking for a place to hide if Sarah ends up being deported, but nowhere in Central America seemed safe.

Sarah scarfed down some shrimp pasta. Katie cut Johnny's food and tried to keep him in his chair. "She's become my right hand," Sarah told me of her 12-year-old. She looked at the clock and determined that she had time for a quick nap. She went into the bedroom and set a timer on her phone for 27 minutes. Katie started doing the dishes. She packed some leftover pasta into a Tupperware container for her mom and placed it in Sarah's backpack with two bottles of water and a ziplock bag of cookies.

Sarah sprang up when her alarm went off. Her eyes were red and wet. She threw on her uniform—khakis and a polo shirt—and brushed her hair back into a ponytail. She called the kids into the bedroom and told them to put their pajamas on while she did her makeup. They climbed into bed and Katie dialed Edwin, then propped her phone up against a lamp so that he could watch them after they fell asleep. A minute later, Johnny was out of bed, pacing. When Sarah finished getting ready, she gathered him in her arms and placed him next to his sister. She looked into the camera at Edwin and said, "Okay, you're in charge now."

Marlyn has been living a version of Sarah's nightmare since she arrived back in Venezuela in February, with video calls as the only portal to her children. She and Jesus moved back into their family home in Guanare, a small city about six hours by car from Caracas. Jesus struggled to find work and Marlyn spent most of her days trying to figure out how to reunite with her sons.

Back in Mobile, Eber demanded to be held constantly, screaming every time Estela put him down. Isaac would hyperventilate and hide anytime someone mentioned ICE. He started acting out in school. Estela was called in for a meeting with his teachers, during

which she explained that she was trying to figure out how to get the boys back to Marlyn. This only seemed to make things worse. A county social worker showed up at her house unannounced, asking questions: *Where were the boys sleeping? What did they eat? Did they have clean clothes?* A few days later, the social worker called and threatened to take the boys from her. “You don’t know what you’re getting yourself into,” the social worker said, according to Estela. “If you don’t have custody and their parents aren’t here, the state has the right to take them.”

“I just wanted to do something good,” Estela told her, “and everyone is making it seem like I’m doing something wrong.”

She called Marlyn in a panic. After her own experience in detention, Marlyn was terrified of her children ending up in government custody. Estela tried to reassure Marlyn that she wouldn’t let anyone take the boys. But she was also scared that she might not be able to stop it from happening. Tension was building between the two women. Estela despaired about giving up her life to take care of Eber and Isaac. All of her time, and a lot of her money, was going toward the boys’ needs: clothes, school supplies, food, medication. Marlyn, who had no way to repay her, was grateful for the help and embarrassed by how much she needed it. She also worried that her children were becoming too attached to Estela. “She was scared I would keep her kids,” Estela told me. “I said, ‘No, I would never do that, because I’m also a mom.’” But she knew that sending the boys to Venezuela could traumatize them all over again. She put Eber in day care so they wouldn’t grow too close.

Eber couldn’t travel until he’d had lung surgery; his doctors said the cyst would become cancerous if it wasn’t removed, and getting the procedure in Venezuela would be nearly impossible. And no airline would be willing to fly Isaac out of the country without a legal guardian or passport.

Estela made dozens of calls to lawyers and nonprofit groups. She contacted ICE offices in Georgia and Alabama but received no response. Finally she reached an official in Chicago who said that if she turned Isaac over to the government, he could be deported back to Venezuela within a few weeks. It seemed like the only option.

Estela asked Isaac's father to explain the plan to his son over a video call. Jesus told Isaac that he was going to a shelter with other children who were waiting to be returned to their parents. "You are going to be okay," he said. "Nothing bad is going to happen to you." Marlyn and Estela repeated the reassurances until Isaac was willing to go.

In late April, Estela loaded a backpack with clothes and snacks. The next morning, she put a piece of paper with phone numbers into Isaac's shirt pocket and told him not to lose it. She drove him two and a half hours to the closest ICE field office, in southern Louisiana. They said they loved each other. A couple of hours later, she got a text from ICE saying that Isaac was on a plane to a foster home in Texas, where the 7-year-old would wait until he could go before an immigration judge and formally request "voluntary departure" to Venezuela.



Estela greets Miguel as he arrives home from work. Caring for Eber has drained their bank account. (Meridith Kohut for *The Atlantic*)

Estela returned to Mobile, and to Eber's more complicated situation. He needed surgery, and his travel would be harder to arrange than Isaac's. He was a U.S. citizen, so he couldn't enter Venezuela without a visa—which requires a parent's permission and usually their presence. Meanwhile, most construction work around Mobile was on hold because workers were too scared to leave their houses. Miguel's business was suffering, but Estela couldn't help, because she had no time to work.

And soon after she began to look into travel documents for Eber, the police started showing up at her house.

The sheriff's deputy at the door said he was looking for Isaac. Estela started to explain the situation all over again, but her heart was racing. She worried that the officer didn't understand or believe her, so she called Shaina Simenas, a social worker at the Young Center for Immigrant Children's Rights. "Okay, put him on the phone," Simenas said. She told the officer that Isaac was in federal custody and that ICE had deported both of his parents. He seemed satisfied, but officers returned to Estela's house twice, until finally Simenas persuaded the department to close its investigation.

The Young Center normally advocates for unaccompanied children in their immigration proceedings, but when family separations began to accelerate after Trump took office for the second time, it assigned a team of six to focus on them. Since then, they've worked on more than 150 cases and have a growing waitlist. "It's a drop in the bucket compared to the need," Kelly Kribs, one of the team's co-directors, told me.

Even without advertising this work, the Young Center has been overwhelmed. Some children and detained parents have found

them by word of mouth. “We got a call from a 17-year-old boy a few weeks ago who was looking for help because his mom was his only caregiver, and he’s couch surfing in upstate New York,” Kribs said. “I think he Googled us.”

Kribs and her colleagues have tried to advocate for a number of women who were still breastfeeding when they were detained, despite an ICE policy against such detainments outside “exceptional circumstances.” One mother from St. Louis who had no criminal history was detained at three months postpartum. ICE ignored the Young Center’s request to release her under the policy. It took days for Simenas and a colleague to set up an account on the detainee tablet system, so she could message her family. “She went weeks without even seeing her infant because of how nonfunctional the system is for these families,” Simenas told me.

The Young Center has also tried to support temporary caregivers who are so overwhelmed that the children are unsafe. Kribs told me about a man in Florida who’d had to quit his job to care for five children, including a six-month-old, after their mothers—the man’s girlfriend and her sister—were detained. He had no income to pay for food and diapers. “He was father to none of these children,” Kribs said. One Illinois woman taking care of a 5-year-old boy whose father had been deported to Mexico was so financially strapped that she became homeless; she sent the child to sleep at a friend’s apartment while she lived in her car. Kribs eventually persuaded ICE to transport the boy back to his father. But first she had to send the caregiver $20 in gas money so the boy could be handed off.

On rare occasions, Kribs and her colleagues have transported children themselves, as in the case of a 13-month-old girl they ferried back to Mexico last year. Kribs said the reunion was bittersweet: The baby’s mother was waiting at the airport with balloons and a giant stuffed animal. But the little girl, who had

spent more than half her life separated from her mother, didn't seem to recognize her.

Now that ICE is almost solely dedicated to maximizing deportations, Kribs said, few people are left at the agency who will listen to their concerns. When possible, the Young Center tries to work with contractors to encourage ICE to comply with the policy on reunifying parents and children, or sorting out custody before deporting them. But not every detention center has enough staff to handle those requests, and some are busier than others. Kribs said that trying to appeal to deportation officers, who are under the most pressure to hit the president's numerical goals, is especially challenging. One officer admitted to her that he thought it was "just so much easier when they leave their kids here," she recalled. "Like it's a logistical headache for them to try not to separate families." (DHS did not comment on this claim.)

Separated parents have told me their pain is all-consuming. Before she was deported, a mother named Lucía called me from the South Louisiana ICE Processing Center, crying about not having seen her 14-month-old and 3-year-old in three months. She said it was excruciating not being able to explain to them why she was gone. "They're babies," she said. "They don't understand." Lucía said that most of the women around her were in similar situations. Some had a spouse who was with their children, but other kids were staying with extended relatives or acquaintances. "In this room where I am," she said, "there are 56 of us, and the majority are moms."

After just over a month in federal custody in Texas, Isaac landed at the airport in La Guaira, Venezuela, in May. When Eber had his surgery, also in the spring, Estela spent three days and nights in a chair next to his hospital bed. She sent pictures to Marlyn and Jesus to keep them updated. Marlyn said very little in response. Not being able to be with Eber had left her speechless. "Thank you, Estela," Jesus replied in one message. "I don't know how, but one

day I’m going to repay you for everything you’ve done for my son.”

Estela promised Marlyn that she wouldn’t hand off Eber to another caretaker, and that she’d get him back to Venezuela. But she’s exhausted. She feels like she’s neglecting her sons and her husband. Recently their bank account was down to $27. She used to go to church four times a week, but now manages just one. In the pews, she asks God to allow Eber to return to his family, and for the patience to keep caring for him in the meantime. “This baby needs to be with his mother,” she said.



After a year of separation, Eber seems to no longer remember Marlyn and calls Estela “Mama.” Estela has been trying to arrange Eber’s transfer to Venezuela all year. (Meridith Kohut for *The Atlantic*)

During a video call with Marlyn in August, he sat on a couch next to Estela, picking Lucky Charms out of a bowl. For 10 long minutes, Estela cajoled him to say hello or blow his mom a kiss. He only glanced at the camera, and didn’t seem to recognize Marlyn’s face or voice.

When I speak with Marlyn by phone now, her speech is slow and soft, almost zombie-like. She says she can’t sleep. Venezuelan officials said that they would add her name to a list of parents who need their children back from the U.S., but they have not given her a timeline for Eber’s return. She calls them every day, but they tell her to keep waiting. She stays in touch with mothers she met in detention, and they update one another on trying to get their children back. So far, Isaac is the only success story among them. Meanwhile, Marlyn didn’t see Eber’s first steps or hear his first words. He was so fragile the last time they were together. Now he’s much bigger, with a mischievous smile that she’s never seen in person. He launches himself into bear hugs that she’s never felt. Even if he makes it to Venezuela, they’ll never regain the time they lost. “I’ve missed everything,” she said.

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*This article originally misstated Estela Díaz’s surname. The article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline “The Babies Left Behind in America.”*

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/trump-ice-family-separation/688695/

# The Baltic States Prepare for War

**Lithuania, Latvia, and Estonia are readying themselves to fend off a Russian attack—with the help of the United States, or without it. **

by Isaac Stanley-Becker

Thu, 01 Oct 2026



Civilian members of the Lithuanian Riflemen’s Union, a volunteer militia, practice a medical evacuation during military exercises near Kyviškės, Lithuania.

One evening this summer, in the village of Bezdonys, in eastern Lithuania, I watched as a platoon of riflemen arrived at a train station occupied by enemy forces. Some of the Lithuanians let out a burst of gunfire from across the tracks, pinning the adversary in place as the rest of the unit advanced on the station. As the firefight intensified, wounded riflemen were evacuated to makeshift medical tents. An enemy soldier lay slumped against the station’s yellow clapboard siding.

Military exercises are elaborate acts of make-believe. I was observing this one to understand how a large-scale attack on the

most vulnerable part of the NATO alliance might play out—and to see how the Baltic states of Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania think about their own defense. The raid in Bezdonys was part of a nationwide simulation and involved the Lithuanian Riflemen's Union, a state-supported militia group that traces its history to the end of World War I. The Lithuanians I met wore camouflage fatigues and had no trouble accepting the scenario behind the exercise: that the enemy—Russia—had invaded their country, and that defensive forces had retreated to a city in the north. In their civilian lives, the riflemen are teachers and sales managers, economists and medical students. Now, suddenly, they were responsible for ambushing Russian outposts, killing enemy soldiers, and transmitting intelligence to the army.

"The enemy has to know," General Raimundas Vaikšnoras told me, "that if they step one foot in our territory, we will strike back." Vaikšnoras is Lithuania's defense chief, and his distrust of Russia, a former occupying power, is not a notional concern. Ever since Russia's invasions of other post-Soviet nations—Georgia in 2008; Ukraine in 2014 and 2022—conflict with Moscow has been front of mind for the people of the Baltic states. The three countries are small—Lithuania, the largest, is about the size of West Virginia—and grouped, one atop the other, on the shores of the Baltic Sea. They are also linked geopolitically by their common experience on Russia's western borderlands, one of subjugation and dispossession. The Baltic states escaped some of that past after the fall of communism and the breakup of the Soviet Union, when they regained their sovereignty. And they took measures to solidify that status when they joined NATO, in 2004, attaching themselves to the American-led security order.

They have much to lose from what looks to be the unraveling of that order. Donald Trump has mused repeatedly about taking the United States out of NATO. On the campaign trail in 2024, he encouraged the Russians to do "whatever the hell they want" to NATO members delinquent in their defense spending. This year, he

threatened to invade Greenland, a self-governing territory of Denmark, an alliance member. When European partners declined to join his war of choice against Iran, he disparaged NATO as a "paper tiger."

Read: Europe without America

Even a small incursion by Russia into the Baltics could be catastrophic if NATO did not adequately respond, thereby breaking the promise of collective defense enshrined in Article 5 of the founding treaty—an attack on one is an attack on all. Over breakfast in Washington, D.C., earlier this year, I asked Jens Stoltenberg, a former NATO secretary-general, whether he was confident that Trump would help defend the Baltic states in the event of a Russian attack. He said, "We base our security on that," a careful reply that stated an incontrovertible fact but did not answer the question.

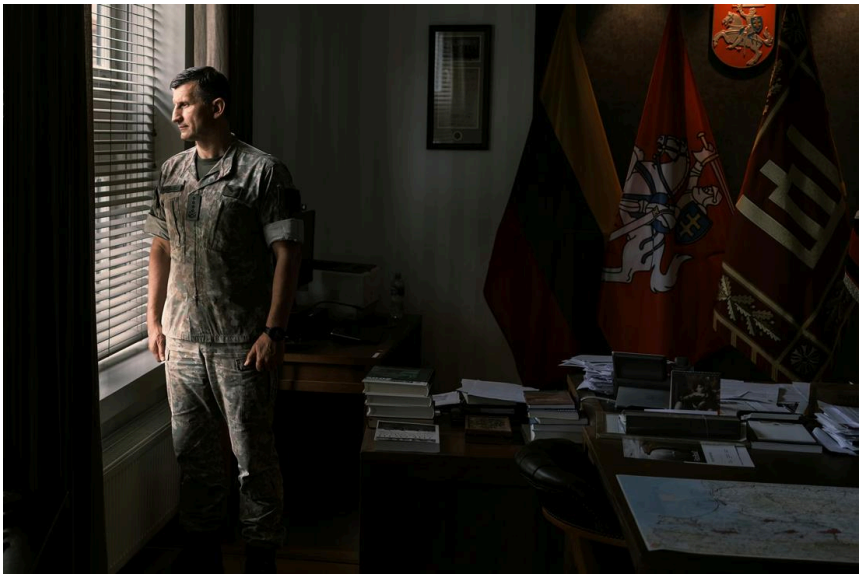



The threat of Russian expansionism may feel remote in the United States. But the idea that Russian soldiers might invade their countries doesn't seem implausible to the 6 million people who live in the Baltic states. It has happened before. The Second World War brought Soviet and Nazi invasions, and the postwar Soviet occupation threatened to extinguish Lithuania entirely. ("Lithuania is beautiful without the Lithuanians," a Politburo member once remarked.) In 1990, Lithuania became the first Soviet republic to declare its independence, and since then has transformed itself into a lively democracy with a high-tech economy. But it remains uniquely vulnerable: hemmed in to the east by the Russian satellite state of Belarus and to the west by the sea, and pinched to the south by the Russian exclave of Kaliningrad, home to Russia's Baltic Fleet and a staging ground for ballistic missiles capable of reaching most of Europe. Nuclear weapons are likely stored there too.

Lithuania spends more on defense as a share of its economic output than any other NATO country, and for years has urged the West to take Russian aggression more seriously. The possibility of war is lodged in its politics, its economy, and its psyche; the memory of occupation haunts its present and its view of the future.

Read: Europeans have realized their error

Whether Russia has imminent designs on the independent Baltic countries it once ruled is a matter of dispute, though the dispute centers mainly on the word *imminent*, not on Moscow's desires. The Russian military is in poor condition in key respects. The cost of recruiting is high, armor stocks are dwindling, and corruption is endemic. But Russia has improved its performance in other areas, including its use of drones and glide bombs, and its agile infantry tactics. A recent American-led air exercise in Poland and the Baltic states, which massed fighter aircraft near Kaliningrad, seemed designed to warn Moscow of the costs of adventurism. Many analysts believe that any mobilization against the Baltics would come only after the end of hostilities in Ukraine, where almost all capable Russian ground forces are currently engaged. Ukraine, Vaikšnoras noted hopefully, is "keeping Russians away." Others see Russian President Vladimir Putin's incentives differently, fearing that he might wish to act sooner, exploiting the interval in which the U.S. commitment to Europe seems to be faltering but Europe's rearmament, after decades of disinvestment, is incomplete. Russian coordination with China—timing an attack in Europe to coincide with a move by Beijing against Taiwan—could be disastrous. Some U.S. and European officials I spoke with believe that the high burn rate of American munitions in Iran may increase Russia's appetite to test NATO with a limited ground attack in the Baltics. The aim would be a fait accompli, taking a small piece of territory so quickly that the defenders decide the cost of reversal is too high. Putin once boasted that Russian forces could seize the Baltic capitals in two days. A Putin ally not long ago described Latvia, Lithuania's neighbor to the north, as a "nonexistent country."



General Raimundas Vaikšnoras, Lithuania’s chief of defense, at his office in Vilnius (Maciek Nabrdalik for *The Atlantic*)

For the Baltic nations, “wait and see” is not a strategy. Distrust of Russian intentions has given rise to a low-grade but pervasive dread that hangs over daily life and has an impact on all institutions. Cities constantly hone their evacuation plans. Hospitals can shift at once to a wartime footing. After Russia’s 2022 invasion of Ukraine, membership in the Lithuanian Riflemen’s Union doubled, and now stands at about 20,000. When I visited Vaikšnoras, he brought me to an alcove behind his office where his helmet, rucksack, and body armor were hanging on a small wooden stand. It’s his job to imagine the worst. But as I learned during a month spent talking with political and military leaders, it’s also true that, in a struggle for survival, the Baltic states possess advantages. They are ready to commit their whole societies to the fight. What they no longer know is whether the United States will be by their side—and in Russian eyes, uncertainty may seem like an invitation.

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## THE FIRST DAY

What would a Russian attack on the Baltic states look like? It could come in the form of outright invasion, designed to control all three

countries and restore what Russia has declared to be its rightful sphere of influence. It could come in the form of "hybrid war," which the Baltic states have gotten a taste of already: think cyberintrusions, assassination attempts, arson, damage to undersea infrastructure, interference with GPS frequencies, and a deliberately heightened volume of asylum flows—transporting desperate migrants from the Middle East and Africa to the border of European Union countries, as Belarus has done since 2021. Russia could also stir up unrest among the Russian-speaking minority who still live in the Baltic states—a scenario that figures in *If Russia Wins*, a best-selling book published last year by the academic analyst Carlo Masala. Short of invading all three countries, Russia could attempt to close the Suwałki Gap—the small patch of border that Lithuania shares with Poland, stretching for roughly 40 miles between Kaliningrad and Belarus. This corridor is the only friendly overland route between the Baltic states and the rest of NATO Europe—an essential lifeline.

Read: Russia's hybrid-war strategy in Europe

Despite the shortcomings revealed by its war in Ukraine, Russia would be a formidable adversary. It is willing to send soldiers to their deaths by the hundreds of thousands, and it possesses nuclear weapons. Baltic leaders do not make the mistake of thinking that Russia will behave the way they want it to. As former U.S. Defense Secretary James Mattis has cautioned, about all military conflict, "The enemy gets a vote." That said, it would be hard to hide large-scale Russian preparations for invasion. Baltic intelligence officers are so focused on every permutation of the Russian threat that their mindset was summarized to me this way by a European expert in Baltic security: "If a seagull shits in the harbor, we know what it had for breakfast, we know where it nests, and we know when it last went to Russia." When I visited Vaikšnoras, I noticed on his desk a map of a new training area, planned for the southwestern part of the country, right near the Suwałki Gap. If enemy troops

start massing on Russian or Belarusian territory, Lithuanian troops will assemble opposite them—force-shadowing, as it is called.

The Baltic states can't trade space for time—a classic defensive strategy that involves yielding territory in order to exhaust the enemy, then waiting until a counterattack becomes feasible. Vilnius, the capital, home to 600,000 people, is a mere 20 miles from Belarus. In the early days of an invasion, it would quickly be threatened by the Russian army. The Baltic states need to hold off the invaders for as long as possible, hoping that allied help will arrive—whether in the form of ground forces or, even more useful, airpower—before the situation becomes irretrievable.

Lithuania's military, though the largest among the Baltic states, is nonetheless modest: some 60,000 men and women in active and reserve units. In an emergency, and with the assistance of well-trained volunteer groups such as the Riflemen, the number could swell to more than 80,000—still small compared with any potential Russian force. To help contain the enemy forces and keep them as close to the border as possible, the Baltic states are building a defensive line—digging anti-tank ditches and erecting concrete obstacles called "dragon's teeth" because of their hulking triangular shape.



Anti-tank “dragon’s teeth” on Lithuania’s heavily fortified border with Belarus (Maciek Nabrdalik for *The Atlantic*)

Modern technology could make a big difference. The plan is to saturate the border with infrared cameras and acoustic sensors, a network modeled on a Ukrainian system called Sky Fortress. Data gathered by this equipment would be shared with allies and analyzed by artificial intelligence to help determine the best way to neutralize incoming threats. Border areas could also be heavily mined. All three Baltic states, along with Poland and Finland, have withdrawn from the 1997 Ottawa Treaty, aimed at eliminating antipersonnel land mines, which can kill or maim civilians long after conflicts have ended. The move caused some disquiet in allied capitals. The reply from the Baltics was, *What choice do we have?*

One afternoon, two soldiers picked me up outside the ministry of defense in a military off-roader, and we drove east to the Belarusian border. The terrain is flat, seemingly favorable to an attacker. But it’s also full of spongy bogs, which serve as natural choke points. Last year, four American soldiers died during a training mission in Lithuania when their 70-ton armored truck sank in a wetland. Lithuania is re-creating swamps and reforesting parts of the border to force the enemy into predictable routes. Man-made obstacles are layered on top of natural barriers to channel (or, in military parlance, canalize) the enemy into narrow zones.

The dragon’s teeth rise to about chest height, and they’re linked by a tangle of metal cords. The fortifications are perhaps the most conspicuous part of Baltic war planning. Rather than destroying a tank outright, the dragon’s teeth catch a vehicle’s underside, where its armor is thinner, and lift the hull off the ground. This leaves the vehicle stranded and vulnerable to artillery and anti-tank missiles. The military has bottleneck coordinates already plotted, anticipating that the enemy will need to slow at specific points.

A breach attempt at a fortified point would create extraordinary violence: tanks caught on dragon's teeth, mines detonating, artillery landing on the stalled convoy, drones circling overhead to hit anything left moving. Meanwhile, the Baltic states would be striking deep in enemy territory. All three Baltic countries have ordered missile launchers called HIMARS, and their most powerful precision-strike missiles have a range of about 190 miles. That's almost exactly the distance from Tallinn, the capital of Estonia, to the Russian city of St. Petersburg.

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## THE FIRST 72 HOURS

Given the likely warning signs, political and military consultations would begin within NATO before Russian troops cross any border. When the Baltic states joined the alliance, NATO leaders initially resisted developing plans for their defense so as not to provoke conflict with the Kremlin. Then, in 2008, Russia invaded Georgia. That year, a senior Russian official and close associate of Putin's publicly described the Baltic states, along with Crimea and other parts of Ukraine, as "traditional territory of the Russian nation." In response, an existing NATO playbook for the defense of Poland was extended to the Baltics. But only meager forces were pre-positioned, and reinforcement timelines were inexact. Implicitly, the strategy was to cede territory in hopes of later taking it back. Widespread Russian atrocities in Ukraine following the 2022 invasion made that prospect unacceptable, and Baltic leaders pressed for changes. A year later, the alliance adopted new regional defense plans aimed at containing and countering an incursion, rather than rolling it back.

The main conference chamber at NATO headquarters, in Brussels, is known as Room 1—an amphitheater with an oval table in the middle. This is where ambassadors would gather in the event of an attack to consider a bid by the Baltic states for a declaration under Article 5—the necessary first step toward a collective response.

The ambassadors make up the North Atlantic Council, the alliance's main political decision-making body. They would seek options from NATO's military committee, composed of the member states' national-defense representatives. Remigijus Baltrėnas, a Lithuanian general, currently leads NATO's military staff, although NATO doesn't have any forces of its own; everything is provided by member countries. When I asked Baltrėnas if he believed that the alliance would come to the aid of the Baltic states, he said, "I'm convinced, practically, that if it will be needed, nations will be able to push aside their national ambitions, their national restrictions, and agree for the cohesion and defense of the alliance, to move forward with whatever is necessary." But as the clauses and qualifications in his gnarly statement suggest, it would be, as he put it, a "painful process." Different alliance members will view the risk of escalation differently. Some may even have different interpretations of the facts.

A new color-coded alert system dictates what degree of mobilization is called for: yellow, amber, and red, with the last meaning that an attack is imminent or has already started. The Supreme Allied Commander Europe, who leads all NATO military operations, has the authority to rush certain forces to the region before the member countries reach a consensus. An American has held that job since the alliance's founding, in 1949. Today, it belongs to Alexus G. Grynkewich, an Air Force general. He can call upon tens of thousands of troops supplied by member countries; their duty is to be mission-ready and able to deploy within 10 days of activation.



Members of the Lithuanian Riflemen's Union monitor military exercises from a facility in Vilnius. (Maciek Nabrdalik for *The Atlantic*)

The U.S. military has been training Lithuanian troops and other armed forces in the Baltics for years. The Riflemen's exercise I witnessed in Lithuania took place at the conclusion of a nine-week commando course run by the 1st Battalion of the Army's 12th Cavalry Regiment, deployed from Fort Hood, Texas. But the American battalion was rotating out of the country the next day—and there would be no "heel to toe" replacement, as there had been since 2019.

That may seem like a small thing, but it occasions nervousness about a larger one. Deterrence is about signaling, and the Baltic nations need Russia to believe that Washington would treat an attack on their territory as an attack on all NATO members. In the past, the U.S. has spoken loudly in support of the Baltic countries. On a trip to Vilnius in 2002, President George W. Bush vowed that "anyone who would choose Lithuania as an enemy has also made an enemy of the United States of America." Those words are engraved on a plaque outside the entrance of city hall. Do they remain true more than two decades later?

NATO could be drawn into a conflict regardless. Each of the Baltic states hosts allied forces, initially assembled in the years after Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014 and then expanded after the invasion in 2022. Multinational forces were originally intended as trip wires that would compel a larger NATO force to intervene. Now their mission is contributing to a credible defense from the very start of an invasion. Kris Reeves, a Canadian colonel who until recently commanded multinational forces in Latvia, told me, "I can fight tonight and tell Ottawa tomorrow." The brigade in Lithuania is expanding to include 5,000 Germans and the latest tanks for added firepower and mobility. About 20 countries contribute to military forces in the three Baltic states, led by Germany, Canada, and Britain.

Žilvinas Gaubys, a brigadier general who heads Lithuania's training-and-doctrine command, told me that the military has considered a scenario in which help from Washington is delayed or does not arrive—indeed, war games have been conducted that consider this premise. Military planners, the general said, must test "the most difficult scenarios." According to established war plans, American forces stationed in Poland or Germany should be activated from the "first minute" of an invasion, Gaubys explained. But what happens if that minute goes by and the Americans don't come? The presence of other international forces offers a measure of reassurance. So, too, according to Baltic officials, does the progress made by NATO's European members in acquiring certain capabilities, such as aerial refueling, that the U.S. once mostly provided. But there would be no easy replacement for American satellite intelligence, or for American missiles and hypersonics capable of reaching far behind the front line. Loss of American support would diminish what the Baltic states can see and what they can strike.

NATO planners know that, early on, Russia would rely not only on physical force but also on cyberwarfare to disable critical infrastructure in the Baltic states—the energy, transport, water, and

communications systems that enable their societies to function. The vulnerability, however, goes both ways. When it comes to cyberoperations, Estonia is a global leader. It made cybercapabilities a priority after a sweeping digital assault brought down government and commercial servers in 2007—a surprise move by Russia or Russian sympathizers to protest the relocation of a Soviet-era statue. In response, Estonia established a dedicated cybercommand within its armed forces, as well as a cyberunit within the Estonian Defence League, a volunteer reserve team drawing on the country's immense civilian IT talent pool. One way reservists contribute is by looking inside successful Ukrainian technology—the Baltic states understand how Ukraine's innovations are transforming the nature of warfare.

Read: Lessons from the world's most tech-savvy government

Estonia's cybercommand is led by a taciturn colonel named René Innos. When I met him over the summer, in Tallinn, he was wearing combat fatigues and black boots but had the tired and under-exercised look of someone who spends most of his time looking at a computer screen. Part of his job, he said, is defensive: Every year, he sees billions of "knocks on the door" by Russian hackers looking to penetrate Estonian networks. But the cybercommand is capable of offensive operations too, and it would be an invisible but major part of any war. One objective, Innos said, would be to disrupt the "kill chain"—the communications links that connect target acquisition and target destruction. Another objective would be simply sowing confusion. The enemy, of course, is renowned for its own digital expertise. Both sides would be asking, *What is the next new trick?*

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## THE FIRST WEEK

The conflict would soon begin to stabilize—not to ease, necessarily, but to unfold along more predictable lines. Both sides

would be using a dense network of drones, sensors, and mines, making a surprise breakthrough on the front difficult to achieve. Russian infantry and armored vehicles would be detected by drone reconnaissance and then destroyed before they could generate momentum and push past defensive fortifications. Many of the defenders wouldn't be firing machine guns or driving tanks. They'd be operating small quadcopters known as FPV drones, because of the first-person view they give remote pilots. FPV drones mostly function as one-way strike weapons, though the same airframes can fly reconnaissance. One Lithuanian colonel estimates that 80 to 90 percent of Russian casualties could be inflicted by FPV drones.

A visit to a training area in the southwestern part of Lithuania, about 30 miles from the border with Kaliningrad, gave me a sense of the country's growing drone capabilities. Trainees were sitting behind a pair of laptops placed on a folding table in a tent. A Monster Energy drink was open on the table. The primary pilot used simple mouse clicks to direct an airborne vehicle—an Estonian-made reconnaissance drone with a range of about 30 miles. Sitting alongside, his co-pilot operated the camera system using a joystick resembling a PlayStation controller.

I had come to the training area from Kaunas, Lithuania's second-largest city, where a military-drone laboratory occupies space in a glass-sheathed university building. The army is using the facility to turn soldiers into engineers. FPV drones are cheap—they can cost only a few hundred dollars apiece—but also full of bugs. Being able to replace a battery in the field could save money and lives. Inside the lab, an airy space with soldering irons and fume extractors, soldiers in army fatigues were bent over worktables. A reservist in jeans and a T-shirt stood at a whiteboard, delivering a lesson about the battery's power connector and protective casing. Nearby, university students were completing an academic 3-D-printing project, unconnected with warfare. They appeared unbothered by the military preparations, which are difficult to keep neatly apart from civilian life. Schools operated by the ministry of

defense are teaching children as young as 10 how to assemble, program, and fly drones.



A trainee learns to fly an attack drone at a military school near Lviv, in Ukraine.  (Paula Bronstein / Getty)

I was in the company of Arnoldas Sadauskas, a major in the Lithuanian armed forces. Earlier, I had seen in the back of his van a pile of torpedo-shaped warheads with propellers, which he showed me while casually lighting a cigarette. The most important lesson to learn, Sadauskas said, is the need for improvisation. He brought up Ukraine, as Baltic commanders often do. Its armed forces no longer wait for foreign companies to provide state-of-the-art equipment. Ukraine builds its own, and constantly changes the technical composition to elude electronic countermeasures. The takeaway—that technical advances can make up for a relative disadvantage in troop strength—is now dogma in Baltic defense thinking. Officers from Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania make frequent trips to Ukraine. I asked Sadauskas if he was adapting lessons from Americans too. He said, “I don’t know what they have to teach me.”

In a sustained conflict, the Baltic states would need private industry to replenish weapons stocks and modify technology as battlefield dynamics change. Because of their size, the Baltic states don’t

build heavy platforms, such as battle tanks and self-propelled artillery. Their advantage lies in niche areas, including electronics, optics, and ammunition components. The field of photonics, devoted to generating and controlling light, is especially strong in Vilnius. Julius Skruibis, the chief technology officer of Aktyvus Photonics, told me that the city is home to no fewer than 60 companies active in this area.

Aktyvus Photonics is in a tech hub on the outskirts of Vilnius, and I met Skruibis at the company's offices. He gave me a pair of sunglasses, and with our eyes shielded and shoes wrapped in plastic coverings, we entered an antiseptic space where engineers in blue lab coats were experimenting with laser designators—highly concentrated light sources used to "light up" military targets. These laser beams guide munitions to their destinations.

The company has developed a handheld designator for the Ukrainian armed forces. In my hand, it felt like a state-of-the-art film camera, smooth and compact. The designator has a range of six miles. The drawback is that a soldier using one from a ground position, kneeling and pointing it at a target, risks exposure to the enemy. The company's newest designator, not much bigger than a Duracell nine-volt battery, can be lifted by a small drone, and is now the biggest-selling Aktyvus product. Keeping the designator steady is the challenge; it's buffeted both by wind and by vibrations from the drone. Digital stabilization is able to remove imperfections in the video feed, but there's as yet no analogue for adjusting the beam of light. The company is working intensively on stabilization technology to hold the designator in place. Skruibis was frank about the kind of accuracy he's seeking: He placed an index finger on his forehead, right between his eyes.

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THE FIRST MONTH

The consequences of any conflict in the Baltic states will quickly expand outward. Within a month of the war launched by the U.S. and Israel against Iran in February, it had grown to involve more than a dozen other countries, closed the Strait of Hormuz, and sent global oil prices to their highest levels in years. Some ramifications of a Baltic conflict are unpredictable, but one is not: The Baltic Sea would become a contested strategic space.

One of the keys to controlling the Baltic Sea is Gotland, a Swedish island about 80 miles from the Baltic states. Its sandy beaches and limestone cliffs make it a tourist jewel. It is also vital to establishing air and naval dominance over the entire region. Several years ago, Russian state television hosted a reserve officer and pro-Kremlin commentator who explained how Russian forces could commandeer Gotland, which is about the size of Long Island, and leverage it as a base while Moscow set about conquering the Baltic states. Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania have no combat aircraft of their own, and only gunboat navies. Lithuania's largest ship is a minelayer that came used from Norway.




A sign reading #MesNATO, or "We Are NATO" in Lithuanian, outside the defense ministry's headquarters, in Vilnius (Maciek Nabrdalik for *The Atlantic*)

Sweden and Finland joined NATO in the aftermath of Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine, casting aside a long tradition of neutrality and military nonalignment. One day this summer, I met Sweden's defense chief, Michael Claesson, on the deck of the Carlskrona, which at 350 feet has the distinction of being the longest ship in the Swedish navy. It packs little firepower but bristles with masts, antennas, radar arrays, and communications equipment. It was docked in the harbor at Visby, Gotland's capital. The fortification of Gotland, Claesson explained, would allow NATO to project air and maritime superiority in the broader Baltic Sea region. Kaliningrad is to the southeast. Rockets and long-range missiles launched from Gotland could easily strike Russian supply lines and other infrastructure supporting military operations in the Baltics. The island is an ideal staging ground for fighter jets: close enough to high-value Russian targets but far enough away to be untouchable by short-range drones launched from Russian terrain. That enviable location has earned the island its description as an "unsinkable aircraft carrier."

Hostilities would convulse the entire maritime zone, one of the busiest in the world for commerce. Trade and civilian traffic in the Baltic would be suspended, with priority given to reinforcement and evacuation efforts. Moscow is not without options, even if the Baltic Sea, ringed almost entirely by Western allies, has come to be seen as a "NATO lake." Russia still has access to Baltic waters from ports at St. Petersburg and Kaliningrad. It could provide military escorts for its merchant fleet and target undersea cables used for power and communication. Missiles from Kaliningrad could menace maritime operations and hold regional economies hostage.

In some ways, Gotland is to NATO what Kaliningrad is to Russia—a forward outpost that helps control access to a vital theater of operations. Which is why the island itself is vulnerable to attack, and why war could spread quickly to Sweden. The Swedish armed forces disbanded the island's last defensive regiment in 2005 and

began restoring its defenses only after Russia's annexation of Crimea. In 2022, as Russian troops massed on Ukraine's border, Sweden dispatched additional units to Gotland. Armored vehicles clambered down Visby's medieval streets. The government in Stockholm is building new barracks and other facilities, and Sweden's military has conducted joint exercises involving U.S. Marines. Bolstering the garrison on Gotland remains a work in progress, and a visitor may well be more aware of archaeological activity (the island has been settled, sparsely, for millennia) than of a humming military presence. Ewa Skoog Haslum, a vice admiral and Sweden's chief of joint operations, was blunt about her view when we spoke: "We have too few forces on Gotland." Moscow is definitely aware of Gotland's strategic value. Russia's ambassador to Sweden recently accused the government in Stockholm of "provocative steps" on Gotland, vowing that Moscow would "take all of this into account in our military-political planning."




General Michael Claesson, Sweden's defense chief, aboard the Carlskrona in Gotland (Maciek Nabrdalik for *The Atlantic*)

Although NATO forces have trained on Gotland, offensive weapons aren't currently stored there. I asked Claesson how long it would take to turn Gotland into a platform for serious offensive

operations. “Days,” he said, holding up a few fingers. “Days on one hand.”

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ENDGAME

Men in hooded suits, gas masks, and orange boots lifted bodies from wheeled gurneys and placed them on folding tables: yet another training exercise, this one taking place in a barracks belonging to the Vitkus Engineer Battalion, in Kaunas. The battalion builds defensive fortifications, clears land mines, and removes chemical and biological hazards. The premise of the training exercise was that the enemy had used chemical weapons against civilians. Victims had to be cut out of their clothes and doused with soapy water. Medics triaged cases while a decontamination team rushed people through washing stations. The equipment came from the Defense Threat Reduction Agency, the part of the U.S. Department of Defense responsible for countering weapons of mass destruction.

The longer a war persists, and the deeper into civilian society it penetrates, the more resources the engineer battalion will require. Its commander told me that its motto is “First in, last out.” The battalion is still finding and disposing of mines and other unexploded ordnance from both world wars. It is named for Juozas Vitkus, a colonel in the country’s interwar army who helped train members of the Lithuanian Riflemen’s Union. He was killed by Soviet troops in 1946.

The Lithuanians I met in military barracks, on training fields, and at government offices all wanted to make sure I witnessed the many ways in which the United States is still participating in their defense—presumably, they want to believe, with every intention of assisting in a potential war with Russia. Strategic culture in the Baltics is indebted to American guidance. Many generals have studied and trained in the United States. When I met with

Vaikšnoras, the Lithuanian defense chief, I noticed a photograph of his graduating class at the U.S. Army War College, where he received a master's degree in 2013. Ties between the two militaries remain close. And although many nations, including NATO allies, are skittish about having nuclear weapons based on their soil, Lithuania is revising its constitution to permit such staging. But the American commitment to NATO—to countries such as Poland and Germany, never mind the Baltic states—is no longer a given. As I watched U.S. Army personnel give pointers to Lithuanian troops, I wondered if they might be among the last American military representatives engaged in Europe in this way.



During military exercises, Lithuanian Riflemen's Union volunteers clear a railway station in the town of Bezdonys. (Maciek Nabrdalik for *The Atlantic*)

These days, the truly inescapable sight in Lithuania is not the Stars and Stripes but the blue-and-yellow flag of Ukraine. It flies outside government ministries. It is draped inside hipster coffee shops. Near the Neris River, which cuts through the capital, I saw a bird feeder painted in blue and yellow. Don't mistake this for a mere token of solidarity. It is a badge acknowledging Ukraine's contribution to the defense of Europe.

The Baltics are sometimes described as the Cassandra of European states—doomed for their prescience. But the metaphor is not quite right. Vilnius isn't Troy, and it wasn't sacked when Lithuania's warnings about Russian expansionism were vindicated in 2022. For now, Ukraine is absorbing the Russian onslaught, and giving survival lessons to other vulnerable democracies. One counterpoint to a weakening American military presence in Europe has been an acceleration of visits by European military leaders to Ukraine. My interview with General Gaubys had to be cut short because he was scheduled for a trip to the Ukrainian battlefield.

Questions about the future of the American-led order are unavoidable in Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania. The doubts provoked by Trump about the principle of collective defense will not easily be assuaged or argued away. But I also encountered something else: the emergence of a new order, in which Ukraine matters as much to the security of Europe as the United States does. Baltic soldiers are in Ukraine every day, embedding with officers close to the front line, helping where they can, but most of all learning, adopting their tactics, and preparing their own defense. They believe that war with Russia is coming. They would prefer to have American backing when it does. But they'll fight without the United States if they need to.

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*This article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline "The Next Front."*

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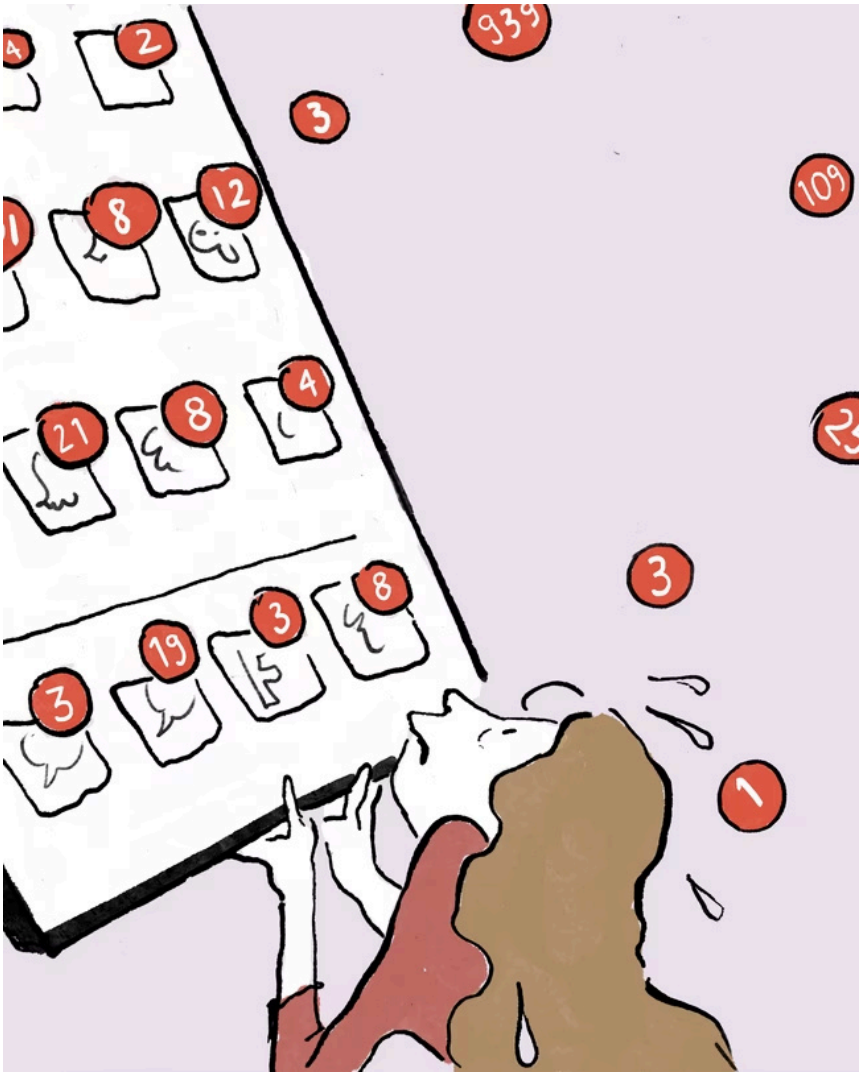
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# Forgive the Bad Texters

**We are truly sorry for our delayed response. **

by Julie Beck

Thu, 08 Oct 2026




Whenever I receive a text, this is what happens. I pick up my phone. So far, so good. I experience whatever emotion the message elicits—the pleasant warmth of being reached out to, possibly the annoyance of being interrupted. Then, if conditions are right, if I’m not too busy or in the middle of talking with someone else, if my

mind is at peace, if my anxiety is at no more than a low hum, if Mercury is not in retrograde, I will respond right then and there. If conditions are not right, it will be as though the text never existed at all.

Right now, I have 30 unopened texts. Scrolling through my messages, I find several more that I opened but forgot to respond to for anywhere between a few hours and a week and a half—from my parents, my sister's fiancé, old friends who are accustomed to this kind of behavior, and new friends who are just beginning to be disappointed in me. At least two people texted me so long ago—more than a month—that to respond now and remind them how long they've been waiting would be worse than not responding at all.

I'm not proud of leaving people hanging. Every text I owe is a tiny siren in the back of my mind, blaring intermittent pulses of guilt. Unless I forget about it entirely, in which case I'll remember it with a shameful jolt some days or weeks later. I'm not one of those modern hermits who thinks you don't owe anyone anything, who likes every Instagram post she sees about boundaries and thinks that flaking on plans is self-care. I write about relationships for a living, and I believe that showing up for one another is the purpose of our existence. That's, like, my whole brand. And so this is my greatest shame: I am a Bad Texter. I am slow to respond. I am forgetful. I get overwhelmed. My own mother has said I'm "probably worse than 90 percent of the other people that I text with."

This might seem like a trivial pathology, but it isn't. Texting is the currency of modern relationships. In 2024, Americans exchanged more than 2 trillion text messages, about 42 billion more than the year before, according to CTIA, a trade group representing the wireless industry. Some of those texts are probably spam. Some are advertising. Some are bits of automated busywork (*click this link to confirm your appointment* ). But many of them, hopefully most of

them, are between people who know one another, reaching out for connection over the waves of the wireless spectrum.

According to a 2023 survey, texting is the No. 1 way that people prefer to communicate with their loved ones, beating out mobile-phone calls and absolutely crushing face-to-face conversations, which got only 8 percent of the vote. Texting came out ahead in every age bracket except the oldest; those 55 and older ranked texting and mobile-phone calls equally. No age group preferred anything over texting.

Yet at the same time, texting stresses people out. A third of Americans report feeling overwhelmed by the number of texts they need to respond to, and a majority say they struggle to keep up with their group chats. As Pranav Malhotra, who studies communication and media at the University of Michigan, told me, texting "is what the people want, but it's not doing them any good." And so, many of us end up feeling like Bad Texters. We are here, we are legion, and we are sorry for our delayed response.

Texting dominates our social lives like nothing else. According to the research firm Nielsen, American cellphone users started texting more than they called in 2007. Since then, unlimited phone plans and widespread Wi-Fi have removed many of the barriers that once led people to restrict their texts.

The ubiquity of text-messaging hardly seems worth questioning—it's simply the way things are. But when you think about it, the modern predilection for managing all of our relationships by typing on a tiny touch screen is a bit odd. "For darn sure, it's a lot faster to talk about things than it is to text them," Naomi Baron, who studies language and technology at American University, told me. "Particularly if you have more than, let's say, 100 characters' worth to say. But it's become the way of doing things."

Texting achieved domination because it's convenient—you can message someone at any time without waiting to see if they're available first—and because it offers a sense of control. You don't need to risk the uncertainty that comes with live conversation; you can plan out exactly what you want to say, and people won't see how you react to their response. This is one of the things that people say they like best about texting. But the ease of sending messages means, on the flip side, that people are receiving more.

Listen: Would you go back to a time before smartphones if you could?

As texting became our default mode of communication, messages that once might have taken another form—your hair salon calling to confirm an appointment, an email invite to your best friend's birthday party, a paper medical bill—started arriving as texts. And the act of texting is no longer confined to whatever mobile app processes your SMS messages. I have four different texting-specific apps on my phone: the standard iPhone Messages, WhatsApp, Signal, and KakaoTalk—a Korean messaging app where my in-laws' family group chat lives. Then there are social-media DMs, which function much like texting, and Slack, where my colleagues send me DMs that would have been emails not so long ago. These show up on my home screen as notifications, and when I respond on my phone, the feeling is very similar to texting.

I have sometimes attempted to deal with my texting overwhelm by communicating in other ways. Lately, I've been trying to call people more to catch up, which is wonderful, but it can also cause alarm. One British survey from 2024 found that more than half of young adults said they assumed unexpected calls meant bad news. (Surely you would just text anything else you want to say.) Sometimes I'll send my friends voice messages when I want to tell them a story that's too long to type, but this, too, is controversial. I love voice messages—I think they feel so much more intimate than a text—but many people think that expecting a friend to take five

minutes out of their day to listen to a mini-podcast you recorded is annoying, or even selfish. For party invitations, vacation planning, or anything logistical, I prefer to use email, but I've received explicit feedback from my husband and many of my friends that I should be texting instead, because "no one checks their email." (Can this possibly be true?) Whenever I try to escape, social pressure always seems to push me back to texting.

And so the texts multiply, taking up more and more space in our relationships, until to be called a Bad Texter feels like being accused of being a bad spouse, sibling, child, parent, or friend.



Instagram's algorithm must have me figured out because it recently served me a video of an episode of "SubwayTakes," in which the

comedian Delaney Rowe shared her take: “There’s no such thing as a bad texter; they just don’t want to respond.” Claiming to be bad at texting, she said, is a “cop-out,” because a lack of responsiveness is conditional. “When a bad texter gets a crush? Best texter in the world,” she said.

This is what I fear my loved ones think: that my response time is directly correlated with how much I care about them. What else could it be? Americans check their phone nearly 200 times a day on average, and the overwhelming majority keep their phone on them “almost all the time,” according to recent surveys. The modern expectation that everyone is constantly reachable is unreasonable, but it’s not *that* unreasonable, given how attached people are to their phones.

Lizzie Post is a great-great-granddaughter of the early-20th-century etiquette writer Emily Post, and a co-president of the Emily Post Institute, where she writes about modern manners. Unfortunately, she confirmed that politeness requires responding to texts promptly, and that too long a delay is rude. (Though the meaning of *promptly* can vary depending on the context.) “I hate to say it,” she told me, but “I would really try to prioritize it a bit more.”

She was not the only expert I spoke with who said I needed to shape up. “Get one with the idea that people who text expect fast responses,” Paul Leonardi, a technology-management professor at UC Santa Barbara and the author of *Digital Exhaustion*, told me. You don’t have to meet that expectation, but there are consequences for not doing so. He pointed out that, especially with long-distance loved ones, a text thread is “the meat of our relationship.” A shared experience is happening there, and you’re either contributing to it or you’re not. Often, he advised, it’s better to just say something—anything—quickly, rather than waiting to form the perfect response later. (I do sometimes delay texting people because I want to wait until I can put more thought into my message. But the longer I wait, the better I feel the message needs

to be to justify the delay. The pressure builds.) Post agreed. By responding too slowly, I'm at risk, she said, of making people think I don't want to connect with them—even if that's not true.

One of the costs of conducting so much of our relationships via text is the loss of context. In exchange for convenience, we give up tone of voice, eye contact, and body language. When all we have to go on are the words in front of us (or the lack thereof), we tend to "overinterpret very minor cues as signals of rudeness or as signals of *Oh, this person doesn't care about me*," Gretchen McCulloch, a linguist who studies online communication and the author of *Because Internet,* told me. Hence the unwritten rule that putting a period at the end of a text is passive-aggressive. My mom recently had a serious dustup with a friend, seemingly just because my mom put the word *not* in all caps in a text. Gaps in information too often get filled in with projections and insecurities.

I know my haphazard approach to texting risks fanning just such insecurities. And I've tried to be better. I put responding to texts on my to-do list. I've tried not opening any texts until I'm ready to write back, letting the notifications pile up and remind me every time I open my phone. I made a calendar reminder for every day at 4 p.m. that says "RESPOND TO TEXTS!!!," following the advice of several experts who suggested setting aside time to deal with all my texts at once, rather than taking them as they come. This helps, although it also makes me feel like I'm treating my loved ones like a productivity problem instead of a source of joy. And there's nothing to stop me from ignoring the reminder the same way I would a text.

Social obligation is as old as human society. In the 19th century, the practice of making social "calls" seems to have produced a feeling similar to the anxiety I get when I open my texts. An 1895 column in the *Rocky Mountain News* declared that the problem was one of volume—there were simply too many calls that one was expected to pay. "It may certainly be a pleasure to visit one's

friends," the anonymous author wrote, but the pleasure fades "when you are meeting them every day almost, by dozens and scores and hundreds." One woman quoted seemed to be on the verge of a nervous breakdown: "The calls I owe haunt me. They rise up in my dreams and chase me with spectre fingers."

Falling behind on your correspondence is nothing new, either. "The guilty message—'I'm sorry it took me so long to respond'—has a very long history," Steven Mintz, a historian at the University of Texas at Austin, told me. Indeed, in the 1922 edition of Emily Post's *Etiquette*, the author writes, "One of the frequent difficulties in beginning a letter is that your answer is so long delayed that you begin with an apology, which is always a lame duck."

The difference is that although an unanswered letter may have caused guilt and anxiety, you weren't expected to respond to it within five minutes. Technology has taken our sense of social obligation, accelerated it, amplified it, and splintered it into billions of little green and blue bubbles, each one both a point of connection and a task hanging over our heads.

"People always say we're wired to connect, but this isn't the kind of connecting that we're wired for," Lori Gottlieb, a psychotherapist and the author of *Maybe You Should Talk to Someone*, told me.

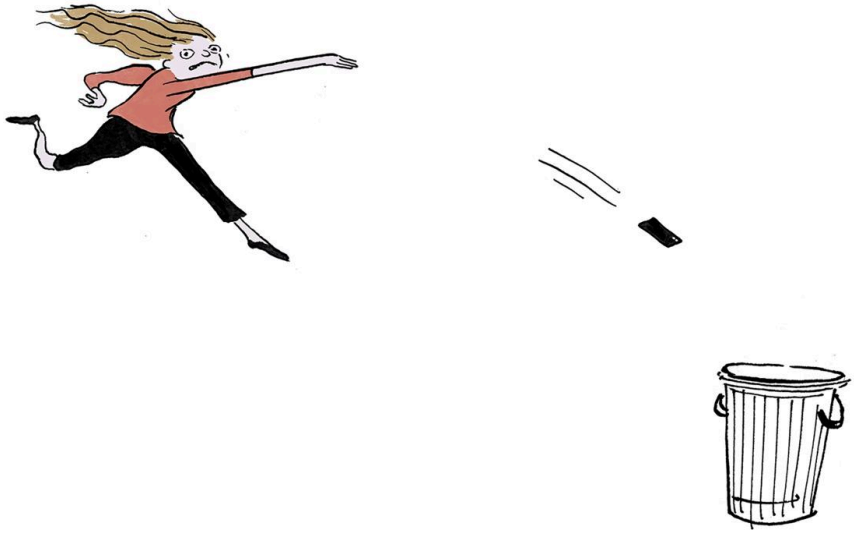
Being a Bad Texter might harm your relationships, but being a Good Texter will not necessarily help them. Research is unclear on this front. In terms of connection, texting seems to be better than nothing, but nowhere near as beneficial as phone calls or face-to-face conversations. The latter are definitely good for us, and they're declining. Time-use data show that over the past couple of decades, Americans have been spending less time socializing in person. One study even found that the number of words people speak out loud each day has decreased.

From the February 2025 issue: Derek Thompson on the anti-social century

Some research has suggested that the more someone texts, the lonelier and less satisfied they feel. In one study, researchers theorized that people found texting exasperating because they were using it with the intention of keeping in touch, but it didn't actually do all that much to maintain relationships. And every text message is a little interruption, taxing your attention and taking focus from the people who may be right in front of you.

Nothing in the research definitively says we shouldn't be texting one another—but nothing says we should prioritize it the way we do, either. "The one thing that's consistent about it is that it's inconsistent," Jess Dominguez, who researches communication at the University of Kentucky, told me. Technology, she said, "is always good and bad, and always at the same time."

The overwhelming emotion associated with texting seems to be ambivalence. The same things that make texting appealing also make it stressful. It's easy; it's convenient; it can be done anytime, anywhere. But that means you can end up feeling like you should be available to respond all the time, everywhere. Texting allows you to keep up with more people at once than phone calls or letters ever did. But those exchanges are shallower and less fulfilling. It gives welcome control over communication, but that can lead to pressure to draft the ideal response, or to using texting as a shield to hide from the messiness of real-time conversation. It is fun and it is frustrating, and it doesn't really matter if you like it, because it is more powerful than you are, and it's not going anywhere.



Eventually, we all must do things we have been dreading, whether it is apologizing for not texting someone back for a month or, in my case, interviewing my friends and family for this article. A story like this requires a reckoning, and narratively, I recognized that I must face up to who I am and what I have done to those I love. But I didn't want to, and I put it off as long as I could, until just before my deadline.

Feedback was kind, but mixed. "I have no complaints," my husband said. Vindication?! But "my bar is very low." Oh. A friend of mine called my failure to respond to a dinner invite until the day of "chaotic." When I asked my parents how their experience texting with me has been, my dad immediately said, "Poor." He had recently sent me a Mountain Goats song he likes; I hadn't responded. "A little too much to ask that you put a heart?" he said, only half-joking. "Couldn't do it, could you?"

My mom said she's never been offended, only confused. "I always walk this line between: Did she see the text, couldn't answer it, and then forgot about it? Or did she see the text and she's still going to answer it? It's, like, this waiting thing," she said. "Should I remind her? Should I not remind her?" Several people told me they didn't think of me as a notably Bad Texter, or at least they weren't bothered by my slowness. My friend Morgan pointed out that a text, like any other form of communication, is a "bid for

connection.” But it’s different than if someone opened their arms for a hug and I just walked away. Although I may drop the ball on responding sometimes, Morgan said, “I don’t feel like you’ve ever dropped the ball on maintaining a connection.”

I once read somewhere that trying to keep up with your work emails is a trap. The emails will never stop coming, and your only reward for responding quickly will be more emails. So you have two choices: You can be good at responding to email or you can be good at your job.

Listen: What it takes to reclaim your attention span

I feel a similar way about keeping up with my texts. I suppose I could opt out entirely and throw my phone into the sea. But opting out of texting would mean, to some degree, choosing isolation. I don’t want people to stop reaching out to me; I don’t want to give up on the good parts of texting, even if they’re inextricable from the bad. So I will try to carve out the occasional hour to attend to my correspondence. But I also want to let go of some of the guilt that tells me every delayed response means I’m being a bad friend, daughter, sister, wife.

I bring other things to the table, after all. If you need practical help—someone to feed your pets, watch your kids, help you move—I would be delighted to provide it. I’ll make spreadsheets to plan our vacations. I’ll buy you little gifts, and alarm you with cold calls just to catch up. If we’re together, I’ll put my phone away and give you my full attention. But if you text me, you may not hear back for a while.

You can be good at texting. You can be good at your relationships. Maybe for some people, it’s possible to be both. But they are not the same thing.

We want to hear from you: Tell us how many unread messages you have—or send a screenshot!—along with your name and the reason you're not-so-great at responding promptly. Text your response to (202) 266-7715. *(By participating, you agree to grant* The Atlantic *permission to use, modify, and distribute your submission text in all media.)*

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*This article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline "Confessions of a Bad Texter." When you buy a book using a link on this page, we receive a commission. Thank you for supporting* The Atlantic.

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/text-communication-social-obligation/688696/

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# When Anesthesia Goes Wrong

**A teenage boy went into surgery for a broken arm and emerged with brain damage. His mother was determined to figure out what had happened.**

by Sarah Zhang

Mon, 05 Oct 2026



Uli Gabriel Gobin Hernández suffered brain damage during surgery for a broken arm in 2006. His mother, a doctor named Yaremy Hernández Castillo, was determined to figure out what had gone wrong.

When Freddy Marquez was 12, he was hit by a motorcycle while biking and smashed his face into the pavement. He healed fast, but as adolescence reshaped his boyish features, the scar started to tug on his upper lip, leaving his mouth ajar. “Mom,” he said, “I’m going to high school. I don’t want to look like this.” So in September 2024, his parents found a surgeon in central Florida, where they live, to do a scar revision.

On the morning of his surgery, Freddy went into the operating room around 9. His mom, Joana Jardin, settled into a waiting-room chair, expecting to drive him home in a few hours. Noon came, then 1 o’clock, then 2, then 3. “Where is my son?” Joana began to ask. “Where is my son?” The staff couldn’t tell her anything, except that she had to wait. She watched as other parents picked up their kids from surgery and left. At 4 o’clock, she realized she was the only one in the waiting room.

When Joana finally got to see Freddy, around 5, he was barely conscious. His eyes were closed, his breaths shallow. He was just sleepy, a nurse reassured her, because he’d gotten Benadryl after a hive-like rash broke out—but not to worry, the monitors tracking his vitals showed nothing else awry. Eventually, Freddy managed to slump into a wheelchair, his eyes still closed. He was sent home.

The next day, Freddy woke up. Then he threw up. He was still drowsy and now irritable. His head hurt. Joana took him to urgent care and later to the ER, where doctors who evaluated him figured he was just recovering from surgery. But in the coming days, his symptoms became stranger and more disturbing. Freddy started losing control of the muscles in his face. He developed tremors. He choked on his saliva. He lost his balance. He felt what he could only describe as electricity coursing through his brain. “Please, Dad, pray for me,” he would cry when the “electricity” struck.

At the hospital where Freddy was finally admitted, doctors ordered two separate MRIs of his brain, and, to keep him still during the

scans, they put him under anesthesia. Both times, he took hours to regain consciousness. Both times, he emerged worse than before.

Freddy lost the ability to walk. His body spasmed and twitched as his muscles took on a life of their own. When Joana saw her son in the hospital bed—eyes staring at the ceiling, limbs flailing wildly—she remembers thinking this is how people once believed you could be "possessed by a demon."

The scans found spots of white in Freddy's brain—signs of dying and dead neurons—but no explanation as to what had caused them. In the coming weeks, he got better and then worse, worse enough that doctors ordered yet another MRI. His parents begged the hospital not to use anesthesia again. Don't worry, Joana remembers being told; the doctors can do it safely. They do it all the time. Joana felt that she had no choice but to trust them. As Freddy slid into unconsciousness, she once again started ticking off the hours waiting for him to wake up: 1 p.m., 2, 3, 4. "Where is my son?"

Freddy never woke up. His body went into cardiac arrest, then respiratory failure. He died on December 29, 2024, at age 14.

Before that final MRI, in one of their last conversations, Freddy had blurted in a half plea, half accusation, "You don't understand what is happening to me, Mommy." He was old enough, by then, to have lost faith in his parents' omniscience but young enough to still yearn for it. His ordeal had revealed to him that the adult world is riddled with unknowns; that the assurances of even doctors in white coats can mean very little. "I promise that I'm going to understand. Until my last breath," his mother told him. "I'm going to understand."

And she would, eventually. Joana did not know it then, but Freddy's death would be linked to dozens of cases of unexplained catastrophic brain damage after routine anesthesia, all in children

or young adults. Several, like Freddy, died. Others became permanently disabled.

The mystery of why Freddy died would ultimately collide with one of the greatest unsolved mysteries of medicine: How does anesthesia work in the first place? How is it that anesthesiologists can induce a state that some have called “functionally equivalent to brainstem death”—only to reverse it? This process happens 60,000 times a day in operating rooms across the United States. Yet it remains poorly understood. What happened inside Freddy’s brain, some researchers now think, may be an extreme version of what happens inside any of our brains when we slip into unconsciousness under anesthesia.

This past May, in Germany, I watched a doctor give a talk to her colleagues about two eerily similar cases almost two decades apart. One was Freddy’s. The other was that of a boy in Germany who went under anesthesia for a broken arm in 2006. Like Freddy, Ulrich “Uli” Gabriel Gobin Hernández was 14. Like Freddy, he took hours to wake up and then gradually lost control of his muscles. But unlike Freddy, Uli survived. The woman giving the talk was not Uli’s doctor. She was his mother.

Yaremy Hernández Castillo, who is soft-spoken and modest to a fault, wore a white coat with sensible sneakers as she flicked through slides of her son’s brain scans. Most of her colleagues at the cardiac-rehab hospital where she worked had no idea that she’d spent the past 20 years—outside her job as an internist—trying to decipher his condition. Early on, she had intuited that what happened to her son could be explained only by something still unknown to medical science. “Uli Gabriel, patient zero,” she came to think of him. But in the initial lonely years of her investigation, his doctors doubted her. Her own medical colleagues did too. “Everyone told me it was absurd,” she recalled to me, even as they could muster no better explanation.

These were the facts of Uli's case: On Saturday, January 14, 2006—a beautiful day to hit the slopes—he went snowboarding near his family's home in the Bavarian Alps. Uli took a jump way too fast and landed on his right arm; the humerus bone did not withstand the force of impact. He ended up at the local clinic, where Yaremy worked at the time, and where she trusted he was in capable hands. On weekends, the alpine-village clinic treated an influx of skiers with mangled bones.

But as the hours passed and Uli did not wake up from surgery, Yaremy began to worry. When he finally did rouse—confused, vomiting, and talking "like a drunk man"—her instincts both as a mother and as a doctor screamed that something was wrong.

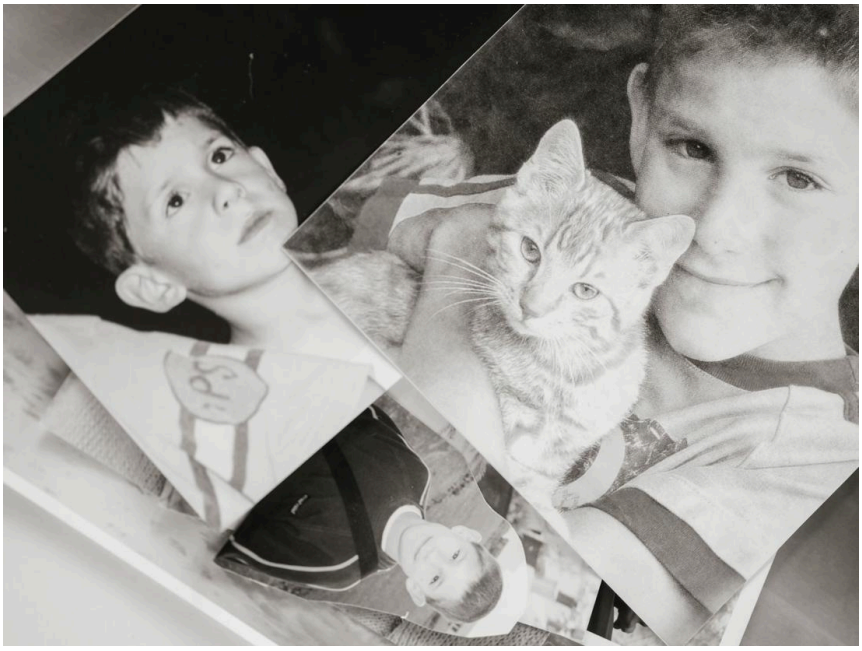
The trauma surgeon came to check on Uli's arm and declared it perfect—his own job was done. No one else seemed to share Yaremy's growing alarm at her son's mysterious neurological symptoms. The word she kept using to describe this period was *alone*. To get an MRI of Uli's brain, Yaremy personally arranged for an ambulance to take him to a larger hospital. On the MRI, two ghostly white spots appeared in his basal ganglia.

The death of brain cells in the basal ganglia, which coordinates movements of the body, explained Uli's symptoms, which progressed to erratic twisting, painful muscle spasms, and involuntary protrusion of the tongue. But what had caused the damage? No one knew. Uli could still walk and talk, albeit with some difficulty, and he remembered everything: the confusion, the pain, the seven dwarfs from *Snow White* plastered all over his pediatric hospital room, which, as a 14-year-old, he found tragically uncool. He was impatient to get better and to get out; he had tickets to a Foo Fighters show less than two weeks later. But the day of the concert came and went, and Uli remained stuck in the hospital, his symptoms unresolved, their underlying cause still unknown. The tests that doctors ran all came back negative.

Had his anesthesiologist made a mistake? Yaremy couldn't dismiss the possibility. How does a perfectly healthy kid become so sick from routine anesthesia, other than because of a terrible mistake? Malpractice could give grief a direction and a shape, suggesting a person to blame (a doctor) and a means of redress (a lawsuit). Friends kept telling Yaremy to sue. In the end, she did, filing a lawsuit against Uli's anesthesiologist, Ludwig Düthorn, a senior colleague whom she regularly passed in the hallways of their clinic. At the very least, she figured, the lawsuit could help uncover what had really happened.

At the clinic, Yaremy began to avoid the ICU, where Düthorn worked, unsure of what to say about the tragedy that had rattled both of their lives. Düthorn, too, was haunted by the case. He replayed the surgery in his mind, searching for any hint of the debacle to come. Uli's blood pressure had dipped briefly—but that wasn't uncommon during anesthesia, and would not have been enough to cause this level of brain damage. Düthorn had counteracted the drop with a routine dose of noradrenaline, and that had worked as intended. All of Uli's other vitals were unremarkable. All of the dosages had been double-checked by a nurse.

Afterward, whenever Düthorn had to anesthetize a healthy young boy, he would think of Uli. "I was personally devastated," he told me. "I thought, *I did the anesthesia. It is my fault*. But on the other hand, I could find no mistake."



Uli was an active kid, skiing at 3 years old and playing soccer in elementary school. (Julia Sellmann for *The Atlantic*)

The death or serious injury of a healthy child from anesthesia is so unusual as to be universally shocking to doctors these days. Anesthesia is known to pose risks to the elderly or ill, but even then it is far safer than it once was.

In the 19th century, as many as one out of 2,500 patients died under chloroform, then a popular anesthetic. But patients were willing to take the risk, because the alternative was pure, visceral horror: During the pre-anesthesia era, hospitals would put their operating rooms in towers, so as to spare other patients from all the screaming.

Like many medical breakthroughs, the discovery of anesthesia was something of an accident. Doctors became aware that ether, a popular party drug at the time, made giddy revelers insensitive to pain. They decided to give it a try in the operating theater: The first public demonstration was carried out on October 16, 1846, when a 21-year-old man under ether had a malformation removed from his neck at Massachusetts General Hospital. (The name *anaesthesia*, from the Greek for “without sensation,” was suggested by Oliver

Wendell Holmes Sr., the eminent doctor and essayist who also gave this magazine its name, in 1857.) At the time, doctors did not understand why ether worked; that it did was good enough.

General anesthesia today is often likened, colloquially, to sleep. But what it does to the brain is stranger and frankly spookier: A patient who is merely asleep would not lie still and take a bone saw to the chest. To render someone so deeply unconscious, anesthesia shuts down multiple distinct functions in the nervous system, making a patient insensate, paralyzed, and unable to form memories. The brain under anesthesia is suppressed to such an extent that Emery Brown, an anesthesiologist at Harvard and MIT, has compared it to coma or brain-stem death.

“The key thing is that it’s reversible,” Brown told me. When anesthetics stop being administered, the patient starts to rouse within minutes. Their consciousness flips back on. The spell breaks. This total reversal has happened millions of times in millions of people, the magic of it now mundane. But Uli had needed hours to find his way back to consciousness, his brain adrift someplace too deep and too dark to return from unscathed.

In the months after his accident, Uli’s symptoms became manageable enough for him to return to school. Still, he could be unsteady on his feet. On a walk with friends and their dog one day in 2007, he took a tumble and fractured his collarbone. His mother hoped the bone would heal without surgery, but his erratic limb movements from the damage to his brain kept jostling the broken bone. Surgery became inevitable.

Wary of anesthesia, Yaremy asked his doctor to avoid the type Uli had received for his arm surgery. She had no scientific evidence to cite, but she hoped he would listen to her, as a worried mother and as a fellow doctor. He did not.

This time, Uli did not wake up for days. Yaremy thought he was going to die. She would open his eyelids to check his reflexes. Nothing. When his eyes finally stayed open on their own, Uli was delirious. He screamed whenever an unfamiliar nurse entered his room. He had trouble following conversations. His skin became hypersensitive to touch. He lost more control over his limbs. He would never again be able to play guitar in his band or impress girls with snowboarding tricks. He would never even walk or talk on his own.

Yaremy struggled to care for him at home, and she began to contemplate her life in small-town Germany. She had grown up an ocean away, in the boisterous city of Caracas. At 21, she met a German man at a disco in Venezuela, who became her husband and then Uli's father, and who persuaded her to move to this tiny ski town, where her new in-laws ran a hotel. When she arrived—with 1-year-old Uli in her arms—she spoke little German. For a long time, she was the only foreigner in town. She missed the warmth of the Venezuelan sun and she missed her large family, who she knew would rally to help her back home.

And so, soon after the disastrous second surgery, Yaremy boarded a plane with Uli, now 17, to Caracas. Her younger child decided to stay in Germany with their father. They all planned to reunite in Venezuela later, but Yaremy knew her marriage was already over, its existing cracks widened by the new challenges of caring for their son.

The move proved, in one way, fortuitous. A few years into living in Caracas, Yaremy encountered the first hint that what had happened to her son had also happened to someone else. When picking up medication for Uli—Botox to relax his clenched muscles—she met another mother doing the same for her own son. The facts of his case sounded awfully familiar: anesthesia, delayed awakening, brain damage, loss of muscle control. The mother told Yaremy about a spate of anesthesia complications in the Venezuelan state of

Carabobo in the early 2000s, which were blamed on a contaminated batch of sevoflurane, then a fairly new anesthesia drug in the country. Her son, this mother said, was one such case.

Uli, too, had gotten sevoflurane during both surgeries. The colorless and faintly sweet gas has since become one of the most widely used anesthetics worldwide. But Uli's surgeries were two years apart and 5,000 miles away in Germany, which had had no reports of contaminated sevoflurane. Yaremy couldn't see how the incidents in Carabobo could be connected to her son's. Still, she filed them away in her mind.

Not long after, Yaremy began chasing down a second clue, which emerged as Uli's malpractice case wound its way through the German legal system. The lawsuit itself was unlikely to succeed, now that Uli had suffered the same complications under a different anesthesiologist, but an expert examining the facts of the case made a crucial observation: The two symmetrical white spots in Uli's basal ganglia, he said, looked much like the brain damage found in people with inherited mitochondrial disease.

Mitochondria are the tiny structures inside our cells that act as power generators. When they become dysfunctional, cells are first starved of energy; then they die. The most vulnerable cells are the most energy-hungry ones; neurons are particularly susceptible, especially those in the basal ganglia. In children with mitochondrial disease, neuron death can be triggered by physiological stress of any kind: fasting, illness, dehydration, and, yes, anesthesia. Perhaps the fault lay with Uli's mitochondria too.

In 2013, Yaremy managed to secure an appointment at a leading genetic-disease lab in Houston. She boarded the plane with Uli, convinced that the answer awaited them at their destination. There, specialists ran a series of blood tests on Uli and searched his DNA for mutations that cause mitochondrial disease. "I felt like I was going to see the light," Yaremy told me over breakfast in May. "But

nothing happened.” She sighed, her shoulders tense with disappointment.

The tests found no mutations known to cause mitochondrial disease. Moreover, Uli had never exhibited other symptoms; mitochondrial dysfunction affects numerous parts of the body, including the heart and muscles, and symptoms frequently manifest in childhood. Uli had been a healthy and energetic boy: walking before age 1, skiing at 3. Yaremy wondered if her son’s reaction to sevoflurane could be caused by a novel mitochondrial mutation. Uli remembers hearing the doctor, who did not know he understood English, mention her belief dismissively to his medical students.

Yaremy and Uli returned home to Caracas, where they had been building a new life. Uli enrolled at Venezuela’s largest university; using an eye-tracking device to communicate, he graduated with a degree in modern languages. Yaremy worked her way up to professor of medicine at the same university.

Then, in the mid-2010s, Venezuela’s petroleum-dependent economy cratered. Public hospitals lacked equipment as basic as disposable gloves; inflation soared to more than 1 million percent. Even with her connections, Yaremy began to struggle to obtain Uli’s medications. She decided in 2018 to uproot their lives once again, taking Uli back to Germany, where he could receive more reliable care.

By then, Yaremy was closer to finding the explanation for Uli’s condition than she knew. She already held key pieces of the puzzle. But it would take a second tragedy in her family for her to realize how they fit together.

In June 2020, Yaremy got a call from her younger cousin—and Uli’s godmother—María Fernanda Pozo Castillo, or Mafer. They are close, having grown up together in Caracas. Because Yaremy is the doctor in the family, Mafer told me, everyone bugs her with

their ailments. (“Yaremy, I have a headache,” she said, slipping into an imitation.) But she was calling about something much more serious. Her 13-year-old son, Matías, had just had knee surgery after a bike accident in Austin, Texas, and he’d struggled to wake up. He had gotten sevoflurane.

“Mafer, no!” Yaremy said.

Even as she began to relive the cold dread of waiting for Uli to wake up, Yaremy pulled herself into problem-solving mode. “Don’t leave the hospital without an MRI, okay?” she told her cousin. “If the doctor says it’s not necessary, it doesn’t matter. You demand an MRI.”

Mafer remembers that the doctors were reluctant to order a brain scan for her son—he’ll be kicking a ball again in three weeks, they told her. But she kept asking and asking until they acceded. Sure enough, the MRI—which was done without further anesthesia—showed two white lesions in the basal ganglia. “Same places,” Yaremy immediately said when she heard this. “Same places as Uli Gabriel.”

In the coming days, Matías started experiencing involuntary limb movement. He developed muscle contractions, even more severe than his older cousin’s, that left him screaming in pain. The contractions have persisted, even with high doses of muscle relaxant delivered straight to his spinal cord. This past summer, Matías’s pain became so excruciating that he had to be hospitalized in the ICU. His mother cares for him full-time. Before we spoke on the phone, she kept apologizing that she might need to leave at any minute to tend to him.

Yaremy was devastated for her family; so was Uli. “I wouldn’t wish it on anyone,” he told me when we met in the spring, tapping the sentence out letter by letter on a board that he uses to communicate.




Uli has been unable to walk or talk on his own since his second surgery. He uses eye-tracking devices and letter boards to communicate. (Julia Sellmann for *The Atlantic*)

Yet amid her grief, Yaremy's scientific mind got to work: One kid in her family? Okay, a fluke. But two? It had to be genetic. She thought of Uli's mitochondrial-DNA test from seven years earlier. The sequencing had found no mutations known to cause disease. But the report did note some "variants of unknown significance," including one called m.11232T>C, meaning that the 11,232nd letter of his mitochondrial genome had been altered from a T to a C. No one made much of the finding; all of us have variants of unknown significance in our genomes, most of which are of little

consequence, like minor typos that do not obscure the meaning of a sentence. But maybe this mutation was, in fact, significant.

Mitochondria carry their own loop of DNA, separate from the chromosomes that make up the rest of our genome, and are inherited through the maternal line. Yaremy's mother and Mafer's mother are sisters, so they and their children share the same mitochondrial line.

Could a single typo in their mitochondrial DNA be responsible for all of the catastrophic brain damage in the family? And what was the connection to sevoflurane?

Yaremy now began searching for a scientist to study her family. She suspected that Uli and Matías carried the same mutation, as might other relatives. Two of her mother's sisters, she realized, had also suffered complications after surgery that now seemed to trace back to anesthesia. Were others at risk too?

She found Julio Montoya, an expert in mitochondrial disease at the University of Zaragoza, in Spain, who saw her email in a waiting room as he was about to undergo emergency surgery for a detached retina. With his one good eye, he read it and replied immediately. He was keen to investigate.

Montoya and his colleague Eduardo Ruiz-Pesini had, it turned out, seen the m.11232T>C mutation before. In 2018, they had found it in a Venezuelan boy at a Barcelona hospital. This patient had become severely ill after surgery to remove his tonsils and adenoids —and deteriorated even further with subsequent rounds of anesthesia in later years. The Spanish team decided, along with Yaremy, to put together a formal research proposal. The boy from the Barcelona hospital would become patient one in their study; Uli became patient two, and Matías patient three.

Over the years, Yaremy had talked with colleagues in Venezuela about Uli so relentlessly that word sometimes came back to her of similar cases: nearly always kids, nearly always after routine surgery. An introvert by nature, Yaremy had to learn to badger anyone and everyone for a useful crumb of information.

She began running down some of these rumors: The wife of the son of a friend knew a neurologist who knew an anesthesiologist who knew of a boy who had fallen ill after surgery on a broken forearm. He became patient four. Patient five was the boy whose mother she'd met picking up Botox in Caracas. A physical therapist told her about a boy who'd had cleft-lip surgery—patient six. An old friend from medical school, an anesthesiologist, had examined a boy who developed symptoms after surgery for a cochlear implant. The friend had once been skeptical of Yaremy's theory, but now he helped her gather data. This boy became the seventh and final patient in the study.

All of the patients who ended up in the study were boys, but Yaremy heard of girls affected, too. For every patient she managed to track down, she followed other trails that ran cold. Families who'd filed lawsuits were reluctant to talk; others were lacking complete medical records. The allegedly contaminated sevoflurane in Carabobo, Yaremy learned, had been widely discussed among doctors at the time, but news coverage of the events 20 years ago had disappeared from the internet as a result of the regime's media crackdowns and poor digital recordkeeping. She managed to get hold of one newspaper article—a printout saved by the mother picking up Botox in Caracas. But she was not able to find any other families whose children had died or become disabled in Carabobo.

A haunting pattern appeared in the cases she was able to pull together. All seven patients in the study had received sevoflurane. Most of them could trace their maternal relatives to Carabobo; Yaremy's own maternal grandmother was from the state. And all seven had the same T-to-C mutation. This mutation is extremely

rare, even in Venezuela, but it is an estimated 15 times more prevalent in Carabobo, where it is believed to have originated many, many generations ago. The Spanish researchers hypothesized that this old mutation had taken on new, potentially fatal importance in the era of modern anesthesia.

General anesthesia today is usually achieved through a cocktail of drugs, both inhaled and intravenous. Of these, sevoflurane is one of the most popular, particularly for children. It is easy to administer, quick to work, and not irritating to the airways. But sevoflurane seemed to behave differently—and dangerously—in the presence of the T-to-C mutation.

To prove this, the Spanish researchers would need to collect cells with the mutation and subject them to sevoflurane in a lab. Yaremy volunteered her own. In the fall of 2024, she found a colleague to draw her blood and a lab to biopsy a ribbon of her skin. Her cells soon made it to Spain, where the team got to work.

As the lab experiments were ongoing last summer, tragic news came out of Chile. Five children there had suffered terrible outcomes after routine anesthesia; four were dead, according to an alert from the Chilean Society of Anesthesiology. All five children were Venezuelan.

The news spread within the Venezuelan diaspora. In the past decade, more than half a million Venezuelans have moved to Chile, where they have not always found themselves welcome. Now some of the parents alleged that poor medical care and discrimination had killed their children. They filed lawsuits and demanded justice on social media. In videos the parents shared of their children on Instagram and on TV, they are all bouncy and bright: a 4-year-old girl swinging in gymnastics class, a 2-year-old boy in a Messi jersey kicking a soccer ball.

Chilean investigators were able to collect genetic samples from only three cases—out of what had grown to a total of seven in the country—but all three patients had the same T-to-C mutation. One of the children who died in Chile, Yaremy later learned, was the cousin of a patient in her study. As word of the mutation spread around the world, doctors started reporting cases in the United States, Canada, Colombia, Peru, and Guyana.

“I suffered with each kid, each mother,” Yaremy told me. Even when a child survived, she saw ahead to their “lifetime of complications.” She often thinks about the boy with the cleft lip from her study, who, abandoned by his mother, lives in a poor village in Venezuela with his grandmother. His family can’t afford Botox or other treatments. In videos she has seen, his muscles are always clenched, his limbs unusable.

Back in Spain, the researchers raced to finish the experiments. They ultimately found that cells carrying the mutation were indeed hypersensitive to sevoflurane. This mutation could explain why Uli—and Matías and all the other children—had stayed unconscious for so long after surgery. The study, with Yaremy as a co-author, was the cover story of the June 2026 issue of *Anesthesiology*, the official journal of the American Society of Anesthesiologists. Accompanying it was an editorial written by two physician-scientists in the U.S., Richard Levy, at Stanford, and Philip Morgan, at Seattle Children’s Hospital.

I had first spoken with Levy a few months earlier, after the ASA issued an alert—following up on the one in Chile—about terrible complications from anesthesia, primarily sevoflurane, in people with maternal Venezuelan ancestry. In our conversation, I asked what seemed like a basic question: How does sevoflurane work? “If you can figure that out, you have a Nobel Prize,” Levy told me. “The reality is, we don’t know.” We don’t know how any inhaled anesthetics work. But this novel mutation out of Venezuela, he and Morgan thought, might hold a clue.



More than a decade after his injury, Uli became a case study in a scientific paper, co-authored by his mother, about how anesthesia interacts with a rare mitochondrial mutation. (Julia Sellmann for *The Atlantic*)

Anesthesia likely taps into something evolutionarily ancient in the body. A one-cell protozoan, a Venus flytrap, and a human are all susceptible to anesthesia—and two of those things don’t even have a brain.

For most of the 20th century, scientists clung to the idea that these drugs perturb the fatty membrane of living cells—a hypothesis based on how the gases behave in olive oil. But by the 1980s, a new dogma began to take hold: Anesthetics bind to proteins on the

surface of brain cells, which interrupts their signaling. This is best understood in a drug called propofol, which is a common anesthetic but not an inhaled one; the milky-white liquid is delivered via IV. In an elegant set of experiments in the 2000s, scientists identified propofol's primary target as a protein called the GABA receptor. Yet the same experiment, when repeated with a common inhaled anesthetic, failed to find an analogous target. Decades later, it remains elusive. Maybe it doesn't exist.

Today, the general consensus regarding the mechanism of inhaled anesthesia is that the gases bind weakly to many proteins in the brain, which together add up to complete loss of consciousness. Most practicing anesthesiologists don't think much about this. Sevoflurane works. The proof is in the operating room every day. What more do you need?

But a group of researchers dissatisfied with the conventional wisdom on proteins, including Levy and Morgan, has been slowly building the case for an alternative hypothesis: Actually, it's the mitochondria.

When these researchers heard about children with a mitochondrial mutation dying from anesthesia, they immediately saw the implications. Scientists have long relied on rare mutations to probe the mysteries of biology. In another Venezuelan state called Zulia, for example, families with a shared mutation for Huntington's disease have been crucial to our understanding of the condition. Rare mutations are a kind of natural experiment.

Morgan, along with his wife and scientific collaborator, Margaret Sedensky, had once run lab experiments looking for mutations that altered sensitivity to anesthesia—though only in a tiny, transparent worm called *Caenorhabditis elegans*. When they induced random mutations in the worm, they found that the relevant ones were clustered in the mitochondria. Their findings didn't make much of an impact among their fellow anesthesiologists, though. "We're

like the comic relief at our big national meeting of 15,000 anesthesiologists," Sedensky told me. "'Here come the worm doctors.'"

But Morgan and Sedensky kept working out the details of their theory. Inhaled anesthetics such as sevoflurane, they now argue, work by inhibiting the mitochondria, inducing a kind of temporary brownout in the brain. The bubbles used to transport brain chemicals become frozen in place, like cars that have run out of gas. They restart as soon as anesthesia is discontinued. But in some hypersensitive patients, the mitochondria could become so impaired that their brain cells die. Morgan had found some of these hypersensitive patients before, but he believes Uli's mutation could help pinpoint more precisely how anesthesia works on mitochondria. This past summer, cells with the mutation—derived from Yaremy's blood sample—arrived in the couple's lab in Seattle.

Understanding how anesthesia works, Levy told me, could enable scientists to design better drugs that precisely target the brain, without lingering side effects. Though modern anesthesia drugs are generally quite safe, they are imperfect. They affect the cardiovascular system; they affect ostensibly unrelated areas of the brain, such as the region that controls nausea. And they have been linked to cognitive decline in the elderly after surgery—though the degree to which the drugs are responsible, as opposed to other factors such as the physical effects of surgery, is still being debated. How much of that can be avoided?

Before her study was published, Yaremy had someone she needed to call: Ludwig Düthorn, Uli's anesthesiologist after the snowboarding accident. She had not seen Düthorn since testifying against him at the malpractice trial years earlier. She'd lost the suit; legally, he had already been absolved. Personally, she felt she had to apologize.

Düthorn was gratified to know what Yaremy had found, but even now, he told me, he feels a doubt gnawing at him in the operating room. Uli had a silent and novel mutation in his DNA. Could his next 14-year-old patient have a different one?

Cases like Uli's unsettle everyone they touch. In the 2000s, Rafael Legórburu, then an anesthesiologist in Caracas, treated a young boy who would not wake up after sevoflurane—a case he now suspects was connected to this mutation. The boy suffered profound brain damage. Legórburu still finds it difficult to talk about 20 years later. "I have a scar," he told me, "for the rest of my life." Today he lives in Spain, where he practices aesthetic medicine, administering Botox and fillers; he says he'll never touch sevoflurane again.

Doctors are now revisiting a number of old malpractice cases—some of which resulted in large settlements—that might be explained by the T-to-C mutation. An anesthesiologist whose hospital had settled one such case involving their patient told me they felt relieved, and vindicated. (They spoke with me on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized by the hospital to speak publicly.) At the same time, they could not entirely shake their sense of responsibility. "It was the worst experience of my life," they kept telling me.

A group of Venezuelan anesthesiologists—largely based in the U.S.—recently formed the Venezuelan Anesthesia Perioperative Risk society, or VAPOR, to raise awareness of the mutation among health-care workers, and to promote guidelines for screening and treating patients with maternal Venezuelan ancestry. A quarter of Venezuela's population—8 million people—has left the country in recent years, meaning the mutation is scattered more widely than ever. Yet within Venezuela, no lab is testing for it, and anesthesiologists do not routinely have access to the specialized equipment needed to administer anesthesia without inhaled gases.

Yaremy is working with scientists to continue studying the mutation, about which many questions remain: Do other anesthetic drugs, inhaled or administered via IV, pose a danger? Are children more vulnerable, or have we simply not looked hard enough yet in adults? The oldest known patient to be affected was 31 years old.

In her own life, Yaremy has finally found a measure of stability. She and Uli live in Radolfzell, a bucolic lakeside town in southern Germany, where she works at the cardiac-rehab hospital. It's calmer than the ICUs where she's worked in the past. "B-O-R-I-N-G," Uli joked, tapping out the letters in English. But the calm is welcome after years of upheaval. Uli has his own apartment and a rotating cast of full-time assistants; he works as a translator for medical records. (He is fluent in English, Spanish, and German.) He is a doting uncle to his niece and nephew, the children of his younger sibling, Levi.

The mutation still lurks in their lives. Both times after giving birth, Levi, who uses *they/them* pronouns, developed an infection in the uterus and needed surgery. Yaremy made sure that they did not get sevoflurane. But what about Levi's kids, who also have the mutation? What if they're rushed into emergency surgery on their own? Levi had closely followed the news of the children who died in Chile. "They could have been my kids," Levi remarked as we parted ways after a family lunch by the lake. The water was a brilliant clear blue that day; so was the sky.

A few days after I left Germany, Yaremy learned about a new suspected case: a 12-year-old boy who'd had trouble waking up after surgery in Caracas. "How can this still be happening?" Uli wrote to me. "I mean what the ****!?"



Uli and Yaremy now live in the lakeside town of Radolfzell, Germany. Uli works as a translator for medical records. (Julia Sellmann for *The Atlantic*)

Joana, Freddy Marquez's mom, first caught wind of the suspected mutation in the summer of 2025, when she heard on social media about the children who'd died in Chile. She, too, is originally from Venezuela. And she made the connection instantly. Months earlier, when Freddy had been hospitalized, his doctors had ordered a genetic test that turned up a variant of unknown significance. Freddy had the m.11232T>C mutation as well. This information never made it into his chart for the same reason Uli's mutation

wasn’t initially taken seriously: No one understood its importance at the time.

Joana began commenting about Freddy on every related post she could find. One by one, she linked up with others who told similar stories: another mother in Florida, the family of a girl who died in Houston, Yaremy’s cousin Mafer in Austin, and so on. Joana got added to a WhatsApp group for the parents in Chile, which has since evolved into a de facto global support group for parents of children with this rare mutation. Through the group, Joana also learned of Yaremy. They spoke for the first time in February, and recognized in each other a maternal instinct that is both steely and tender. “She was in tears,” Joana told me, “and I was in tears.”

In February, Joana appeared on Instagram Live in a zebra-print shirt to talk about Freddy, alongside other affected mothers. The zebra print was a reference to the old medical adage “When you hear hoofbeats, think horses, not zebras”—meaning: think of the common explanation, not the exotic one. But sometimes, it *is* zebras. Freddy died because what happened to him lay just outside medical knowledge. His particular mutation is rare, but encounters with the unknown in medicine are not. Joana was asking for some humility, some openness to the possibility of zebras. Since Freddy’s death, she has made advocating for people with rare mitochondrial conditions her life’s mission.

Joana can still picture him: swimming, playing basketball, riding “like crazy” on his bike as Gordito, his Alaskan malamute, raced alongside him. “His flipping dog is now chasing me wherever I go,” she said. And Joana continues to propel herself forward. She’s cold-calling researchers. She’s going to medical conferences. She’s offering up her own cells to study. She is keeping the promise she made to Freddy before he died.

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/anesthesia-brain-damage-death/688691/

# The Man Who Wanted to Understand Every Aspect of Jewish Life

**In the Pale of Settlement, the writer S. An-Sky made an ecstatic, obsessive attempt to wrap his arms around an entire people just as it was disappearing.**

by Gal Beckerman

Tue, 13 Oct 2026



*Updated at 5:24 p.m. ET on October 14, 2026*

# I. 2,087 Questions

The Pale of Settlement is teeming with ghosts, and why shouldn't it be? At the turn of the 20th century, some 5 million Jews lived in this region between the Baltic and Black Seas, and by 1945, almost all of them had been murdered. If they slouch now like scarecrows over the tilled black earth, or float between wooden shacks, or even peer over the shoulders of the babushkas selling neat piles of used clothes in front of the bus station in Rivne, this is to be expected. What I hadn't quite anticipated was just how many questions they had left unanswered—2,087 to be exact. A long list of queries covering nearly every particular of how they lived their lives, from circumcision to shiva, sat on my lap as I stared out the window on a 10-hour car ride from Warsaw to Kyiv, through the heartland of what was once the Pale.

31. Is there a belief that if a pregnant woman steps on the spot where a mare has rolled around, she will carry her child for 12 months?

269. With what do people frighten a child so that he will go to sleep more quickly?

1,280. Is it a custom to drink red liquor if the bride turns out to be a virgin?

1,281. Is it a custom to eat hard cheese if she is a virgin? What does this signify?

1,714. Do people ask for forgiveness from a dead child?

I was on my way to visit the archives, once thought lost, of the early-20th-century Jewish writer Shloyme-Zanvl Rapoport, better known by his nom de plume, S. An-sky. He was the author of this insanely granular questionnaire. I could have spent my car ride reading any number of other works by An-sky, who, among his

many eccentricities, had a touch of graphomania. His collected writing comprises 15 volumes. He left behind thousands of pages of diaries, essays, short stories, and plays, including his best-known work, *The Dybbuk*, a masterpiece of Yiddish theater. But I decided on the long list of questions because An-sky saw them as the culmination of his life's greatest endeavor: an ecstatic, obsessive attempt to wrap his arms around an entire people just as it was disappearing.

These 2,087 questions were the first part of his Jewish Ethnographic Program—and the only part that was published, in 1914, under the title *Der mentsh*, which simply means "The Person." (An-sky's introduction and questionnaire were translated into English by Nathaniel Deutsch and published in his book *The Jewish Dark Continent*.) "The Person" was the beginning of a survey that An-sky hoped would cover "every aspect" of Jewish life. "Death, life after death, demonology. Holidays, everyday life, abstract questions," An-sky wrote to a potential donor. "In short, we'll have over 10,000 questions." Looking out the window, I kept imagining a poor surveyor trudging through the mud of a shtetl with a clipboard, asking, *Do you have a couple of months to spare?*

Some of the questions are open-ended (897. How did people treat an old maid in the past, and how do they do so now?), but most are hilariously leading. Why would you ask, for example, whether children ever engaged in pranks like gluing their rabbi's beard to the table when he fell asleep (484) if you didn't already have intimate knowledge of such a beard gluing? In fact, An-sky had done his research. The questionnaire was the fruit of an ambitious ethnographic expedition that he'd carried out from the summer of 1912 to the onset of World War I, two years later.

This sort of ethnography is now a mostly outdated social science, a relic of an imperial age in which certain peoples, such as the Inuit, were unthreatening and near-extinct enough to be placed behind glass in a museum. But An-sky's was a kind of self-ethnography, a

work of salvage and redemption. He was born into the shtetl world in 1863 and grew up in the town of Vitebsk, in present-day Belarus (Marc Chagall's hometown as well). Raised in poverty by a single mother who ran a tavern, An-sky rebelled against tradition. In his late teens, he was expelled from a nearby shtetl for trying to persuade the young yeshiva boys he was tutoring to abandon their studies and become freethinkers. When he finally left the Pale, in his 20s, he intended never to look back. He began a peripatetic life as a revolutionary, working in salt mines in the Donbas region alongside Russian miners, living in Berlin and Paris and Bern, developing his writing and his political commitment to radical reform. This is what led him over time to ethnography, which was a way of elevating cultures that were being trampled by the Russian empire.

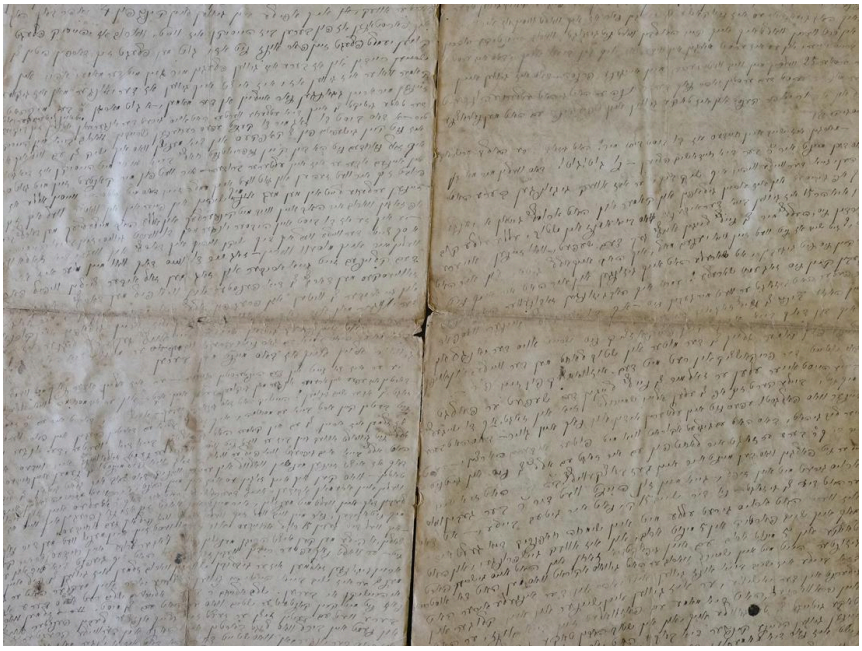
Only in his 40s did An-sky realize that the insular but vibrant world of the Jews could be the subject of such ethnography as well. "There is no people that has talked about itself as much and knows itself as little as the Jews," he wrote in his 1908 treatise "Jewish Folk Art." He may also have been thinking about himself, and the "emptiness" he frequently described in his letters. In 1912, he secured funding for an expedition from a financier, Baron Vladimir Gintsburg, and set out with a photographer and a musicologist—a small team that would grow the following year—to explore the Pale. Slogging through mud "so deep you could die" (as the Hebrew poet Haim Nahman Bialik put it), he gathered all he could, including songs—he brought along an Edison recording device that could capture sound on wax cylinders, making An-sky the Alan Lomax of the shtetl.

The final tally of what the expedition managed to collect after two years—visiting more than 60 towns and villages—gives a sense of An-sky's intense ambition: some 1,800 folktales, 1,500 songs, 1,000 melodies, 100 historical documents, 500 manuscripts, 700 sacred objects, and 500 wax cylinders of music.

An-sky didn’t intend for his collection to be a time capsule. He saw it as raw material that could help Jews build a secular national identity for themselves. But a time capsule is exactly what it became. Because in the years that immediately followed, the armies of Russia and Germany clashed in that mud, and each took its wrath out on the shtetl Jews, killing more than 100,000 of them; because Jews would leave the Pale after 1917 for cities such as Moscow, Berlin, and New York; because during World War II, the Nazis would bury what was left of this way of life in an archipelago of mass graves. What An-sky ended up collecting became not the mortar for building a modern Jewish culture, but shards from a now-extinct civilization.

The archives of this expedition had essentially vanished for most of the 20th century, and were rediscovered only after the end of the Cold War—mostly in St. Petersburg institutions and Ukraine’s national library. Now the country is in the fourth year of what Ukrainians uniformly refer to as the “full-scale invasion” (“war” would imply mutual aggression). With Kyiv under bombardment, a good number of the An-sky materials are again endangered.

I was traveling there to see what remained. The YIVO Institute for Jewish Research, a century-old organization now based in New York City that works to preserve Yiddish culture, had come to an agreement with the Ukrainian government to digitize An-sky’s papers. Jonathan Brent, a historian and the organization’s head, had invited me to tag along with him and his chief of staff on their trip to the country to make it official.



The handwritten manuscript of a story by An-sky in the Vernadsky National Library of Ukraine (Lesha Berezovskiy for *The Atlantic*)

There was a terrible feeling of continuity, heading into Ukraine right now for this purpose. An-sky was desperate to save all that was strange and beautiful about his people; Ukrainians have been dying for four years by the tens of thousands for largely the same reason. They are fighting to preserve their autonomy, which includes the uniqueness of their national and cultural identity—a front line that An-sky would recognize.

As he began his expedition at the end of June 1912, An-sky wrote a letter to Gintsburg, his benefactor, in which he felt compelled to spill out his feelings: “I am very nervous, as if standing before the great unknown. How will this all turn out?” Would these villagers regard him as an interloper, or one of their own? “And yet, at the same time, I have a great feeling of joy in my soul, that the most treasured dream of my life is beginning to come to fruition.”

## II. A Bird and a Cat

When I strode into the Vernadsky National Library of Ukraine, I assumed that the traces of An-sky’s expedition were mine for the

finding if I just asked nicely. I was wrong. What I discovered instead was the shabby attic fortress of the Judaica department and its head, Tetyana Batanova, who greeted me with pinched lips and a look of exasperation before I even opened my mouth.

I had originally thought the An-sky archives would be housed in the main branch of the Vernadsky, which I'd ogled online before arriving in Kyiv. This giant modernist slab of a building, which opened in 1989, seems frozen in late-Communist style, with rows of card-catalog drawers and socialist realist murals depicting proletarians plowing fields. In fact, the An-sky material, along with the rest of the Judaica collection, was located in a neoclassical relic, one of the original library buildings in the city's center. This was a musty edifice whose interior was painted a faded sky-blue. A grandfather clock sat at the top of a grand stairway, chiming every hour, beneath portraits of the library's elaborately bearded founders.

The Judaica department, tucked away on the top floor, was almost cozy by comparison. Houseplants crowded the windows. As I entered, along with the YIVO contingent, an air-raid siren went off. The Ukrainians in the room took out their phones, as though consulting a weather app. "There are 50 Shaheds, but not near us," one of the librarians said, tucking her phone back into her pocket. Drones rather than missiles. The tour continued.

The reason for Batanova's wariness of YIVO—and, by extension, me—seemed obvious. As the head of the Judaica department since 2019, she was protective of this material, which had barely survived the 20th century, and she did not seem all that excited to share it with outsiders who presumed they were its saviors. Brent saw his claim to An-sky's papers as part of his organization's mission to preserve Jewish heritage. Batanova saw the same papers as integral to Ukrainian heritage. These were not easily reconcilable positions. But Batanova's reaction was more than just

defensiveness. I also picked up another, conflicting emotion as she led us through the dilapidated stacks: shame.

One look at the large water stains on the ceiling—the roof had been leaking for years, Batanova told us—made it clear that the situation for these thousands of precious books and manuscripts was not great. Century-old newspapers were stacked on top of one another, moldering on shelves that seemed about to topple over. Batanova pointed out where flimsy blue and red construction-paper folders that held the An-sky material sat in the open. The building lacked any climate control. In the winter, the temperature inside dipped well below freezing, but that was better than the summer, Batanova said with a sigh. Humidity was the enemy of this yellowing paper. As we walked through, Brent muttered, “What a fucking *shande*.”

Wartime had not helped. In the fall of 2022, two cruise missiles slammed into the park across the street and a nearby intersection, killing several people and shaking the building. In early September, a missile struck within a few blocks of the archive’s many vulnerable windows. But limited resources had long been a problem. A researcher who worked there in the 1990s told me she’d been warned that she should bring her own toilet paper. I assumed she was describing a post-Soviet situation of economic hardship, but when I asked Batanova where the restroom was, she pulled a packet of Kleenex from her purse and handed it to me. As part of the deal with the Ukrainians, YIVO was going to pay the library—Brent wouldn’t tell me how much. In short, Batanova knew she needed help, but she didn’t want to need help.



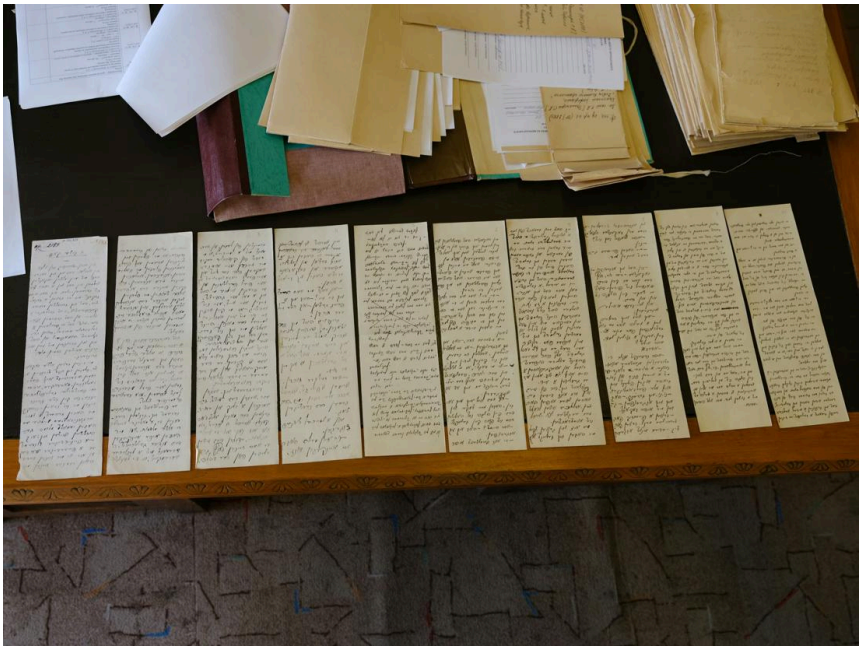
In the Judaica department of the Vernadsky, windows are covered with plastic sheeting to protect the material in case of missile attacks.  (Lesha Berezovskiy for *The Atlantic*)

Yet it was a miracle that anything had survived at all. In an academic article, Batanova's predecessor had described (with Slavic understatement) the "misadventures" of this archive. In 1929, when nearly 30 percent of Kyiv's population was Jewish, an Institute of Jewish Proletarian Culture was established with the goal of collecting every Yiddish periodical, book of poetry, newspaper, and manuscript it could get its hands on throughout the new Soviet empire. By 1934 it had more than 100 employees and housed a quarter of a million volumes—including the contents of

five suitcases and boxes that An-sky had left in his will to be preserved. Then, in 1936, as part of the Great Purge, Stalin shut the institute down and executed its founding director. Parts of the collection were carted away by the NKVD, the precursor to the KGB, or burned in the courtyard.

Not long afterward, the Nazis showed up. The occupiers looted what was left of the collection, which had been moved to the Vernadsky, stripping out valuable items to send to Berlin. After the war, the degradation continued. Stalin's 1949 anti-cosmopolitan campaign targeted Jews and Jewish institutions, and led to the killing of most of the Soviet Union's leading Yiddish cultural figures. Around this time, almost all of the Judaica collection was taken out of the library and hidden in the dank catacombs of the medieval Vydubetsk monastery, where it remained until 1968. From there, it was moved into a private basement, languishing until it was discovered in the 1990s and eventually transferred back to the Vernadsky.

Misadventures, indeed. After the YIVO folks left, I was alone with Batanova and her staff of four. Letting their guard down slightly, they began showing me An-sky items. In one folder were some drafts of short stories in his handwriting, including "*A goyisher kop*," a 1912 tale of a Jewish man who attempts to assimilate and pass as a Christian. An-sky's neat Cyrillic cursive slanted across long, thin strips of paper. The folders were full of such strips, pages that seem to have been sliced in half, apparently his preferred writing material. His signature was at the bottom of one page, with its idiosyncratic hyphen. (No one knows for certain where the hyphen came from; one of the many reasons An-sky offered throughout his life was that it was originally a printer's typo he'd found charming.)



An-sky preferred to write drafts and notes on long, thin strips of paper. (Lesha Berezovskiy for *The Atlantic*)

What I really wanted to see were notes from the expedition, but every request seemed to meet Batanova's resistance. When I mentioned this afterward to people familiar with the library, I was told that a Soviet attitude still prevailed in such institutions; the default was to withhold information. I started throwing more darts, asking for random folders. I saw some strips on which An-sky had jotted down legends he had heard about the Baal Shem Tov, the mystical 18th-century founder of Hasidism. These were surely from the expedition. One folder revealed a long numbered list of signs that would indicate the Messiah had arrived—including that children would spontaneously clasp hands and start to dance.

I asked to see the wax cylinders and Batanova said no, they were too delicate. At this point I started to worry that coming all the way to Kyiv had been a mistake—if there were ghosts here, they were definitely in those cylinders. When I had spoken with Lyudmila Sholokhova, the musicologist who'd helped discover the abandoned recordings in the early 1990s, she described the first time she heard them as a moment of total awe. "I still remember the shock when actually hearing the voices and laughing and

coughing. It was super exciting. People would introduce themselves, saying their name and how old they are, and then they would start to sing.”

But Batanova said that every time the original cylinders were played, they degraded. The best she could do was bring me one of the canisters in which they were packaged. I gazed into the darkness of the empty beer-can-size receptacle with EDISON written on the side in large letters, next to a photo of the inventor. This was what anticlimax looked like.



Tetyana Batanova, the head of the Judaica department at the Vernadsky (Lesha Berezovskiy for *The Atlantic*)

What about some of the *pinkassim* that An-sky had collected? These were local record books, some of which went back hundreds of years. The historians I'd talked with before I left for Ukraine told me they were probably the most precious items I could see at the library. Batanova brought out three from the town of Berdichev, part of the 109 in the collection. The pages were covered in calligraphic Hebrew script. One book was from a "Brotherly Love Society," which a group of tailors established in the mid-19th century. It included bylaws and some fantastic illustrations, among them a drawing of a lion wrestling a snake.

The reading room was about to close for the day. As Batanova began gathering up the folders, a photograph slipped out of one of them. It was of An-sky—a strange picture. He is standing in a street, squinting into the sun, wearing a black coat and vest. His salt-and-pepper goatee, thick swept-back hair, and dreamy look give him the appearance of a Jewish Don Quixote. But the strangest thing about the photo is that he is cradling a cat in his arms while a bird is sitting on his shoulder. Everyone, even these two enemies, looks copacetic and calm.

From the January/February 2024 issue: Judith Shulevitz on Ukraine's "zombie history"

## III. A Severed Finger

Somehow this photo of An-sky managed to make me forget my frustration, because it revealed something of his magic. He got people (and apparently animals) to relax in his presence. Those who traveled with him from shtetl to shtetl said he was often mistaken for a holy man. He was 48 when the expedition began but looked like he was in his 60s, which, as one of his biographers pointed out to me, was actually a benefit: Being preternaturally aged was a sign among rabbis of God's grace.

An-sky lived a vagabond existence from the time he was a teenager. “I have neither a wife, nor children, nor a house, nor even an apartment, nor belongings, nor even any settled habits,” he once admitted. On the expedition, he developed a method for quickly gaining trust. He would show up at synagogues and study houses to pray with the local men, disarming them. A crowd would usually gather around him after the service and then follow him to the local inn where the expedition members were staying. Abraham Rekhtman, who joined the group in its second year, recorded his memories nearly 50 years later, describing how, “over a glass of tea or, more often than not, a shot of liquor and a bagel for a snack, An-sky would at last ask questions.” On his long strips of paper, he would jot down stories and sayings and local legends.

His most successful technique, however, was to bring out the phonograph. The shtetl folk may have heard of such machines, but most had not seen one before. An-sky would demonstrate by recording a familiar song but coughing or laughing or making a mistake halfway through. He would then play the cylinder back and watch the mouths drop as they heard the recital, coughs and all. This was enough to break the ice, and men would then offer up wedding songs, lullabies, and wordless melodies called *nigunim*. I’ve now heard dozens of these digitized recordings, and they are eerie and sublime and a little sad. To take one example, Shloyme Kulish, a 24-year-old shopkeeper from Ludmir, was recorded singing on July 17, 1913. For 36 seconds, you can hear him lose himself in a song that sounds, as many of them do, halfway to a sob: *Oh dey dey mama mey / Oh dey dey mama mey*.

An-sky was particularly interested in healers and exorcists, mostly older women, who seemed to hold a special power in every town and village. Rekhtman described them in his memoir as performing “magic with knives, socks and combs; they poured wax and poached eggs and knew hundreds of ways to cure a patient.” They also closely guarded the secrets of their spells, amulets, and remedies. An-sky would often invent a tale of catastrophic bad

luck, explaining that he had once been a rich man—and now look at him! He could pay to reverse the curse. The healer would usually pity him and oblige, for a fee. The incantation would then get written down and added to the collection.

Out of an intense desire to save all that he was seeing, An-sky also started to gather artifacts, whether intricately embroidered kippahs or ritual objects such as the silver plaques used in synagogues to indicate east, the direction of prayer. The *pinkassim* I saw fell into this category. I also saw an album he'd made that included pages from illustrated Passover Haggadahs; some of these booklets dated back to the 16th century. No manner of ephemera was too small for him. Somewhat blasphemously, he even collected *kvitlekh*, the little notes left on the graves of famous Hasidic rabbis by people asking for intercession on their behalf. When young Jewish men were called up to serve in the czarist army, they sometimes tried to avoid the draft by cutting off a finger. But they usually saved these, because Jewish law demands that a body be buried intact. An-sky met an old man in Proskurov who sold him his own finger, severed when he was a teenager. It was to be displayed in a planned ethnographic museum.

An-sky managed to persuade people to part with their songs and community records and even fingers not just because he was charming or because he could pay well—though both were true. I imagine that people felt safe with him because they sensed that he was recovering pieces of himself. There aren't too many firsthand accounts of An-sky doing his collecting, but I like what this little tidbit from Shmuel Shrayer, a member of the expedition, reveals: "Our phonograph stood in the corner and recorded the Hasidic melodies with all the 'bimbumim.' Sometimes An-sky would get into the groove and he would sing along like one of them."

IV. Sem Sorok

On my second morning in Ukraine, I woke up to a video of a buzzing kamikaze drone careening into the side of a building in the center of Lviv, exploding in a bloom of flames and debris. The attack had taken place the previous day and nearly destroyed the city's historic archive. The sirens I had heard while touring the Judaica collection were part of Russia's biggest air assault on Ukraine since the start of the invasion, involving nearly 1,000 drones and 34 missiles. Lviv's archive, which caught fire, holds some of the oldest documents relating to Ukrainian history, including three 12th-century manuscripts composed on birch bark.

I happened to have an appointment with Anatolii Khromov, the head of the Central State Historical Archives, who showed up with his tie loosened and nervously sucking on a cigarette. The Lviv attack had left him in shock, he said. We met on the outskirts of Kyiv, where the country's main archives are kept, and he pointed to an enormous construction site nearby, where an underground bunker was being built to safeguard the collection. "We need to build faster," he said.

Later, in the center of the medieval Kyiv neighborhood of Podil, I noticed a small tower of wooden panels protecting a statue from shrapnel. Peeking through the cracks, I saw the bronze face of the Ukrainian philosopher Hryhorii Skovoroda. For Ukrainians, the stakes in this conflict are nothing less than their survival as an intact culture. Russia is not just a military aggressor; its invasion is premised on the idea that Ukraine doesn't even exist.

Oksana Semenik, a young art historian, has made it her mission to "decolonize" Ukrainian art, using social media and podcasts to revive the works of forgotten Ukrainian artists, but also to reclaim cultural figures such as the painter Kazimir Malevich, who has long been considered Russian despite his Ukrainian roots. In Ukrainian House, an enormous concrete structure once known as the Lenin Museum that felt like the inside of a missile silo, she showed me around an exhibit of early-20th-century modernist paintings by

Ukrainian women. Semenik seemed to apologize for the sparseness of the paintings and drawings. “We are lucky to have what we have,” she said. Most of these painters’ work was suppressed or destroyed during the Soviet period.

Her desperation to salvage Ukrainian culture is not that far off from An-sky’s efforts to rescue his own. “With every old man who dies, with every small-town fire, with every exile, a piece of our past is lost, and the most beautiful expressions of traditional life, with its customs, traditions, and beliefs, disappear,” An-sky wrote in the foreword to his questionnaire. When I mentioned this parallel to her, Semenik stopped walking and looked at me intensely. “When I was young, it shocked me whenever I thought about the Jews who once lived here,” she said. “The idea that a whole people could just disappear. Could a people just disappear?”

Despite a history of murderous anti-Semitism on the part of Ukrainian nationalists, the country’s current vision of national identity is a pluralistic one that includes Jews—such as Volodymyr Zelensky, the country’s wartime president. Semenik told me about a new show she was curating for Ukrainian House about Chernobyl, with the goal of changing the perception that the city is defined only by the nuclear disaster that occurred there. It was also once a major spiritual center of Hasidism.

Seeing Ukrainian history through a Jewish lens means clashing with some patriotic narratives. On his expedition, An-sky collected traumatic stories about 17th-century massacres carried out by the Cossack leader Bohdan Khmelnytsky, which killed tens of thousands of Jews. Many shtetls preserved similar legends about a local couple about to be married who were murdered together by Khmelnytsky’s men, and whose common grave became a talisman. But for Ukrainians, Khmelnytsky is no villain. He led an uprising in 1648 that established the Cossack Hetmanate, the first independent Ukrainian state. A region of the country is named after

him, and an enormous statue of him on a rearing horse stands in the center of Kyiv. My hotel was on Khmelnytsky Street.

When I returned to the Judaica reading room the next day, Batanova had warmed a bit. She even let me see the wax cylinders after I put my hands together in supplication. I went down to another, freezing room in the Vernadsky; signed a number of ledger books so that I could be granted admittance; and then saw dozens of smooth black tubes, kept in the kind of wooden crates in which you might store paint cans.

I asked Batanova whether her family and friends thought it was strange that, as an ethnic Ukrainian, she had devoted her life to Jewish culture, becoming a teacher of Yiddish and a keeper of this Judaica collection. Yes, she said, some members of her family did think it was pretty odd. An encounter with Yiddish as a student had changed her life. After years of trying to master German and failing, she took a Yiddish class. It was “like my language,” she said. “I understand the humor and the pain of this language. It’s in its structure. It’s in everything.” She smiled. She also felt a kinship between Yiddish and Ukrainian, two languages that she learned had both been dismissed by Russian imperial officials as *zhargon*, or “jargon”: disposable dialects.

Jewishness was part of Ukrainianness, she insisted. It shows up everywhere. In the 2000s, she traveled all over Ukraine to explore Jewish cemeteries, reading the lost histories of those towns on the tombstones. She also found artifacts with “Hebrew words or sayings incorporated in local Ukrainian.” Batanova told me about a dance that is popular at Ukrainian weddings, Sem Sorok, which sounds like traditional Jewish klezmer music—even though the people dancing in the middle of a circle holding a handkerchief between them have no idea about its origins. *Sem Sorok* means “7:40”; this was the name given to a commuter train that once arrived daily at that time in Odesa, bringing Jewish merchants

home from all over the country. On YouTube, I found a video of a Ukrainian teenager with a blue mohawk breakdancing to the tune.

## V. A Lullaby

On my third and last day in Kyiv, the archive began to satisfy my demands that it speak to me. This was not a foregone conclusion, even now that I had Batanova's help; so much had gotten lost and scattered over time, and An-sky's expedition itself had been cut short by war. Rekhtman, the member of the group who later wrote a memoir, remembered all he had to leave behind when he fled rampaging Ukrainian militias in 1915. "I did not manage to take along with me the great collection of ethnographic pictures (approximately 1,500), as well as the few hundred journals containing notes on the expedition. Everything remained in my hometown Proskurov," he wrote, and the material "vanished" during the anti-Jewish violence that convulsed Ukraine after World War I.

I was operating somewhat blindly in this huge archive, and my requests to see more and more items in the hope that An-sky's expedition might come into view were met with some distress. "How long are you in Kyiv?" a few of the librarians asked me, anxiously. Soon I came across what appeared to be a dirty little saying jotted down in a notebook: "When I become drunk from the liquor, a pretty girl is essential" (this sounds funnier in Yiddish, because the words for "drunk," *shiker*, and "essential," *iker*, rhyme). Then I began opening folders that contained hundreds of pages of what appeared to be lyrics, which one of the expedition's musicologists had neatly transcribed in small notebooks. Immediately, I encountered yearning. One song was attributed to a 24-year-old man named Dovid Keller:

> Ach, there in the woods stands a tree,
> The tree is bent and stooped
> And there and there stands a lover

With two eyes filled with tears

Ach, there and there stands a vineyard
The vineyard has not yet been reaped
I wasted the years of my youth
Like a gambler with playing-cards

A gambler who plays, plays to win
Plays his cards with the goal of a win
I have lost the years of my youth
I will never win them again.

There were a number of lamentations like this: songs of longing, of lost love. And a few truly tragic and disturbing ballads, such as one that seemed like it could have been sung by Johnny Cash, about a boy who follows a girl he loves “one nice night on a summer’s day” and demands to know if she will marry him. Her parents forbid the match:

As soon as he heard this,
He got very upset
He took out a revolver
And shot her on the spot.

When he shot her like that
She fell like a stone
He then turned the gun around
And shot himself alone.

I also liked the lullabies, because I could picture a mother or father rocking a baby to them. This one, a lullaby within a lullaby, was attributed to a man named Hersh Perlokh Kaliker:

In the Holy Temple in a corner
The widow Bas Tzion sits alone
She rocks her only son, Yidel

And sings him a beautiful lullaby:

La la la Yidel’e, when you become a rich Yidel’e
You should remember this little song:
Raisins and almonds, that will be your trade,
Sleep, my dear Yidel’e, sleep. Sleep, dear Yidel’e, sleep.

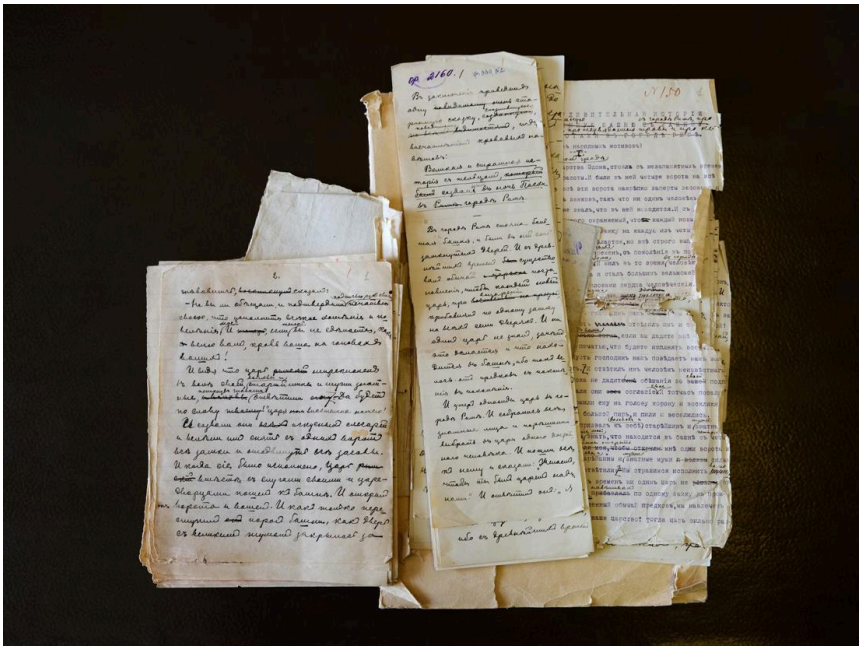
Here was the treasure I was after, distinct voices from that lost, muddy world. (The translator Rose Waldman helped me reveal more of their color.) They should have been strange and unfamiliar, but they weren’t really. The emotions were so everyday, so known. I’m sure every culture that ever was had versions of songs carrying these sentiments—the desire to matter, to find love requited, to get a baby to fall asleep.

An-sky didn’t focus on the universal, though. What felt exhilarating to him about his discoveries in each of these shtetls (“The happiness I feel from this work is limitless,” he wrote) were the inventive ways Jews confronted the human condition—all those ditties and amulets and dirty jokes. I looked through a collection of the photographs taken on the expedition, the originals of which are in St. Petersburg: a man transporting matzah on his back in a large wicker basket. A circle of schoolchildren during recess. A rabbi, with his long white beard, lying down for a nap. Taken by the photographer Solomon Yudovin, these images are incredible. But they don’t move me in the same way as the songs, because the photos are passive; they tell us what people wore, how they worked, and how deep that mud actually was. But folk culture is active—the record of how grief could transform into the stitch on a white burial shroud, how joy could turn into a rhyme belted out by children to accompany the skipping of stones across a lake.

When An-sky was in his 20s, working in the mines of the Donbas, he began writing down the songs that miners invented to pass the time. Even though these men had been uprooted from their villages —“some kind of nomadic tribe, torn away from one shore but not

having reached the other”—they were meeting their new reality by generating new culture, an act of adaptation. When he finally returned to the shtetls on his expedition, this was what he understood ethnography to be: capturing the product of this living process. Never given to understatement, An-sky said that he was gathering nothing less than “another Torah, an Oral Torah,” one that was “on par with the Book, with the great Written Torah.” What Jews normally called “oral Torah” referred to the history of rabbinic interpretation and reinterpretation of the biblical laws, recorded in works such as the Talmud. An-sky used the term to refer to something else entirely, created by “the people, themselves, especially the common folk.” This oral Torah “reflects the same beauty and purity of the Jewish soul, the gentleness and nobility of the Jewish heart, the height and depth of Jewish thought.”

What I’d finally seen at the Vernadsky were remnants of this Torah. Batanova, who wore white gloves as she carefully flipped each page, certainly would understand this. YIVO would as well, because this justified the great effort of digitizing it all. It suddenly seemed right that the transcription of a song sung more than 100 years ago and preserved in a little blue notebook should be the subject of such competing attentions. When I made my way down the linoleum hallways of the library for the last time, I had a strange, An-sky-inspired urge: to go back and kiss the thin pages I’d just seen. Every Jew knows, after all, that when you come across a Torah, this is what you do.



Notes from S. An-Sky's archive, stored in the Vernadsky National Library of Ukraine (Lesha Berezovskiy for *The Atlantic*)

VI. The Tightrope Walker

An-sky wrote *The Dybbuk* while on the road, in trains and horse-drawn carts, pouring into it the same curiosities and artifacts that went into his 2,087 questions. I chose to read the play on my return trip to Warsaw, which included an eight-hour wait to cross the Ukrainian-Polish border. The alternative title of *The Dybbuk* is *Between Two Worlds*, and that is how I felt while idling in line with dozens of other cars. The eerie dialogue of the play only heightened the sense of being in-between. As the young bride, Leah, is about to be possessed by a dybbuk, a demon, she says to her old nurse, "They are here with us. A person is born to live a long life. But if he dies before his time, what happens to his unlived life, his joys and his sorrows, the ideas he did not have time to develop, the deeds he had no chance to do? What happens to the children who were to have been born to him? What are they? Where?"

*The Dybbuk* depicts the shtetl as a place saturated in magic, where the dead mingle with the living. A poor young student named Khonon is disturbed that Leah, the woman he loves and believes he

is cosmically fated to marry, has been betrothed to another man. Khonon pursues all kinds of magic to stop the wedding. But, as he says, “they didn’t help—not the fasts, not the ablutions, not the mortifications of the flesh, not the kabbalistic spells!” He dies from the intensity of these efforts and returns as a spirit to possess Leah’s body. The last two acts of the play are an extended exorcism, a ritual that An-sky must have observed.

The stories and customs gathered from the expedition are present in nearly every line of the play—one critic dismissed it as simply “an ethnographic museum.” I even found in it a story I’d seen on one of those thin strips in An-sky’s own hand, one of the many legends he collected about the Baal Shem Tov. In it, the Hasidic sage joins a crowd to watch an acrobat do a tightrope act. His students wonder why the rabbi is paying attention to such silly entertainment, and he answers, “I came here to observe how a person crosses a deep abyss. And as I watched I thought: If a person were to put as much effort into developing his soul as he does into training his body, how many and what deep abysses would his soul be able to traverse on the slender thread of life.”

*The Dybbuk* is much more than a patchwork of archives, a way of preserving the oral Torah. It also expresses the horror of experiencing a world in collapse. When I watched the 1937 film version produced in Poland, I jumped at the moment the possessed Leah, about to be wed, shrieks in a voice that is not her own, “You are not my bridegroom!” This cry of dislocation could be An-sky’s primal scream, addressed to modernity itself—to the waves of murder to come. “We are too late,” Reb Azriel, the exorcising rabbi, says as he rushes into the synagogue in the last moments of the play, to find Leah dead.

When the First World War broke out, in the summer of 1914, An-sky got himself commissioned by a relief organization to embark on a new kind of expedition, working frantically to save Jews trapped in the crossfire between German and Russian forces. What

he witnessed, and then recorded in a four-volume diary published with the title *The Destruction of Galicia*, was apocalyptic. Hundreds of thousands of hungry refugees, bodies strewn in the streets of abandoned shtetls, survivors of rape, synagogues burned to the ground—and in places where he had been just a year before, recording songs on his phonograph. In a photo from this time, he is dressed in a uniform with a fur hat on his head and a Red Cross armband over his coat. He looks ancient, and exhausted. An-sky also never stopped trying to save Jewish culture. In Lutsk, which I passed on my drive out of Ukraine, he encountered the frazzled remnants of the community, which had become a "ghost town," he writes, and they handed him a trunk filled with objects from the synagogue, including a silver Torah crown from the 18th century and a gold-embroidered curtain for the ark. An-sky managed to get them to St. Petersburg.

In the upheavals of 1917, he would lose track of these items from Lutsk and almost everything else he collected from his travels. He had to leave behind even his draft of *The Dybbuk*. The first phase of the Russian Revolution actually found An-sky elected to the Russian Constituent Assembly as a Socialist Revolutionary, representing his hometown of Vitebsk. But when the Bolsheviks took power in the fall, he had to flee, first to Vilnius and then to Warsaw. He was already battling heart disease and diabetes, and in November 1920, just after a meeting of a new ethnographic society he was trying to form in the Polish city, he died of a heart attack. He was 57. He did not live to see the worst of it.

I can't think of a better testament to An-sky than his play, and I am struck by the self-awareness in that title, *Between Two Worlds*. He had himself traveled as deftly as a tightrope walker between two worlds—Jewish and secular, traditional and modern—but he also witnessed the passing of one world into another, and it made him determined to hold on to what he came to understand mattered most, and to avoid the abyss. I spent most of my short time in Kyiv frantically trying to put some flesh on those ghosts. As I waited for

the border to open, it occurred to me that maybe this manic urgency was what brought me closest to An-sky.

Will the Ukrainians fare better? I hope so. Struggling to keep fighting, dodging missiles, surviving, gets you only partway there. An-sky recognized this. Writing in 1916, looking back on his travels through lands now decimated, he still held on to the truth of his expedition: “A nation lives not in suffering, but in the ecstasy of the realization of its ‘I,’ in joyful creation, in pride in its culture, in the poetry of its daily life. Only in that.”

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*This article has been updated to acknowledge the work of Nathaniel Deutsch, whose book* The Jewish Dark Continent *contains the only English translation of An-Sky’s questionnaire. The article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline “Ghosts of the Pale.” When you buy a book using a link on this page, we receive a commission. Thank you for supporting* The Atlantic.

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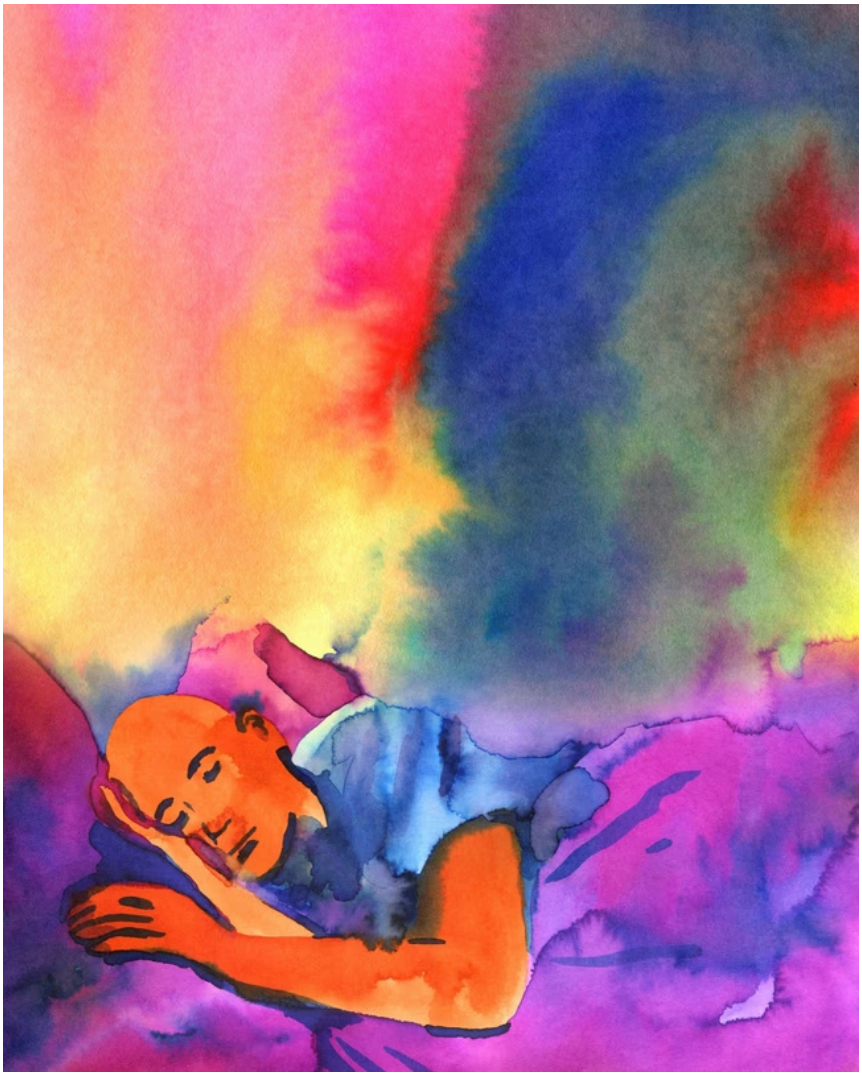
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# What Were My Dreams Trying to Tell Me?

**To make sense of my deepest experiences, I needed a new way of talking about the soul.**

by Ayad Akhtar

Mon, 21 Sep 2026



When I was 20 years old, I started to sense a hole inside me. The feeling was utterly concrete, though the result of no medical condition that any of the various doctors I saw could identify. The hole felt like a viscous emptiness—a paradox, admittedly, as any

real emptiness should have felt like nothing. This was a nothing, but its nothingness very much felt like something—and something that was growing.

Accompanying this feeling of an expanding hole at the center of me was a sense that I was losing more and more of myself to it, like shoreline eroded by rising waters. To lose myself felt less like oblivion than instability. I observed in myself a new susceptibility to the opinions of others, and a new recklessness, as if some dark, decisive action might either quiet my doubts about my fundamental worth or end my longing once and for all. I recall one particularly dangerous, drunken night that had me well over the legal limit, both aware that I was getting into a car that could kill me and others, and also not believing that any of it mattered.

The onset of my devolving well-being was strange and sudden, and seemed connected to childhood in some way I couldn't understand. I hadn't been a tortured child but rather placid, if introverted. My parents always said that I had been easy to keep happy. It sometimes seemed to me as if the hole I was experiencing was one where some piece of my childhood had once resided.

My friends found my behavior disturbing. I was missing class in college, showing up to theater rehearsals drunk. A caring young woman I was dating could take no more of my savage, ranting mood swings and persistent despair. She broke up with me over tea at the student union and implored me to seek help. I knew she was right. Even sleep was now fraught with violent, terrifying dreams—of rocket ships out of control, conflagrations and invasions, and, yes, holes into which I would disappear. But exactly what sort of help I might need, I didn't know.

I confided my woes to a friend who'd grown up on a farm in Kentucky. He never missed Sunday Mass, and when I told him about the hole inside me, he pulled a copy of *The Seven Storey Mountain* from his bag and handed it to me. Thomas Merton, he

said, had written about something similar. It was what had led him to leave the world and become a monk.

I found deep resonance in the book's harrowing account of Merton's time at Cambridge and Columbia—the intense restlessness and emptiness, the disgust and torpor and despair. But Merton's solution was theistic: a turn to God that I could only read as naive and distorting. I didn't have any interest in God. Even the passages that approached the specificity of my own experience were charged with personification that read as anachronistic at best:

> The room was very quiet. It was rather dark, too. And as I lay in bed, in my weariness and pain and disgust, I felt for a moment the shadow of another visitor pass into the room.
>
> It was death, that came to stand by my bed.
>
> I kept my eyes closed, more out of apathy than anything else. But anyway, there was no need to open one's eyes to see the visitor, to see death. Death is someone you see very clearly with eyes in the center of your heart: eyes that see not by reacting to light, but by reacting to a kind of a chill from within the marrow of your own life.

I knew this experience: a central chill, a lightlessness connected to the doomed feeling of some ultimate end. But I resisted any characterization that departed from the fundamental sensation itself—of a growing hole inside me. For no reason I knew, I was convinced that remaining honest with myself about this basic fact was the only thing I could do to help myself.

My parents were worried. They flew out to visit me at school and figure out what was wrong. Over a meal they prepared for me in a hotel room with a kitchen, I confided in them. There was a hole inside me that I needed to address, I said. They were understandably perplexed. My mother found me a psychiatrist, an

avuncular Brit who was more interested in my sex life than my interior void, which I insisted was more real than he seemed willing to allow. But something important endured from the handful of sessions I had with him. A volume on the shelf over his left ear drew my fascination, and would soon fill weeks of my life: Freud's *The Interpretation of Dreams*.

That book began a process in me, what I've often called "curiosity" when I've told this story, but which is probably better described as a form of relationship. The nightly tumult of disturbing dreams persisted, and even if I couldn't be sure whether Freud was right about how to make sense of them, simply attempting to do so seemed to help. Paying attention made it easier to remember my dreams, and to remember more of them. In one, I was carefully drawing an empty circle on a page of the Quran that my grandparents had given me as a boy, a circle through which—impossibly—I could reach and touch cool water. I awoke with the feeling that the hole inside me might be leading to something better, however unknown.

Even so, it wasn't until I mentioned that I was interested in dreams to a teacher I admired that I started to keep a detailed nightly log. This teacher had done a great deal of dream-work, and suggested that I tie a pencil to my finger to remind me, in those brief moments of stirring between sleep cycles, to write down whatever fragments were stirring in hypnagogic consciousness. So I did. What resulted was a daily haul of interior riches. The vividness of my unadulterated hopes and sorrows, the unusual expansiveness and wonder I experienced by night, lived on in the often-paradoxical images I would recall throughout the day.

My study of Freud led to a similar scouring of the work of other psychoanalysts—and, later, mystics such as Emanuel Swedenborg, Ibn Arabi, and Rabbi Nachman—for clues about what kind of sense to be making of my dreams. In my final year of college, I encountered, in a late work of Carl Jung's, the advice to treat

dreams as meaningful psychic events, a technique to facilitate what Jung called their “compensatory” function—balancing the biases and limitations of one’s conscious attitudes. I took this to mean treating a dream’s images as real in their own right. Whether doing so had any such balancing effect on me, I can’t be sure. But my persistent despair seemed to be dimming; the hole inside me felt different the more I was able to gaze patiently into it for whatever was coming through. The dream-work was paying dividends, though what exactly was paying them out, I had no clue.

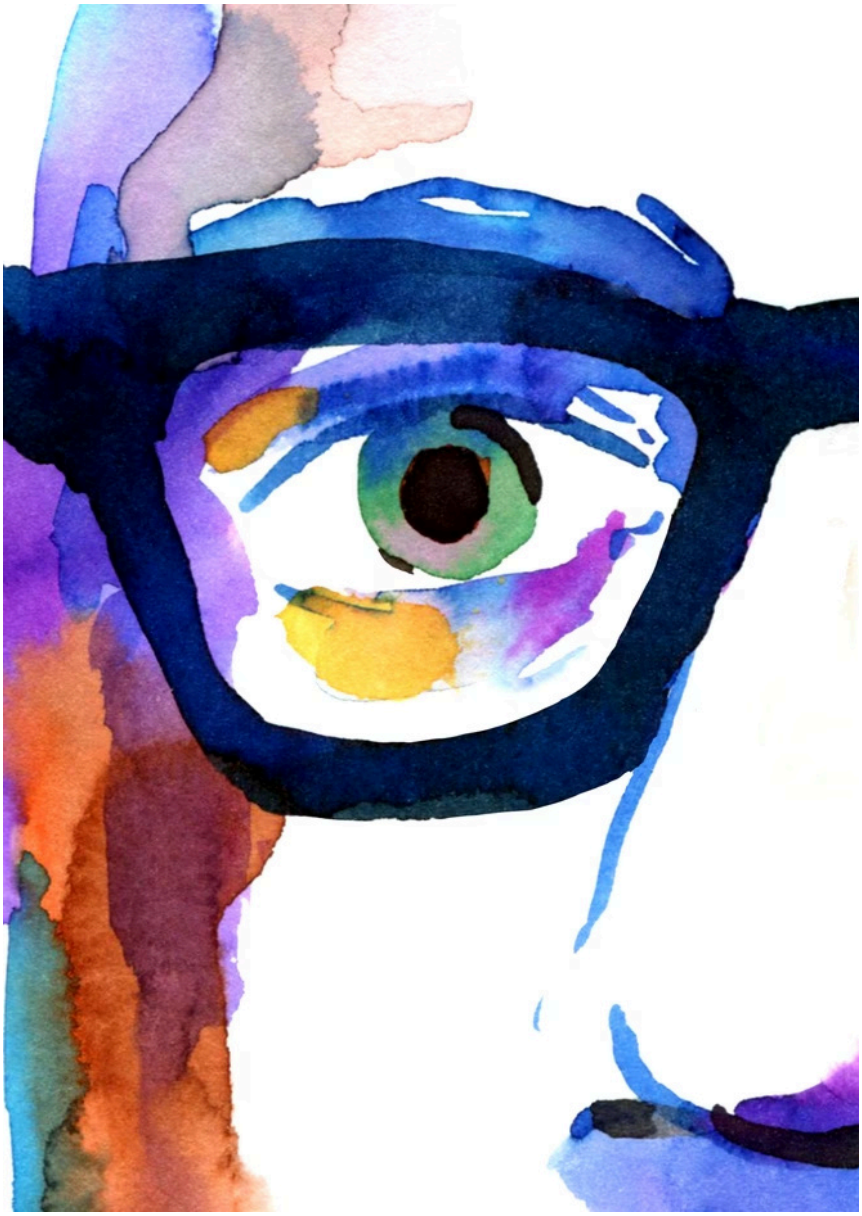


Illustration by Hélène Blanc

I know how what I'm about to share is likely to come off; it isn't the first time I've spoken it aloud. I started to dream of things that hadn't happened yet, to "see" things at night that then appeared in my life during the day. One of the earliest and most startling of these uncanny doublings took place in my first year after college. I was living and working in a small town in the Tuscan countryside, without a phone, before the internet. I dreamed that a friend I knew in Paris showed up on my doorstep with skis on his back. Two days later, I awoke to the sound of my name being called from down in the piazza, outside my front window. I opened the worn balcony doors to find the very friend I'd dreamed of; he'd gotten my Italian address from a mutual friend and seen that the town I was living in wasn't too far out of the way as he made the trip from Rome up to the city in the Alps where he planned to spend a few days skiing. I resisted speaking of what had happened, lest I be impelled to name whatever in me had seized my bewildered attention.

The Tuscan episode was not the last time dream and day seemed to cross wires. Years later, I would dream of a terrorist attack on Manhattan two days before 9/11, and of a malign, cough-inducing fog slowly engulfing the world several weeks before the eruption of the coronavirus into my (and the world's) awareness—improbable coincidences I struggled to accept as such. And yet, these visions became the occasion to doubt any picture of the universe that failed to make room for what could only be experienced as a kind of magic.

If the prognosticating mode had been the only benefit to accrue from my attention to my dreams, I might not have been so diligent in my recordkeeping. After all, I wasn't seeing stock prices or lottery numbers, the only rationale many might have accepted for my habit of destroying every good night's rest. For at that point, I was waking up every 45 minutes to reach for the bedside pad on which I made notes about whatever was moving around inside me. But my night work was opening up creative vistas. One mentor, well-versed in working with the unconscious, suggested that it was

enlarging the space of what she kept calling—despite my confusion about what she really meant by it—my psyche.

Read: *McNeal*, a play by Ayad Akhtar

Indeed, a growing spaciousness was now my sense of the interior core where the hole had opened up. The hole itself wasn't gone, but it had changed character, less a wound now than an opening, though I couldn't always tell the difference. And yet, the trajectory seemed to be shifting. That pliant, receptive brightness bearing the imprint of something more than just my name, the self, began to feel heightened, enlarged. I had learned that some cultures conceived of the self as containing two parts: a smaller, individual, daily self, and a larger, multiple, primordial one. This greater self, it was believed, was the one that dreamed. Something about this way of thinking felt more useful—and more reflective of my experience—than any of the latest studies in neuroscience I read about the physiological functions of dreams.

*Psyche*: Greek for "soul." Which felt like a more appropriate frame of reference—despite my continued resistance to the language of theism—for experiences that so evidently defied the materialist doctrines of my late-20th-century education. To privilege the Newtonian model of classical mechanics—one object pushing or pulling another, all the way down to the molecules that formed consciousness—over the actual data of my experience felt like intellectual laziness. I understood that others would see my willingness to abide more patiently in the mystery as irrational. My usage of the Greek term started to give way to its English corollary. The word *soul* seemed to make better sense of whatever was expanding inside me, a rising that was also a deepening, married to the uncanny knowing of what seemed like prognostication, and, more valuably, to a natural empathy for others. And in case this comes off as more altruistic than seems reasonable: Less blinded by myself, more porous to others, I found, too, that I was becoming a better writer.

From the November 2024 issue: Jeffrey Goldberg, Ayad Akhtar, Robert Downey Jr., and Bartlett Sher on writing in the age of AI

*Soul* was, for me then, a mode of being mostly experienced in images by night that shaped my understanding by day—for example, that a close friend was like the abandoned dog I dreamed he was, long neglected by his family, never allowed into the house; an image that helped me navigate his touchiness, providing readier access to the wellspring of loving loyalty that coursed beneath his habitual choler. I found in the use of *soul* a capaciousness that not only accounted for this richer relationship to others and the world—and to myself—but served as a bridge to deeper mystery, and to a new patience that allowed me to acclimate to it.

There were other benefits, too. Just as the vital, vivid stuff of my brain's nightlife enriched my being—to use a word that joined *soul* in the lexicon of descriptive terms of dubious provenance—so did my immersion in dream dross seem to feed my capacities with language. There was a stronger tether now between word and thing, a tether, paradoxically, that operated simultaneously in many directions and layers. The webbed, protean mode of associative thinking—one thing reaching for another, in opposing vectors at once—was less an effort than a reflex, more instinctive than the ordinal fixity of my usual habits of mind. Shakespeare, whom I'd long struggled to apprehend, now made easier sense, even as the experience of reading him felt like perpetual entry into undiscovered country, the phonetic expatiations, the dense semantic clusters, the sounds and images opening up more and more effortlessly into a particular state of absorptive flow, a pleasing emotional and intellectual static that I took to calling "linguistic space."

I started taking a yoga class on the Upper West Side. Our becalming teacher spent the better part of our weekly hour teaching us to meditate. Setting aside my irritation with her hushed and holy tones, I found myself growing more susceptible to her instructions.

I could catch a gap between thoughts that felt curiously similar to a rich blankness that resulted from hours spent in linguistic space. The fixed point of focus on the breath sharpened my mind and filled it with something closer to light than thought. On my own, I began to sit—sometimes for hours—in this pregnant blankness, exhibiting a facility for what the yoga teacher called “practice” that I couldn’t explain.

My weekly hour with that yoga teacher sparked an interest in meditation that led to weeks, and years, of working with other instructors of inner techniques. I learned to visualize and hold in memory shapes derived from Gnostic practices and colors derived from Sufi ones. Intoning Abulafia’s list of Hebrew names for God at the proper pitch and volume shook the bones in my ear and nerves along my neck. Calm was promised, and often followed, though I wondered whether this said more about my susceptibility to suggestion than the practices themselves. Sometimes what followed was stranger. Once, as I sat in a darkened room at dusk, observing the breath going in and out of me, I felt that breath begin to breathe itself. In the half shadows, with my eyes closed, a startling brightness waxed and waned with the movement of air. *What was this light?* I wondered. Was this just the room’s faint light filtering through my eyelids, brightening and dimming as my pupils dilated and contracted with each breath? If so, was this suggestion too? I would come to no definitive answer. The inner light continued to strobe.

If it was all suggestion, I didn’t mind. It was getting me further than faith had. From Meister Eckhart I learned to recognize in my meditative blankness a silence clean of longing, one that, if I could remain in it, would release an astonishing vitality. Others I studied with found it strange that my interest in meditation would be piqued by dream-work and quickened by pentameter. They sometimes remarked that what I was up to resembled anthropology more than devotion. They were only partly right. To me, it was all a study in being, or soul, or spirit (the latest addition to my lexicon)

—which is to say, an inquiry into the substance and nature of the interior life.

My reading, too, reflected the scavenging of a magpie in search of material from which to build its nest: the *Phaedrus* and Patanjali and Mulla Sadra; *Being and Time* one month, *Mathnawi* the next. What exactly I thought I was doing was not a matter of concern as long as I kept to myself about it. What I'm compressing into paragraphs here took so much longer, of course, and was hardly as sequential as telling makes it sound. I kept at it for the reward of the work itself. I had experiences of rapture (and sorrow) so deep, of pleasures so unprecedented, it was sometimes hard to return to the dishes and the rent. But I had studied with a remarkable Vedic teacher who warned me about seeking states rather than the truth. "What is the truth?" I once asked him as we sauntered along a Tennessee creek. He pulled his orange robe tighter against a rising spring wind. He was too smart to oblige. "The truth is not like knowledge about that tree," he said, pointing to a blooming magnolia. "Only the tree knows its truth." I didn't want to pretend I understood him. "You write stories," he said. "Inside the story is a meaning that is the reason for it. Not words that carry it, but the wordless substance of its truth you take away."

Despite my customary reticence about such things, I had occasions to compare notes with fellow travelers. One evening, at a fundraising function downtown, I found myself sharing martinis with a physician whose lived-in eloquence about his Zen practice felt like an opening. I was not expecting the lesson in brain science he proceeded to impart: I'd become addicted, he said, to activating certain parts of my cerebral cortex. Like an addict—I flinched at that word—I was pulling on neurological switches, training my brain to release its own pleasure chemicals through a growing grab bag of inner tricks. Clearly he didn't approve. I was too embarrassed to ask why, even as I recalled my teacher's warning not to chase states, but rather to seek the wordless substance of

truth. I resisted the physician's account even as I couldn't ignore the unease it stirred in me.



Illustration by Hélène Blanc

My fellow traveler was right, at least as far as neuroscience went. Studies were beginning to show that meditation—a loose term for the various practices of inner focus I was involved with—activated and deactivated specific parts of the human brain. In the 1990s, the neuroscientist Andrew Newberg studied advanced Tibetan monks and Franciscan nuns as they entered deep meditative states. The results were strikingly similar. In both groups, areas of the brain believed to be responsible for orienting us in space and time showed markedly decreased activity, as if the neural basis for the boundary between self and other had gone quiet. They were using very different techniques, but the results, neurologically speaking, were nearly indistinguishable. Each group, however, described the experience differently: the nuns as a feeling of union with Christ, the monks as a state of emptiness.

I knew enough about Buddhism to recognize in that word, *emptiness*, something very different from the hole that had opened up inside me during early adulthood. For the Buddhist, perception of the nature of reality discloses the identity of emptiness with

form, and form with emptiness. It's a perception described in other traditions by other means, and sometimes, in Christianity, as an annihilation of the individual personality in the presence of God. The maps and words and techniques were different; somehow, the underlying experience itself, beyond words or ideas, was the same.

Not quite in the words of my Vedic teacher: The brain scans were a story containing a truth known only to the one inside them.

For a long time, all of this felt like little more than a motley, life-enhancing assortment, which is not to downplay the valuable place it had in my life. Rightly or wrongly, I attributed the return of my fundamental stability after the harrowing years of early adulthood —and the return of the placid, placable self I'd known much earlier in life—to my commitment to daily practice. I would come to think of inner work as an adult corollary to the joyous absorption of childhood play. I'd found a way to play again, I concluded, and somehow this had seemed to "fill" the hole again.

But the life of the spirit was not what I took my real life to be. I was a writer. I wanted to know the broken world that was, not the healed one that could be. I had no fundamental interest in escaping the human condition. To the extent that spirit—or soulfulness—anchored my curiosity, quickened my perceptions, deepened my empathy, I rationalized its creative and analytical utility. In truth, something less tangible than optimization bound me to practice. It kept me in the company of more eternal conundrums, questions of consciousness and origin and meaning for which, of course, I expected no answer. But proximity to the unknown—living contact with it, if you will—seemed like a worthy form of knowledge.

In this, I was like many friends who took psychedelics; I wanted to recover the awe and mystery I recognized in their accounts when they shared them. For the most part, though, I was still doing what my teacher had warned me against—chasing states. In part, this was a function of resisting meaning. I had been too respectful of

my teacher back then to tell him I wasn't sure that a story's meaning mattered to me the way he assumed it would. But I felt the slow accretion of a wordless substance inside me, not well-being or certainty or the rapture of some fugitive sublime, but something I might call intimacy: intimacy with an inwardness spied only indirectly, whose purer acquaintance I seemed to be making very slowly indeed.

With the hindsight of decades, I can track a tectonic shift away from the visible to something more diffuse and sustaining, an interior through line that has both warned me against the tyranny of acquisition—of things, of states—and provided the means of finding sustenance in absence. Whatever this is, whatever name I might give it, I can't deny that it all seems to have proceeded from that perception of a hole I felt or imagined when I was younger. William James might have called it a "sick soul"; I still don't feel entirely confident about what word to use for the continuity that I've found or constructed, though some word has always been necessary. I had spent years resisting every vocabulary that exceeded the raw data of sensation, only to find that this austerity, too, had to be exceeded.

Too much of what mattered most in my own life had remained unspoken not because it was unreal, but because I did not know how to bring it into language without betraying it. For decades, I steered conversations away from these inner experiences, obedient to the rule that such things could not be talked about without sounding foolish or deranged. But my reticence began to feel like capitulation to falseness. It took me years to understand that my silence was not only protective but deforming—for without others to hear it, the still, small voice within was so much harder to discern. And yet, the silence was not my own to break. With so little room in our common life for such things, we have no common language for them either.

Ralph Waldo Emerson knew the problem. In "The Over-Soul," he wrote that language could not paint this "subtile" order of our experience in its own colors; but he knew how important it was to keep trying. The great Russian novelists knew it too, treating *soul* not as a word reserved for Sundays, but as the moral substance of life. I've found myself mourning not their metaphysics but their seriousness, their acceptance of the inscrutable boundlessness of the inner life—unruly, morally consequent—as a subject for public speech.

What matters to me now is less the defense of any particular term than the search for a language in which such things can be spoken of seriously, in fiction and elsewhere, without piety or diagnosis. Without a language for speaking openly together about the inner life, what often matters most to us remains locked away, inaccessible to the inquiry and challenge vital to all knowledge.

As I finished a draft of this essay, I had a dream. In it, I stood at the edge of a well—another hole, I realized as I made note the following morning—where there was no bucket to draw water. Around it moved countless people in a flurried hubbub, shepherds and masons and architects, all of us trying to figure out how to draw the water whose surface we could see in the faint shimmering at the bottom.

It was going to take time, I thought, before we figured it out—just as I awoke.

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*This article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline "In My Dreams." When you buy a book using a link on this page, we receive a commission. Thank you for supporting* The Atlantic.

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/ayad-akhtar-dreams-meditation/688676/

**Dispatches**

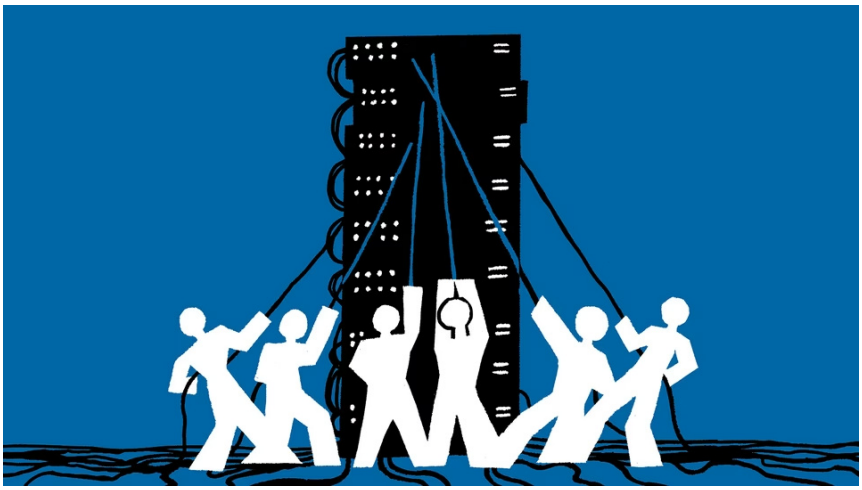
- **The Great Data-Center Rebellion**
- **The Children of Cheaters**
- **Requiem for a Condiment**
- **Bait and Switch**

# The Great Data-Center Rebellion

**Could a new populist movement help save American democracy?**

by George Packer

Wed, 30 Sep 2026



Clinton, Iowa, is topographically flat and economically declining. The sawmills that made the city rich in the late 19th century have been repurposed as a museum. One of the Victorian mansions long since abandoned by the old lumber barons is open for tours, but tourists are scarce. Clinton has shrunk to about 24,000 people, and the town center, along the Mississippi River, feels nearly empty. On the west side, miles of deep-green corn and soy fields are crisscrossed with transmission wires and zoned for heavy industrial use. The city's economic activity includes corn processing, pet-food production, and methamphetamines. With available land and a dire need for investment, Clinton seems like the perfect place for a gigantic data center.

In January, a Clintonian named Stephen Figg, who owns a small firm that builds technological infrastructure, including for data centers, heard from a customer that a broker was making inquiries

about buying farmland on the west side, north of Highway 30. In mid-February, a father of two girls named Ryan Wisor, who had obtained a residential exemption to live in that area, noticed surveyors with boring rigs working in the field behind the house he'd built. He asked his stepsister, who sits on the city council, if she knew of a planned development. Several weeks later, she told him of a proposal for a data center. He learned that the project would border his house on two sides and come to within 65 feet of his well.

For almost two years, city officials, utility companies, and a pro-business nonprofit, Grow Clinton, had been in discussions about the construction of a data center in Clinton. It later emerged that an international developer called Quality Technology Services (QTS), owned by the trillion-dollar private-equity firm Blackstone, planned to build one of the country's largest AI data centers—10 buildings of 500,000 square feet each—on behalf of a client that remains anonymous. Private meetings, nondisclosure agreements, and even a code name ("Saturday River") had kept the plan's existence quiet until Andy Sokolovich, the president of Grow Clinton, unveiled the proposal at a county-board meeting on April 27. He had wanted to keep the project confidential longer, but word was getting out.

Theresa Andrews, a quality analyst at a chemical company, had heard a rumor in mid-March about a development planned for the cornfields in her area, but she'd blown it off. After watching the April 27 county meeting online, she went on the city's website and noticed dozens of requests for information about the status of parcels of farmland; a few of them were right across the street from her house. Andrews stayed up late for several nights creating a spreadsheet of the parcels and then a map of the projected site. The scale was almost unimaginable: 1,100 acres, or 832 football fields—about the size of Central Park. This would be a "hyperscale" data center, and it turned out to be far along. From FOIA requests,

Andrews learned that plans for upgrading utilities in the area had been in the works since 2024.

This was how the Data-Center Rebellion of 2026 came to Clinton, Iowa. Not through Chinese propaganda, or misinformation on social media—though both are plentiful—but because a small group of residents accidentally got wind of a megaproject planned for their community. Andrews, Wisor, Figg, and others had concerns about water consumption, electrical-grid capacity, soil contamination, low-frequency sound waves, nonstop light, an invasion of out-of-state contractors, and—for those in the leviathan's shadow—the permanent destruction of their rural life. "There's no proven history of these things," Wisor told me. He imagined playing in the yard with his 9-year-old daughter and worrying what their colossal new neighbor might be doing to his family's health. "I go sit outside and all I think is, *This could all be gone*. You can't turn it off."

Large numbers of Clintonians began to attend contentious city-council meetings. On June 9, the council voted down a proposal for a 120-day moratorium that would have allowed more time to assess the risks of something so immense and unknown. The city proceeded to draft an ordinance for a data center's construction and use. Legally, QTS could begin without one. According to Andrews, city officials "were trying to tell us we have to hurry and get the ordinance in place so QTS won't just start building: 'You should want us to push fast.'" Instead, she and other citizens formed Clintonians Against Data Centers.

Even in a city as small as Clinton, the seven members of the group's steering committee—four women and three men, all white, most of them middle-aged—were at first strangers to one another. The group includes Republicans and Democrats, probably more of the former, but they didn't know one another's political affiliations and didn't seem to want to. Political comments unrelated to artificial intelligence are scrubbed from the Facebook page. "It's a

fun collection in terms of their politics," Chris Baldus, the editor of the *Clinton Herald*, told me. "Outside of this, there's no way in hell these people are talking to each other."

Celeste Robbins, who works in law enforcement and describes herself as both "artsy" and "very religious," is a disenchanted Trump voter. "If you want to get rich as a state or as a town," the president said in September, "you're going to want a data center." Robbins told me, "I do not agree with him about this." She lives far from the proposed site, and her opposition comes down to AI itself: She hates the ease with which it replaces human thought, and she fears the mass elimination of jobs. Figg, who couldn't bring himself to vote for either candidate in the last presidential election, has worked in tech all his life and welcomes the progress that AI might bring. He had just finished eight months of work on an Amazon data center in Indiana when he learned about the proposal for Clinton. He started attending city-council meetings to offer his expertise. "But the more that I try to provide this knowledge to the city and the city council and the mayor, the less receptive they are," he told me. "That makes it very difficult for me to want to continue that pursuit instead of the pursuit of just trying to prevent it."

With four children and a small business, Figg had never been involved in local activism before joining Clintonians Against Data Centers.

According to a recent NBC poll, nearly 70 percent of Americans oppose the construction of a data center in their area. Kevin Bradley of Clintonians Against Data Centers observed that this many Americans haven't agreed on anything since 9/11: "This is affecting all of us—rich, middle-class, and poor. We're coming together because we're not happy." More than 500 jurisdictions have passed moratoriums or bans. This grassroots movement rose so fast and spread so widely that politicians in both parties, including Iowa's candidates for governor and senator, are struggling to catch up with their constituents. The meteoric

emergence of the data-center rebellion is a response to the speed and scale of construction, which in turn reflect the sudden ubiquity of generative and agentic AI. President Trump's policy has been to turn everything about the technology, including data-center construction, over to private industry. He derides people like Robbins, Figg, and Andrews for wanting to remain "backwards and poor." But on this issue, most of Trump's base remains angry and opposed to him; the only precedent might be the case of Jeffrey Epstein. By pushing so hard and promising so much, tech companies, venture capitalists, and their political allies ensured that AI would create a firestorm.

Supporters of data centers point out the benefits—jobs, tax revenues, the many advantages of AI itself. Clinton's mayor, Scott Maddasion, told me that the project could bring $20 million in annual property taxes to a city with a $24 million budget. Sokolovich, of Grow Clinton, told me it would be closer to $30 million. He said that QTS has requested no tax incentives and will pay for 100 percent of the utility improvements required for the center to operate. A spokesman for Alliant Energy, the region's regulated electric utility, promised residents that costs related to the data center's extreme demand would not fall on existing customers.

Read: The one town that wants a data center

Clintonians Against Data Centers was not immune to bad information and conspiracist thinking. One member speculated that the sudden appearance around Clinton this past spring of three giant trolls, sculpted from local reclaimed lumber by the Danish artist Thomas Dambo to commemorate the trees consumed by the sawmills, had been funded by QTS to create a "diversion." A pro-data-center councilman mocked Robbins when, after touring another QTS project in Cedar Rapids, she reported having seen only one bird. Baldus, the newspaper editor, complained that the opposition doesn't understand how city government works, "and

they come in hot.” Sokolovich analogized data-center opposition to COVID skepticism and election denialism.

But the facts about water consumption and tax revenues, though important, are not the crux of the matter. Opposition to data centers comes from a deeper concern than NIMBYism, resource misuse, or environmental harm. Over and over, Clintonians expressed a feeling of being misled, ignored, disrespected, betrayed—of having no say over basic matters in their own lives. The data center seemed to be a deal made among secretive insiders—huge, far-off entities in Silicon Valley, on Wall Street, and in Washington, as well as the local leaders of their own city. To the tech giants, QTS, Blackstone, and the Trump administration’s AI boosters, Clinton is an empty space on the Mississippi that looks like an opportunity. That the industry seeking to buy 1,100 acres on the west side of town is in the business of replacing human beings with machines—and perhaps, according to some AI experts, even rendering them extinct—only intensifies a sense of powerlessness.

The data-center rebellion, with its local origins and compounding grievances, is thoroughly American. In the 18th century, rural citizens rose up against heavy taxes and farm seizures. In the early 20th century, a time in many ways similar to our own, Louis Brandeis spoke of the “curse of bigness”: concentrations of money and power so great that the individual almost ceases to exist, and democracy itself is threatened. Like other heartland communities, Clinton has suffered “a history of abandonment,” Matt Parbs, the vice president of Grow Clinton, acknowledged. “Clinton since 1980 has internalized the downturn in midwestern industry.” What if, in a few years, 5 million square feet of steel, concrete, computer servers, and microchips in the cornfields become obsolete and go the way of the sawmills, or of the liberal-arts college in Clinton that was bought by a for-profit, moved entirely online, and closed?

I tried to imagine a hyper-scale data center engulfing the yard where Ryan Wisor’s daughter plays with the family’s chickens.

Against such an immense force, with all the wealth, political power, technological sophistication, and claims of historical inevitability behind it, a sense of dignity can only raise a small voice in protest.

In a city the size of Clinton, the controversy over the data center was bound to hurt personal relationships. Linda Chapman, whose husband was the city's fire marshal, knows all seven members of the city council and has stopped trusting most of them. Wisor and his stepsister on the council no longer speak. Andy Sokolovich, of Grow Clinton, can't appear in public without someone sticking a phone camera in his face and asking him incendiary questions. The mayor received a death threat. But the converse is also true: To get anything done, Clintonians can't just abuse one another on Facebook or podcasts. They have to sit in a room together and talk face-to-face.

Throughout the summer, the city pushed ahead with an ordinance while Clintonians Against Data Centers kept raising objections that were mostly ignored, hoping to stall the process until QTS decided to look elsewhere.

In early September, I attended a council meeting where the language of the ordinance was to be hammered out. To accommodate several hundred people, the meeting was held not at city hall, but in a cavernous pole-frame lodge at the northern end of the city, in a park overlooking the river. The president and vice president of Grow Clinton were not present. "I don't want to say I'm intimidated, but the opposition has been vocal," Sokolovich told me. "I'm growing weary of it." Baldus, of the *Clinton Herald*, attended grudgingly, out of professional duty; he didn't seem to regard coverage of the data center as the most exciting opportunity for his paper. Theresa Andrews, who was routinely staying up past 3 a.m. to research the issues and prepare for meetings, arrived with a tense look on her face and a binder full of scientific studies on topics such as the effects of noise and light on livestock.

The seven members of the steering committee, some in green CLINTONIANS AGAINST DATA CENTERS T-shirts, sat at a long table with their backs to the audience, facing Mayor Maddasion, the council, and other city officials. This would be a parley between two groups in which everyone now knew everyone. The mayor, an Air Force veteran in his early 40s with a receding hairline, slender and mild, gaveled the meeting to order and led the room in reciting the Pledge of Allegiance.

The meeting went on for more than five hours, while darkness fell over the Mississippi. With a draft of the data-center ordinance on the table in front of him, the mayor briskly led the council members and city officials through it section by section and took their comments. Then he heard out the criticisms and suggestions of Clintonians Against Data Centers. The most contentious issue was setbacks—the required distance between data-center buildings and neighboring residential properties. The draft ordinance called for 1,000 feet. Andrews, quoting a study from counties in Pennsylvania, argued for 1,500 feet—a distance that might make the whole project untenable. A councilman named Cody Seeley, who did most of the talking for the pro-data-center side, said that the developer and property owners could negotiate the setbacks, adding, “I think 500 feet is adequate,” which also happened to be QTS’s position.

Cries from the audience of “No! No!” The mayor called for silence. Ryan Wisor, for whom the setback question meant the defense of his homestead, said with a slight quaver in his voice: “My frustration is this ordinance is meant to protect the citizens and our property. This isn’t meant to conform so that we can fit a particular business in a particular piece of land.” He added, “For us to give up our rights, it’s not fair.” General applause. It was the emotional high point of the night.

I found the proceedings both mind-numbing and inspiring. The seriousness of purpose, the attention to detail, the stamina required

to talk and listen—all of it moved me more than it seemed to impress anyone involved. Clintonians Against Data Centers still felt patronized and ignored. Perhaps the council came away exasperated with the NIMBYs and gadflies who were making the process such an ordeal. (Later, the mayor admitted to me, “We’re learning that there’s probably more ways that we can communicate with the citizens.”) In all likelihood, this small populist uprising will not achieve its goal; a hyperscale data center will come to Clinton, Iowa, amid widespread unhappiness and damaged friendships; and AI will continue to roll over the fields of the republic. But a democratic pulse was still beating along the Mississippi River. That was something.

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/data-center-resistance-movement/688671/

# The Children of Cheaters

**I thought my father was unique. Then I started meeting other people just like me.**

by Tom Junod

Fri, 09 Oct 2026



We met by accident. I mean that literally—a Yankee friend of mine blew a tire while driving south and swerved into oncoming traffic. He came out of it untouched, and wound up in Atlanta while his car was being serviced. I live in Atlanta, and he called to see if I

wanted to go out to dinner with him and his Aunt Maura to celebrate his survival.

Maura was around my age and fairly new to town. We talked for a few minutes before dinner and she asked what I'd been writing. I told her I'd just finished a book about my father, Lou Junod. "What's so interesting about him?" she asked, and I gave what had become my standard answer: "He was a philanderer." And then, because that word didn't seem to do Big Lou justice, I added the usual modifiers: charismatic, reckless, ruthless, relentless, irresistible, unrepentant, prolific.

Maura's reply did not require as many words. Her father also happened to be a philanderer, she said. But he wasn't like *that*—he didn't play the field. He was, by all appearances, an upright man. He just had a woman across town, and with her he had a second family, who knew him better than Maura's family ever did, because at least the children the world deemed illegitimate knew his secrets. "It haunts me," she said. "It haunts me, and it haunts my choices."

And then she asked the question that changed how I think about my father and men like him, perhaps men in general:

"How many of us do you think are out there?"

It was the *us* that threw me. I'd known almost all my life that my father was different from other fathers, both the comical ones I met in my neighborhood and the wise ones I watched on TV. When I was 3 years old, he had an affair with the mother of my first friend. When I was 6 or 7, he asked—he made a big deal of asking—if I wanted to go out for a hot-fudge sundae, and then stopped at a woman's house on the way to the ice-cream parlor and left me outside on the swings. When I was in college, he invited me to New York City for a night on the town, and introduced me to one of his girlfriends. I was close with my brother, my sister, and my mother, but I never told them what I knew. I never told anyone.

I was ashamed, of course—ashamed of him, ashamed of myself. But I was also proud. I had to be, because that's what he demanded, that was our margin of survival. He made my mother cry. He made me cry too. But that wasn't his fault; it was ours. It was, especially, mine. He didn't do what he did because he was broken or weak or simply bad; he did it because he was special, a traveling salesman who, by virtue of his looks, his tan, and his insistence on his own virility, became a kind of bedroom celebrity, even to actual celebrities like the Gabor sisters. He did what other men wanted to do, what all men *would* do, if only they could, if only they weren't so … weak. Did I want to be weak? No, anything but that. And so I made a faith of his faithlessness, believing that it, like Lou Junod himself, was unique.

From the April 2019 issue: Sarah Zhang on the fertility doctor's secret

I knew what he did when he went on business trips for five or six weeks at a time or stayed overnight in Manhattan. But it took me a long time to find a language for what and who he was. He kept *Playboy* magazines in the drawer of his nightstand. Is that what he was, a playboy? Well, maybe, except that playboys weren't supposed to be married to my mother. Was he a swinger? Nah—because he wasn't countercultural, and he was above growing out his sideburns and wearing Nehru jackets. How about the words I encountered when I went to college and read Dostoyevsky, words such as *sensualist* and *libertine* ? That was more like it, because at least those words were classy, unlike the more readily available, the more down-and-dirty *adulterer* and *cheat*.

I forget when I first came across *philanderer*. I remember that it struck me right away as a euphemism, a kind of excuse. Though rooted in Greek, it seemed French in intent, a description of a man with a pastime instead of a problem. It is a victimless crime of a word. Like multitudes of men and women throughout history, Lou Junod was promiscuous, lavishly and energetically so. But as a

philanderer in good standing with the *Oxford English Dictionary*, he acquires a certain distinction—a set of linguistic cuff links for his custom-made shirts—that sets him apart and gives him what he was so skilled at making: a pass.

Society has adopted *philanderer* as its word of choice for men like my father. But I did not write about him as such; I was careful to write about him as Dad rather than as a type. I doubt he'd appreciate having his secrets remorselessly exposed by his son in the pages of a book, but I believe he would give me credit for abiding by the terms of the silent pact we made so long ago. He would never be anything less than one of a kind. He would never be less than Big Lou. And so I was shocked when I met my friend's Aunt Maura and with one question she turned the whole proposition upside down.

"How many of us …"

And there it was, the most impossible word for the child of a philanderer, the *us* that tells you you're not alone. Don't get me wrong—I liked the idea of having something in common with other people. I even liked the idea of being, well, a *people*, something larger than myself or even my family, a betrayed class, an entire woeful demographic. The only difficulty was that in seeing myself as part of an *us*, I had to see my father as part of a *them*, and I had invested so much of myself and my writing in the premise of his singularity. He was grubby and unglamorous as part of a group. He was typical—oh, let's just say it, he was a typical male. He was not just unfaithful, he was not just promiscuous, he was not just an adulterer, he was not just a cheater, he was not just a philanderer—or, rather, he was just those things, and nothing more.

He was run-of-the-mill.

From the December 2019 issue: Tom Junod on his friend Mister Rogers

And yet the question that Maura asked was not an idle one, not just a thought exercise. It has an answer, and I've been reminded of it nearly every day since publishing my book.

I see them at the end of the signing line in bookstores, waiting patiently not just for an inscribed copy, but for the chance to speak the words that for most of their lives have been stalled at the tip of their tongue. I hear from them by email or direct message, the high-school classmates who write that they never knew I was just like them; the children of my father's friends who tell me that I've told their stories as well as my own. And I meet them at parties, the acquaintances who become friends when they tell me about the news they received when they took their Ancestry.com tests; when they heard from the siblings they'd never known; when they found out about their father's second or third family, or when they discovered that *they* were members of the second or third family and not, as they'd thought all their lives, the first and the only.

How many of us are out there? I can say with great confidence that the answer is *a lot*, because I've gone out at last to meet the *us*, and it's been the great belated gift of my growing-up to be able to speak with them, to be able to speak for them, and to know that what they want to tell me is often exactly what I want to tell them:

*I loved him.*

We are a wised-up lot, you see. We spent our innocence trying to believe in men we knew were guilty, only to find ourselves sometimes being employed as accessories and even collaborators in their crimes. But we always had one thing we could count on because we didn't find it in our fathers' closets, drawers, coat pockets, briefcases, or post-office boxes but rather in ourselves: our helpless love for the men who couldn't stop breaking our hearts. And so when I'm out among them, my people, I hear myself saying it, and they hear themselves saying it, and we know it's only a matter of time before we move on to the question we can't answer:

*Did he ... ?*

And there's something I hear myself saying often in response to this, in addition to my hopeful *Yes*. He was a good father, I say. He tried hard. He spent time with me. He always showed me affection. He never stinted on telling me he loved me. He was dedicated, he was dogged, he was determined.

And that's when I see that I'm at last surrounded by people who are not so different from me, who are just the same, and who know that everything I'm saying about Lou Junod as a father, I could be saying about Big Lou the philanderer.

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**Image sources: CSA-Printstock / Getty; GraphicaArtis / Getty; LMPC / Getty; Found Image Holdings / Corbis Historical / Getty; Jack Mitchell / Getty.*

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/tom-junod-father/688672/

# Requiem for a Condiment

**When Durkee Famous Sauce disappeared from grocery-store shelves, I mourned a piece of my childhood.**

by Wright Thompson

Fri, 02 Oct 2026




When I was a boy, my small-town-attorney father had a client who paid his legal bills not in money but in deliveries of homegrown tomatoes. I still think about those tomatoes, almost vulgarly red,

the size of softballs, juicy, earthy. My dad liked to put salt on them "to make them bleed," he said.

This was the mid-1980s, and life in the Mississippi Delta still moved in fading agricultural rhythms. My parents had grown up around a few old people who remembered the Civil War. Clarksdale, where we lived, smelled like defoliant sprayed from low-flying yellow crop dusters. In the summer, most of my high-school friends and I went to work at 6 a.m., chopping cotton or working in the gin yard.

My family ate those tomatoes nearly every night of the summer, usually on sandwiches—bacon and tomatoes on Wonder Bread covered in a mayo-mustard hybrid called Durkee Famous Sauce. Durkee's, as it's known, served as the base ingredient in my mother's stuffed eggs—we never called them deviled—and was the only acceptable condiment for a Thanksgiving-leftovers sandwich. It's a staple of refrigerators across the South.

But this summer, right in the middle of tomato season, my mom burst into my house with terrible news. Durkee's had been discontinued! There were no bottles anywhere! Her friends in the Delta had all been searching, in stores, online. Attempts at bootleg recipes had begun. She told me that summer would never taste the same. "You just count on some things being there," she said. I looked at her and knew she wasn't joking.

"It really is the taste of summer," she said. "I wonder what the poor tomatoes are going to think."

My mom grew up during the civil-rights movement in Shelby, Mississippi, a farming town that is now dead, and soon after she married my father, they moved 20 miles north to Clarksdale, a farming town that is now dying. She's 79. The headlines she reads these days feel like dispatches from a time she thought would never return. Like a lot of progressive southerners, she's had to watch the

thing she counted on most, the flawed yet moral core of the United States, turn to ashes in the last years of her life. Sometimes the big losses are too much to process, and little things, such as losing a familiar taste, become mourners' benches. (Also, those sandwiches were *really* good.)

She asked me, her reporter son, to find out what had happened.

I quickly confirmed what my mom told me: Durkee's was dead.

B&G Foods, which bought the Durkee brand back in 2016, killed the condiment sometime last year. The company made no announcement and issued no press release. Some people learned that the sauce was dead when others posted screenshots of emails they'd received from B&G. Many more realized this summer, as the last bottles in the supply chain disappeared from shelves. (I emailed the company multiple times; eventually, a spokesperson responded to say that Durkee Famous Sauce had been discontinued "at least temporarily" because of a problem with the manufacturer.)

"I guess it wasn't big enough for them," Otis Maxwell, a food blogger, told me when I called him.

He started noticing as far back as 2013 that he could no longer find Durkee's regularly in stores and had to chase it down online. "I've been aware for some time that it was endangered," he said.

Maxwell wrote about the sauce being officially discontinued over the summer and offered his own take on Durkee's; those posts have been among his most read. "My copycat recipe really is very good," he said. "People are passionate about it." My reporting showed me that Durkee's has fans outside the South: Maxwell lives in Saratoga Springs, New York, and I read online about lovers in Butte, Montana.

Other recipes are circulating online, and an emerging Durkee's subculture revolves around the many attempts to re-create it. My mom got a recipe and bought the ingredients the other day. I'm waiting on her report. Casey Roberts, writing for *The Perry County Herald*, described how, after experimenting with three different recipes, he settled on a mixture of egg yolk, apple-cider vinegar, mayonnaise, Dijon mustard, sugar, dry mustard, Worcestershire sauce, and salt. After cooking it in an improvised double boiler, he had something approximating Durkee's. "Pales in comparison to the real deal," he told me, "but we do what we have to in such desperate times."

I asked him what seemed to be missing.

"There's something sweet, but almost umami," he said. "Like, this balance that's really difficult to achieve as I've been tinkering."

My friend Jeffrey Reed recently moved down to the beach. He loves to fish. A few days ago, he came back to northern Mississippi one final time to get the last load of things from his house. He packed up frozen redfish and speckled-trout fillets into a cooler, along with elk, oryx, sandhill-crane breasts, duck, and his Hatch chiles. And his two remaining bottles of Durkee's. "That Durkee's was one thing I made damn sure to put in the ice chest," he said.

I posted online about the death of Durkee's, and people have been writing me nonstop, dozens of them. They are distraught, and cataloging how they used the last bit from their last bottle. "Durkee's was at every family gathering that I can remember," my friend, the southern rock-and-roll-tour photographer Andy Tennille, told me. "Durkee's, Maker's Mark, Vantage cigarettes."

Searching for answers about Durkee's led me to corners of the internet where people gather to reminisce about vanished brands and bygone restaurants, such as Fleur de Lis Pizza, in Baton Rouge, Louisiana; the Ranchero, in Clarksdale; and 14th Street

Grill, in Phenix City, Alabama, to name three closings that really affected me. (If Doe's Eat Place, in Greenville, Mississippi, ever went out of business, it would be like losing a part of my late father all over again.) In a country where people so often move to chase work, home is defined mostly by familiar tastes—the ones that bring us hurtling back in time, to a kitchen table, to parents and grandparents, to a moment when all the possibilities of what we might become remained.

From the October 2024 issue: To understand Mississippi, Wright Thompson went to Spain

Advertisements in the 1930s suggested pouring Durkee's over boiled meat. Some people made salad dressing with it. Others used it to marinate shrimp, or to make a sauce for chicken by mixing it with apricot jam. People put it on green beans. It was a secret ingredient in pimento cheese. Florida folks served it with lobster and stone crab. And we've all got stories of cousins sneaking out to smoke a joint after Thanksgiving dinner, carrying breath spray and eye drops, then raiding the fridge for turkey and the Durkee's sauce.

Tomatoes with bacon and white bread remains my preferred delivery mechanism. I went through my pantry and found one bottle of Durkee's way in the back that we'd forgotten about. It expired two years ago. I'm definitely eating it anyway. Like my mom and her friends, I tried searching for any straggling bottles on the internet. I didn't find one. eBay doesn't have any. Neither does Amazon, Kroger, Walmart, or Publix. I cannot find a single bottle for sale anywhere. There are rumors, though, of secret stashes. "Like black-market Durkee's honey holes," Tennille said, laughing. "Kinda reminded me of when my aunt was ordering Tab by the case from Yugoslavia."

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/durkee-famous-sauce-discontinued/688673/

# Bait and Switch

**Fishermen have always exaggerated the size of their catches. But AI has taken the practice to a different level.**

by Tyler Austin Harper

Sat, 03 Oct 2026



Earlier this year, one of my fishing partners sent a 1 a.m. message to our group chat. It was a link to an Instagram post of an angler holding a sizable striped bass. Dappled gold and silver with a dozen distinct black lines that stretched from gills to tail, it would have been a gorgeous fish if not for two problems: Striped bass usually have seven stripes, not 12, and men usually have five fingers, not six. The photo, it seemed, was AI-generated. To say we were dismayed would be an understatement.

From May to November each year, I spend most of my nights doing an extreme version of surf fishing for striped bass called “wetsuiting,” which involves wading or swimming out to distant ocean rocks and sandbars after dark. This kind of surf casting is a niche activity, and like many niche activities, the community for it is small. Wetsuiters can be found in a smattering of local fishing

clubs throughout the Northeast—the typical range of the striped bass—but are primarily connected through Instagram, where some people, mostly for bragging rights, post images of fish they've caught.

From the October 2024 issue: Inside the dangerous, secretive world of extreme fishing

In our group chat, my fishing partners and I spend too much time scrutinizing photos of bass that other anglers have posted. People who fish are habitual liars (I say this fondly), and most of our conversations take the form of debates about whether a fish is really as big as someone claims. Lately, though, we've been asking a different question: Is that fish even real?

In recent months, the small corner of Fishing Instagram devoted to surf casting has been plagued by a slow drip of AI-generated or AI-enhanced fish. Sometimes, the fraud is egregious—one of my friends, a fishing photographer, discovered that another angler had stolen one of his photos and crudely replaced my friend's face with her own. More often, the distortions are subtle. Typically, a fish or fisherman looks ever so slightly off, usually in ways that a casual observer might not notice: A bass's fins aren't quite right, or the lure in its mouth looks oddly distorted, or the angler's arms are a bit too long. In my favorite example, a man lifts a large striped bass just as he is getting pummeled by a wave. The scene looks daunting—until you realize that the ocean behind him is peaceful. Where did this rogue wave come from? One suspects that the enterprising angler, wanting to look more hard-core to his Instagram followers, prompted a bot to dial up the intensity. *ChatGPT, make me look badass*.

Fishing magazines report growing concern about AI-generated fish in freelance photo submissions. I have written occasionally for the small online magazine *Surfcaster's Journal*. Over the summer, the *Journal* announced that it would now run all manuscripts and

photographs through AI-detection software. “For some reason, I naively assumed that fishermen wouldn’t stoop to the ‘core of the earth’ lows required to use AI to prop oneself up as a fisherman worthy of clicking the follow icon,” Dave Anderson, a well-respected wetsuiter and an editor at *The Fisherman*, wrote in an article lamenting the scourge of artificially generated fish on social media. “I was very wrong about this.”

Angling, even extreme angling, is just a hobby, but although the stakes may be low, the anger about artificial fish is real. Partly, I think this is because of the work that being even remotely good at the sport demands. Striped bass move and feed in locally specific patterns that can take months or years to crack. There is a risk of drowning, and the mounting reports of bull sharks, tiger sharks, and great whites in the Northeast call attention to another layer of danger: We smell like fish, swim in dark water, and look like clumsy seals in our black neoprene. Wetsuiting does not change the world, but it is an activity that is hard and honest and, in that way, human.

Read: The year great white sharks took over Maine

Even taking a picture of a fish is demanding, requiring salt-water-proof cameras and often wading or swimming a bass back to shallow water, where it can safely be photographed and then released. The Photoshopping of fish pictures—and of the natural world in general—has been an issue for years, but AI, with its ability to conjure a simulacrum of reality out of nothing at all, is another matter. It automates away the need not only to photograph a fish, but to even catch one in the first place.

The problem extends to other sports and hobbies, many of which are now defined by what Stuart Franklin—who took one of the celebrated “Tank Man” photos at Tiananmen Square—calls the “documentary impulse.” Social media has turbo-charged that impulse into an imperative. A good local skateboarder’s or surfer’s

reputation would once have been built through word of mouth. Today, posted photographs and short-form videos may constitute the primary proof of ability. Concerns about AI slop are already being raised in cycling, skiing, and other activities. *Climbing Magazine* recently called out an AI-saturated YouTube channel purporting to chronicle climbing disasters that in fact never happened.

As AI-generated fish have appeared more frequently in my social-media feed, I've been reminded of a scene in the bird-watching documentary *Listers*, where a highly competitive birder is asked whether he would keep bird-watching if the photo-logging website eBird disappeared. His answer—"No"—was unsettling, not least because one suspects that this sentiment is widespread in hobbies besides birding. I have often wondered if, for some of the wetsuiters who populate surf-casting Instagram, the dopamine hit from the likes and fire emoji is sweeter than the hit from catching the fish itself. Now that posted images are being looked upon with an ever greater degree of suspicion, I also wonder how much longer the dopamine hits will come for them at all.

This is hardly the greatest challenge posed to humanity by the advent of AI. But hobbies, particularly those that require some measure of skill and endurance, have an influence that extends beyond those who directly participate in them. *Free Solo*, the Oscar-winning 2018 documentary about the death-defying rock climber Alex Honnold, found a wide audience outside the narrow world of climbing because people are invested in seeing other people do difficult things. I love videos of big-wave surfing even though I never plan to climb onto a surfboard. If AI makes it impossible to trust what we see, even something as simple as a surfing video, then we have lost more than the integrity of any one sport. We have lost the ability to believe in the accomplishments of others.

*This article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline "The Fish Are Getting Bigger."*

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/ai-images-hobbies/688674/

**Culture & Critics**

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- **Zombie Originalism**
- **The Vanity of Kings**
- **The Journalist and the Manipulator**

# Those Books of Smut and Wonder

**How Sarah J. Maas became the queen of romantasy**

by Honor Jones

Sat, 10 Oct 2026



Do your heroes weep? Do they swoon with lust? Are they really confused by their new magical powers? Then you're already a fan of romantasy. For those still waiting to discover romantasy: It's fantasy, with strong female protagonists and fewer boring bits—the long treks over major landforms in hard weather. Sex is plentiful,

but sex is not the genre's defining feature. You can go chapters before encountering a reference to someone's toned body. Far more significant are feelings and friendships between the heroes: enchanted beings with relatable self-esteem issues who don't just seek and fight but also yearn and banter as they face down enemies who aren't only evil, but super bitchy too. Then the heroes cry and have orgasms (sometimes they orgasm first and cry after).

In the kingdom of romantasy, one writer reigns supreme: Sarah J. Maas, the author of *ACOTAR*. It sounds like a missile-defense system or an autoimmune condition, but it's the acronym for one of the most popular series of novels for adults written in the 21st century. *A Court of Thorns and Roses* is the first of many books about Feyre Archeron, a young huntress spirited into the faerie realm. Humans hate the leaders of the faerie world, called the High Fae, who once enslaved them. But as soon as one bursts through Feyre's door, having shape-shifted into the body of a green-eyed, bearlike beast, the reader thinks, *I bet some of these guys are going to be hot*.

Feyre falls in love and breaks a curse and brings down a depraved fae queen, and that's just in the first book—eventually she'll assemble a crew of beloved sidekicks and a heap of supernatural powers. On any given week, you can see every book in the series stacked in a column on the *New York Times* best-seller list. If you combine *ACOTAR* with Maas's two other series, *Throne of Glass* and *Crescent City*, she has sold some 75 million copies. *The Lord of the Rings* has likely sold more than twice that, but J. R. R. Tolkien had a 60-year head start.

After *A Court of Thorns and Roses* come courts of: *Mist and Fury*, *Wings and Ruin*, *Frost and Starlight*, and *Silver Flames*. Fans waited five long years for the sixth book. Would the next court have one syllable and two syllables? Would the decent faeries stop the awful ones from slaughtering and re-enslaving the humans? Then Maas announced, in a rare interview on the podcast *Call Her*

*Daddy*, that she would actually be releasing *three* new books—one in October, one in January, and one more after that—and people lost their minds. Right away a question shot into the inboxes of America's bookstores: Are you having a midnight release party? Tickets sold out. For one "fantasy ball" at a bookstore in El Paso, Texas, they sold out in 12 hours. A second party was announced; it sold out too. Book clubs began rereading all of the courts in preparation.

Read: The publishing industry's most swoon-worthy genre

On social media, bets were made about which of Feyre's sisters or friends the new books would focus on, and what color the covers would be (Maas hadn't done purple yet). In August, images of the next two jackets—for *A Court of Splintered Harmony* and *A Court of Forgotten Melody*—lit up Times Square. They were ombré!

But search *The New York Review of Books* or the *London Review of Books* for Maas, and you'll find references to a German foreign minister, a river, the Pynchon character Oedipa Maas—and no trace of Sarah J. *The New Yorker*'s culture podcast summed up the low end of romantasy as "customer service wrapped in self-care wrapped in literature," though one of the critics admitted that she'd loved *A Court of Thorns and Roses*. Hear enough writers lament that the only books that sell now are faerie or dragon or elfpunk porn, and you start to get the feeling that the literary establishment is committed to resenting this rare bright spot in the publishing industry.

Maas, now 40, was a teenager when she wrote an epic fairy tale about a young assassin who can slit throats as well as waltz at balls for a fiction site. That story was published by Bloomsbury, in 2012, as *Throne of Glass*. The novels that followed took off on #BookTok and then in real life thanks to a generation of former *Harry Potter* fans who now had jobs, babies, and stymied sex drives. These

people (women) started reading (or listening). They started going to bookstores.

Fewer Americans are reading for pleasure every year, and yet people keep opening bookstores—romance bookstores in particular (more than 100 in the past year and a half alone, according to the American Booksellers Association). Zella Funkhouser, a high-school science teacher, runs three book clubs at the newly opened Bonfire Bookstore & Yarnery, in Shenandoah County, Virginia. She told me that she picked up *A Court of Thorns and Roses* in 2023, after having gone "years without really reading a whole lot." Then back-to-back snowstorms hit, and her husband, who does road work for the state, spent days out plowing. Alone at home behind a wall of snow, Funkhouser devoured all five books. "We didn't have internet; we didn't have power," she told me. "I was obsessed."

On a Saturday night in June, her book club discussed *Thorns and Roses*. Erin was reading the series for the third time, Tiffani for the fourth, Abby for the fifth. "We're not reading high literature, let's be honest," one of the women acknowledged. But they weren't looking for formal innovation; they were looking to be inspired and turned on.

It's true that you're rarely transported by *ACOTAR*'s language. Characters say things like "I admire your balls, Feyre." Sometimes they make me laugh. "Shall we assist you, or just flap here, talking?" a leader of winged reinforcements asks, when it seems the battle has been lost. Characteristic of the genre, the books remix familiar stories. The first meal in *Beauty and the Beast*, minus the dancing silverware. *Pride and Prejudice*, if the lovers started out on even worse terms. Hades and Persephone, if the king of the underworld just really got you.

But even if you don't read romantasy (I don't read romantasy), the books are well crafted and very entertaining. And for its hard-core fans, *ACOTAR* has achieved something like a vertical integration of

the imagination: the raw fiber of old myths woven into new stories, processed through the internet, refined into audiobooks for intimate delivery straight down the ear canal, which drive fans back to bookstores, where they can buy a keepsake hardcover and even, if they're lucky, drink themed cocktails in *ACOTAR*-inspired ball gowns at midnight.

With this kind of power, Maas doesn't need the literary establishment. (Bloomsbury, her publisher, declined to share advance copies of the new novels with me.) At one point, Maas puts her toughest character alone in a library. She's full of rage and a terrible power. And—take this, haters—she's reading a smutty romance.

In the *Call Her Daddy* interview, with her high cheekbones and golden hair and bare feet tucked beneath her, Maas looked a bit like one of her own characters as she talked about her "useless" creative-writing degree and recalled telling a professor, "I will never fucking write a poem." She couldn't understand "the meter and the rhythm" and had to ask her math-major boyfriend (now husband) for help. But when you read about a battle ending with enchanted water bubbling from "the lips of all the Hybern soldiers as Tarquin drowned them on dry land," you suspect she knows what meter is, even if she doesn't care what it's called. She's got a line of nearly perfect iambs there.

Enough about language. We've gone too long without talking about sex, and Maas would not approve. Sometimes she makes you wait for it (faeries, who are basically immortal, can spend centuries edging) but then, before you know it, someone's getting a blow job in the dining room.

The books get dirtier as they go. Reading on the subway about Feyre coming so hard that she "couldn't tell where one climax ended and the second began," I might have been less embarrassed to be caught watching actual porn. I really wished that one crucial

sex scene hadn't involved so much wet paint. Maas's characters are often splattered with something: mud, blood, stardust, semen (but only by Book 5). Still, there's this one scene: Feyre—degraded, but into it—and a throne room, and a thumb moving in lazy circles … I'll say it. I'm just going to say it. I liked it.

Smut aside, what really matters is how the characters grow together. You keep reading to see if they track down the enchanted artifacts but also to find out if true romantic partnerships are possible, the kind where care is taken and respect given. In the real world, many women are profoundly disappointed by and mistrustful of men. You might assume that this is why so many women are suddenly so eager to fantasize about another species entirely. But, fundamentally, these books are stories of friendship and love. Why should the novels' popularity suggest that women are giving up on men? It could mean they're holding out hope.

Maybe, eventually, more than a handful of men will read these books. After all, I was raised on the paperback heroes of my father's epics: *The Lord of the Rings*, *The Wheel of Time*. And *Harry Potter*, of course. Being a girl didn't stop me from wanting the boy to save the world. I remember listening to *The Sorcerer's Stone* in the car as a child, on road trips with my family, when things were not so good, when things were sometimes pretty bad, and seeing, not the tense edge of each parent's opposing shoulder, but the night sky across the ensorcelled ceiling of the Hogwarts dining hall.

Romantasy readers know they're not actually going to "go out and find dragons and magic," Funkhouser said, but if they're snowed in—or trapped by a pandemic, or up with a nursing newborn, or stuck in any of the ways humans tend to get stuck—it can help to imagine they could. Some books make you want to be a better writer or thinker, some books make you want to be a better person, and some books make you glad to be reading them. There may be a ceiling on what this literature can do. But it's an enchanted one.

*This article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline “Those Books of Smut and Wonder.”*

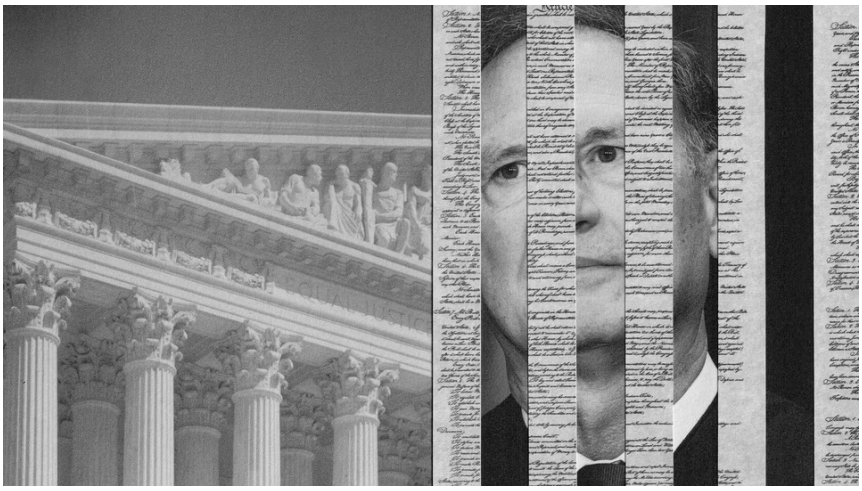
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# Zombie Originalism

**Samuel Alito's efforts to revamp the conservative legal philosophy reveal that a new movement is ascendant.**

by Jack Goldsmith

Tue, 06 Oct 2026



Samuel Alito is, with Clarence Thomas, one of the two most conservative sitting Supreme Court justices. In his 20 years on the highest bench, he has reliably voted for conservative positions—especially on social issues, criminal procedure, voting rights, discrimination, and religious liberty. He wrote the majority opinion in *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization*, which overturned the constitutional right to abortion. During the second Trump administration, he has so far voted more often than any other justice to uphold its initiatives. And in speeches, Alito has taken an unusual step for a sitting justice: He has become an active participant in the culture wars, opposing affirmative action, progressive campus orthodoxy, attacks on religious freedom, and hostility toward Judeo-Christian values.

Alito has now collected adaptations of 19 talks (all but six of them from the past decade) in *So Ordered: An Originalist's View of the Constitution, the Court, and Our Country*. Many of the wide-ranging essays are charming and genial, which will perhaps surprise those primed to expect an acerbic, embattled style. He includes an ardent fan's primer on baseball's lessons for life and law, a tribute to the "long-term vision of national greatness" in the Gettysburg Address, and an appreciation of the "long, deep, and sometimes scarring experience" of religious liberty's great defender Karol Wojtyla, before he became Pope John Paul II.

As the subtitle suggests, the most important talks concern "originalism"—the view that the Constitution should be interpreted according to its meaning at ratification. Originalism is the credo of the conservative legal movement that since the 1980s has traveled from obscurity to triumph, marked by the arrival of a Supreme Court supermajority that is dismantling the revolutionary progressivism of the Warren (1953–69) and Burger (1969–86) Courts. Yet Alito's embrace of the originalist label is also likely to come as a surprise to people on the left and the right.

From the October 2025 issue: Jill Lepore on how originalism killed the Constitution

Close observers of the Court have long seen Alito as a skeptic of orthodox originalism, and *So Ordered*, far from a paean to the philosophy, delivers a vigorous critique. In its place, Alito offers an approach that at times sounds like a conservative version of the judicial activism that originalism aimed to combat when liberals held sway on the Court. And the style of judging he defends, which he has practiced for decades, has now acquired currency: It dovetails with a Trump-era New Right conception of law that is unshackled by restraint and focused solely on conservative victory.

Alito joined the Reagan Justice Department in 1981 at age 31, just as the conservative legal counterrevolution against the Warren and

Burger Courts was getting under way. There he argued cases before the Supreme Court and advised the White House and attorney general. He also became an active participant in the Federalist Society, founded in 1982, which quickly emerged as the intellectual home of conservative and libertarian legal thinking. In the government and out, Alito made plain his conservative bona fides and was immersed in formative discussions of originalism.

The doctrine was fashioned as a response to a liberal conception of judging called “living constitutionalism,” which celebrated the ability of the document’s “great principles to cope with current problems and current needs,” in the words of Justice William Brennan. Conservatives hoped that originalism would limit or reverse the progressive transformation of American society set in motion by Supreme Court decisions that had expanded criminal-defense rights, ended prayer in public school, recognized the rights to contraception and abortion, strengthened voting equality, and supported affirmative action and busing. Originalists also claimed the mantle of democratic legitimacy. The doctrine elevated what the American people had ratified in the past over unelected judges’ revisions to the Constitution based on modern values and personal preference.

Alito watched as Antonin Scalia, who joined the Supreme Court in 1986, became originalism’s greatest champion. Scalia, a former law professor, was a theorist who worked out originalism in academic lectures. His brilliant judicial opinions went on to make the theory and methods a creditable enterprise and, eventually, the defining conservative legal dogma. But when President George H. W. Bush made Alito an appellate judge in 1990, originalism had not yet achieved its central place in the movement. During a decade and a half on the court of appeals, Alito established a reputation as a careful jurist who wrote tightly reasoned opinions that were as conservative as the law would permit. Originalist argument played no significant role in his decision making.

In 2005, Bush's son nominated Alito to replace Sandra Day O'Connor on the Supreme Court after his initial nominee, the White House counsel, Harriet Miers, withdrew amid bipartisan questions about her fitness. Alito was the credentialed, establishment legal conservative she wasn't, a judge with a Federalist Society pedigree and a long record of case outcomes that proved he wouldn't stray. During his confirmation hearings, critics dubbed him "Scalito" due to his conservative affinity with Scalia (and their Italian heritage). But originalism was barely mentioned in those hearings, and Alito made no concrete jurisprudential commitment to it.

When Alito joined Scalia on the Court, he maintained his traditionalist, lawyerly bent; eschewed theorizing; and paid close attention to case particularities. He continued to arrive at consistently conservative results, more forcefully articulated now without the constraint of possible Supreme Court reversal. He often broke with Scalia's originalist decisions, especially when they aided criminal defendants, and he rarely dove deeply into original meaning. Alito famously poked fun when Scalia asked about the views of the Constitution's ratifiers in a 2011 case about California's regulation of minors' access to violent video games. "I think what Justice Scalia wants to know is what James Madison thought about video games," Alito said, to laughter in the courtroom. "Did he enjoy them?" More often, however, his skepticism remained muted.

A low point for the Court's conservative wing came half a decade later. The 2015 *Obergefell v. Hodges* decision announced a constitutional right to same-sex marriage based on what Justice Anthony Kennedy, the swing vote on the bench, called the Court's "reasoned judgment in identifying interests of the person so fundamental that the State must accord them its respect." Scalia's dissent condemned this logic as a "judicial Putsch" that lacked "even a thin veneer of law" and rested solely on the preferences of "a select, patrician, highly unrepresentative panel of nine." Alito

joined neither Scalia's dissent nor Thomas's lengthy orthodox-originalist one. His own dissent emphasized same-sex marriage's defiance of tradition and expressed concern that "those who cling to old beliefs" would, in the decision's aftermath, "risk being labeled as bigots and treated as such by governments, employers, and schools."

When Scalia died seven months after *Obergefell*, the conservative legal movement seemed near failure. Republican presidents had appointed three-quarters of the justices since Earl Warren had retired in 1969. The Federalist Society had trained two generations of lawyers and developed a formidable network that dominated federal judgeship hiring. Yet the Supreme Court still practiced living constitutionalism. When President Obama nominated Merrick Garland to replace Scalia, the Court seemed likely to tip decidedly progressive.

But then Senate Republicans denied Garland a hearing and Donald Trump defeated Hillary Clinton. By the end of 2020, Trump had put three young conservatives—Neil Gorsuch, Brett Kavanaugh, and Amy Coney Barrett—on the Court, which promptly veered to the right. With Scalia gone and a conservative supermajority on the Court, Alito grew more confident in expressing impatience with orthodox originalism and in charting a new course for legal conservatism, especially in his extrajudicial writings and talks.

*So Ordered* decries judges who aim to be theorists and lays out a "working judicial" brand of originalism that reflects Alito's decades of "hands-on experience." In many respects, his approach inverts the orthodox view. He jettisons "restraint" as a goal and counsels that originalism "sometimes calls for bold action." In marked contrast with Scalia, who believed that a judge who "always likes the results he reaches is a bad judge," Alito tells jurists "who welcome occasions when their originalist analysis leads to results they dislike" to "shed this insecure mindset." He also thinks that originalists should call attention to the value of the

outcomes that their decisions produce. Unless the theory "is *widely* viewed as *generally* producing good results," he argues, it won't survive. He never explains what makes a result good and never considers that he and his colleagues—and the American people—disagree on that question.

Alito usefully highlights important theoretical conundrums for originalism. A central one is how to tell whether the invariably fuzzy meaning of an old term (*equal protection*, for example) should be applied in specific contexts that the Framers never imagined. Scholars offer an array of complex and clashing solutions to this and related difficulties. Alito invokes judicial "judgment" as the global solution. "Broadly worded constitutional provisions can be regarded as delegating a *degree* of authority to apply those provisions to new situations that could not be anticipated at the time of adoption," he maintains. "Identifying just how far this delegation of authority extends calls for the exercise of judgment."

The obvious problem is that this sounds suspiciously like the judge-specific, discretion-laden "reasoned judgment" that Kennedy invoked in the gay-marriage case—precisely what orthodox originalism aimed to eradicate. Many important constitutional clauses—not just *equal protection* but *due process*, *freedom of speech*, *executive power*—are broadly worded. And many issues that arise in connection with these terms could not have been anticipated in 1791 or 1868. To escape Scalia's "judicial Putsch" verdict, Alito must explain why the judgment that he believes his kind of originalist justice often must exercise won't be guided by ideological or other personal factors. But his explanations are thin and slippery.

Alito holds up Edmund Burke's teachings about prudence and tradition as "invaluable" guides for the "many times when originalist jurists must exercise judgment." But he otherwise defends Burke's relevance to American judging only by noting that

he and many other conservatives esteem him. Unexpectedly, Alito also voices great respect for the work of the Harvard Law professor and fellow Catholic Adrian Vermeule, an arch critic of originalism. Vermeule argues that the theory's moral skepticism, "defensive crouch," and allergy to considering outcomes render it "an obstacle to the development of a robust, substantively conservative approach to constitutional law." He favors interpretation aimed at "the common good," a concept associated with Catholic social teaching.

Although Alito resists some elements of the theory, his account of proper judging seeks to accommodate Vermeule's criticisms—a contrast with the response of his Catholic and orthodox-originalist colleague Amy Coney Barrett, who dismisses it as marred by "all of the defects that originalists critiqued" in the 1980s. Alito also says his own version of originalism "furthers the common good," and he even asks whether "an assessment of what the common good requires" might inform the Court's judgment when original meaning cannot resolve an issue. It's a question he refrains from answering.

Like Alito's dissatisfaction with restraint and his insistence that originalists attend to outcomes, his reliance on ill-defined principles to steer judicial judgment when originalism is stymied will fuel the widespread view that he reads his conservative views into the Constitution. Nor do Alito's several insightful essays on the art of good judging as a practical task grounded in "personal observation and experience" help much. He has a deserved reputation as a fine judicial craftsman, but his judging is filtered through a deeply traditional conservative outlook evident in almost every essay. This is the ideological element that invariably informs judicial judgment—left, right, and center—however much both orthodox originalists and Alito may purport to shun it.

Alito's nominal adherence to originalism even as he struggles to revamp it is but one indication that the doctrine is becoming a

zombie creed that functions more as a shibboleth than as an actual guide to conservative constitutional decision making.

Originalism certainly does not explain the Court's sharp rightward turn since Barrett joined the bench in 2020. Only Thomas, Gorsuch, and Barrett regularly try to practice originalism, and they do so very unevenly. Most of the important recent conservative victories—including overturning *Roe v. Wade*, ending affirmative action in higher education, and giving Trump criminal immunity—were not resolved on the basis of original constitutional meaning. And countless non-originalist precedents remain untouched. The Roberts Court is becoming the "Conservative Warren Court," as Richard Re of Harvard Law School has argued, because it has a "strong majority ideological alignment" that "wields its power in pursuit of its ideological goals" and has soft-pedaled many of the limiting principles, including orthodox originalism, that once defined the movement.

Yet even as the conservative Court has moved right, it has managed to anger the much more right-wing second Trump administration. It has upheld many aspects of Trump's program, most notably his "unitary executive" power to fire heads of independent agencies. But the Roberts Court was trending toward this ruling before Trump came on the scene. More remarkable than how many Trump 2.0 initiatives the Court has validated is how often the moderate conservatives on the Court (some combination of Roberts and the three Trump-appointed justices) have joined liberals to block initiatives—on tariffs, birthright citizenship, National Guard deployment, deportations under the Alien Enemy Act, Federal Reserve independence, mail-in ballots, and more. These decisions have enraged the president and his supporters, who have excoriated the orthodox-originalist Barrett, Scalia's former clerk, in especially vicious terms.

Their fury is more encompassing. Federalist Society lawyers and "originalist judges" are blamed for tying the president's hands

during his first term, for inadequately unwinding progressive constitutionalism, and for disloyalty in not backing Trump when he challenged the 2020 presidential-election results. The president himself has denounced the Federalist Society and hired personally loyal lawyers unburdened by jurisprudential niceties who are eager to implement the administration's self-described "radical" constitutional agenda.

In their attacks on the Court and its moderate conservatives, the Trump administration and its allies are articulating a New Right idea of conservative judging. That view despises originalism's value-neutrality, prizes conservative results, admires judges with the "courage" and "loyalty" to uphold Trump's program, and views adverse decisions as evidence of timidity, establishment capture, or betrayal.

This New Right has its own think tanks and advocacy groups. It has made inroads in Federalist Society chapters on campuses, including my own. The administration is grooming dozens of conservative lawyers to share its view of the law, and has placed at least one New Right stalwart, Emil Bove, on the federal bench. The old conservative legal movement is very far from dead. But its centrality has waned and its originalist commitments are no longer sacrosanct among conservatives.

Alito claims no association with the New Right, but his essays and work on the Court make plain why its legal camp venerates him. Alito, along with Thomas, has supported the Trump administration in every second-term case of importance, including with dissents in every major Trump loss. His results-focused jurisprudence, his culture-warrior profile, and his scorn for fainthearted conservative jurists mesh with the Trump-inspired movement.

Yet it would be a mistake to read Alito's attempts to articulate a judicial philosophy as mere camouflage for a hard-right jurisprudence. *So Ordered* leaves the clear impression that he sees

himself as a serious lawyer adhering to principles. If the principles are not as coherent as they might be, that does not distinguish him from most justices, now or in the past. What is curious is that Alito has articulated a semblance of a judicial philosophy at all, given his wariness about theory as a guide to judging. In the end, his essays serve as a marker of our bitterly fractured constitutional moment. And Alito himself remains an elusive yet powerful presence—the face on the Court, however unintended, of the Trumpian legal agenda.

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/samuel-alito-originalism-so-ordered/688699/

# The Vanity of Kings

**How the ancient pharaohs attempted to preserve their legacies for eternity**

by Susan Tallman

Sun, 04 Oct 2026



The face of Thuya, mother-in-law of Amenhotep III, on her outer anthropoid-coffin lid (Massimo Listri / Fine Arts Museums of San Francisco)

Not so long ago, heroic public statuary felt irrelevant—good for locating yourself in traffic circles but otherwise dismissed as a relic of some credulous, great-man-besotted past. The fact that places like Pyongyang and Ashgabat still went in for it just confirmed the association with autocratic backwardness and childish megalomania.

Things have changed. In Washington, D.C., millions of taxpayer dollars were spent on regilding a pair of allegorical equestrian bronzes with the cheap sheen of a dollar-store trophy, and the Trump administration has been defiantly pursuing legally contested plans for an arch of hypertrophic vulgarity. Meanwhile, in Los Angeles, an exhibition with Kara Walker's dismembered and reconstituted statue of Stonewall Jackson and his horse became one of the most widely covered art events of the past 12 months. Figurative monuments are now being taken seriously—desired by some (well, at least one guy), vilified by many, and argued over by just about everybody. Whose history do they tell? When should they be pulled down or repurposed? How effective are they anyway?

In this environment, the advent of two big museum shows with "Pharaohs" in the title feels timely. No people on Earth have done monuments more ambitiously and lastingly than the ancient Egyptians. Staking claims to eternal fame, pharaohs stamped their names and features on objects of mind-boggling scale: the Great Sphinx of Giza, the Colossi of Memnon, the mountainous figures of Ramesses II at Abu Simbel.

Curated by the former director of the Egyptian Museum in Cairo, Tarek el-Awady, and with a catalog by the high-profile Egyptian archaeologist Zahi Hawass, "Treasures of the Pharaohs" is both a buzzy blockbuster and an assiduous cultural survey. (Now at the de Young Museum, in San Francisco, it will travel to the Kimbell Art Museum, in Fort Worth, next year.) Its 100-plus artifacts stretch from tiny gold animal amulets some 5,000 years old to a gilded

incense burner about 2,700 years younger, and from a child's clay rattle found in a workers' settlement near Thebes to the gold funerary mask of the 21st-dynasty king Amenemope, his bland face framed by the flanged nemes headdress still de rigueur for all costume-party pharaohs.

Styles changed over that enormous time span: The French-bob wig shown on a statue of Lady Hekenu in the fifth dynasty differs from the Gidget flips worn by Ukh-Hotep's wives in the 12th dynasty, which look nothing like the elaborate braided wigs of Senetnay and her daughter in the 18th dynasty. Wigs aside, however, the story is one of overarching continuity: a society structured around divine kingship, detailed preparations for the afterlife, and the cosmological ideal of truth, justice, and order known as *ma'at*, all of which found expression in a remarkably stable set of visual forms.

New pharaohs imitated the monuments of old pharaohs or had them retailored to fit themselves. The essential Egyptian pictorial convention of figures in profile with torsos twisted forward was already in place by the time of King Narmer (around 3000 B.C.E.) and was still serving Cleopatra in 30 B.C.E. (It's worth noting that the distance between those two rulers is 1,000 years longer than that between Cleopatra and us.)

The hook is Bronze Age glamour, and exhibition publicity gives pride of place to the beautiful golden face and blue-lined eyes of Thuya, mother-in-law of the pharaoh Amenhotep III. But Hawass also wants viewers to understand Egypt as "a pioneering power that demonstrated how to build a unified state, establishing the fundamental principles of science and governance." A model boat from the early Middle Kingdom (circa 2000 B.C.E.), fully staffed with oarsmen, a captain, and a sailor plumbing the depths, serves a discussion of Egyptian nautical sophistication. Tomb portraits of commoners such as the carpenter Inty-Shedu back up Hawass's

claim that Egypt's social stability rested in part on its allowance for skill-based upward mobility.

The problem for big surveys like "Treasures" is that it's hard to keep track of so many pharaohs, dynasties, kingdoms, and gods (Hawass counts more than 1,500 deities). The larger sociological points land, and many objects dazzle, but the individual biographies tend to blur.

"Maverick Kings: Three Visionary Pharaohs of Egypt's Golden Age," at the Museum of Fine Arts in Boston, takes a different approach. Lawrence M. Berman, the exhibit's curator, has written two books that tease out tales of individual lives from objects in his care. This exhibition does something similar, zeroing in on Hatshepsut, Amenhotep III (him again), and his son Akhenaten. All belonged to the 18th dynasty (circa 1550–1292 B.C.E.), when Egypt was at its richest and most self-assured. All were outliers in different ways, and all were committed (it's tempting to say addicted) to proclaiming their achievements and broadcasting their images as broadly as possible.

The daughter of one pharaoh and the half sister and wife of another (a frequent Egyptian arrangement), Hatshepsut was serving as co-regent with her young nephew/stepson when she took the title of king herself—an extraordinary, though not unprecedented, action. For more than two decades, she kept the peace, expanded trade, and transformed the temple complex of Karnak at Thebes. She aggrandized processional routes with monuments, including obelisks of solid granite that rose 100 feet and were topped with electrum (a mirror-bright natural gold-silver alloy). Built into the cliffs on the west bank of the Nile, her memorial temple rises in stepped terraces, like something Frank Lloyd Wright might have done if he'd had the power and purse of a potentate. These efforts may have been for the glory of the dynasty's official state god, Amun-Re, but statues of Hatshepsut punctuated the vistas like a visual drumbeat.



A delicately feminine statue of Hatshepsut, a rare woman who took the title of king. (The Metropolitan Museum of Art)

In Boston, an obelisk fragment shows Hatshepsut flat-chested and broad-shouldered, wearing the kilt, headdress, and rectangular false beard of a pharaoh. But in a beguiling seated statue on loan from the Metropolitan Museum of Art, she appears distinctly feminine, delicate and beardless, though still clad in a pharaoh’s kilt and headdress. These variations tell us less about Hatshepsut’s gender proclivities than about monuments as public performance. Egyptian kingship had a recognized visual grammar, and attributes of office could operate independently of physiognomic truth. A manly statue of Hatshepsut was no different in principle from the perennially

youthful Ramesses II we see depicted across his six and a half decades on the throne.

Amenhotep III was Hatshepsut's great-great-grandnephew and perhaps "the greatest patron of the arts in Egypt's history," Berman writes. Having inherited a kingdom and immense wealth, he threw himself into aggrandizing old temples and constructing new ones; he built a palace complex big enough to accommodate an artificial lake and accessorized everything with statues of himself, including the 60-foot-tall Colossi of Memnon. Tempering the geometric rigor of earlier monuments with a new sensuality of form, he established an Egyptian classicism to which later generations repeatedly returned.

It's hard, looking at the finely carved quartzite head of Amenhotep in Boston, to grasp the majesty it would once have conveyed. His skull flows into the bowling-pin-shaped crown of Upper Egypt in a way that closely resembles the Coneheads of early *SNL*. And whereas most pharaohs are shown with a small, serene smile, Amenhotep's heavy-lidded eyes, elegant brows, and grinning lips convey such self-satisfied beatitude that he looks a bit stoned. Originally, however, the head was probably part of a standing statue in which the king's living spirit was present. Instead of conveying drowsiness, those lowered eyelids would have directed his gaze down at subjects, who would have felt themselves seen by a king and a god.

Amenhotep seems also to have been a notably uxorious pharaoh. His wife Tiye is prominent on monuments and sometimes shown at the same scale as her husband, an exceptional statement of equality. When Amenhotep declared himself to be the incarnation of the sun god Re-Horakhty, Tiye, too, was deified. Together they began to shift the focus of royal worship to the Aten, the golden disk of the sun.

Akhenaten followed in his parents' footsteps, dedicating himself to the worship of the Aten, but then, in a profound break with tradition, he eliminated the rest of Egypt's crowded pantheon. When he declared himself to be one with the Aten, Akhenaten fused not just with a god, but with *the* god. His wife Nefertiti joined with both the king and the god in a divine triad.

In Amarna, Akhenaten's new, Aten-focused capital, the art was as peculiar as the theology, offering both the most naturalistic and otherworldly creations in the Egyptian canon. The workshop of the sculptor Thutmose (not to be confused with the pharaohs of that name) contained faces so rough and unflattering that they are thought to have been cast from life. Yet that same workshop created the famous bust of Nefertiti now in Berlin, one of the world's most acclaimed visions of idealized beauty.



Akhenaten, Nefertiti, and two of their daughters appear as eccentrically curved figures in a scene of familial intimacy, a

departure from the heroic and rigid style of royal tradition. (Massimo Listri / Fine Arts Museums of San Francisco)

In place of the heroic proportions and rigidity of royal tradition, statues of Akhenaten emphasized eccentric curves—narrow shoulders, swelling hips, carefully detailed sagging tummy flesh, and a face at once cadaverous and voluptuous. The writer Thomas Mann used the analogy of “an aristocratic young Englishman of somewhat decadent stock; spare, haughty, weary,” but the stylizations could reach buglike extremes. A stela included in “Treasures” shows Akhenaten, Nefertiti, and two of their daughters as wasp-waisted, with bulbous thighs and spindly arms. And yet the affectionate way the two little girls hold hands seems entirely natural. In the context of royal Egyptian art, such scenes of familial intimacy were a novelty, and remain touching.

All three maverick kings did everything in their substantial power to shape their image and control their legacy. It didn’t go as planned for any of them. Hatshepsut had been dead for 20 years when her co-regent and successor, Thutmose III, began erasing her from pharaonic history. The cartouches inscribed with her name were shaved down, her statues smashed and dumped in a quarry pit and in a nearby depression that excavators in the 1920s dubbed the “Hatshepsut Hole.”

Earlier Egyptologists, unable to imagine an honorable woman with power, saw this iconoclasm as a nephew’s revenge on the “vain, ambitious, and unscrupulous” aunt who’d cheated him of his birthright. In the midst of our current culture wars, we might read general misogyny into it, or hostility toward gender nonconformity. The favored explanation among contemporary Egyptologists, however, is dynastic: The aging Thutmose was aware that Hatshepsut’s side of the family had grander bloodlines than his side did, and represented a potential threat to the ascendancy of his son. Traditionally, such women were married off to the heir to gin up his claim, but Hatshepsut’s successful kingship had set a disruptive

precedent. *How nice*, he may have thought, *if people simply forgot that she had ever been pharaoh*.

Earthquakes and the death of hieroglyphic literacy during the Roman empire completed the job Thutmose had begun. Hatshepsut's name was forgotten; her memorial temple was rededicated to healing gods and later became the Coptic monastery of Saint Phoibammon, before falling into ruin. Its walls remained mute until 1829, when Jean-François Champollion, following his Rosetta Stone triumph, visited the site and puzzled over the pairing of an image of a male pharaoh with texts using feminine grammatical endings.

Egyptologists are still sorting out what happened at the end of Akhenaten's reign. Names came and went in quick succession; Nefertiti may have claimed the throne for herself or one of her daughters. When the young Tutankhamun (thought to be Akhenaten's son or nephew) became pharaoh, he wasted little time in restoring the old gods. Within a generation, Akhenaten's temples had been dismantled; within two, his name no longer appeared on the official list of kings. None of his dozens (possibly hundreds) of public statues survives intact. Akhenaten's suppression of the divine pantheon lasted perhaps 17 years, but the disappearance of Akhenaten lasted more than 3,000. Not until the late 19th century did living people again know anything about him, thanks to excavations at Amarna sparked, so the story goes, by a farmer's chance discovery of clay tablets.

As for Amenhotep III, his legacy wasn't attacked, just recycled, as generations of successors helped themselves to his monuments (so much more convenient than quarrying stone from the ground). The most insatiable was Ramesses II, so it is fitting that millennia later, the impending arrival in London of part of one of Ramesses's colossi provided Percy Bysshe Shelley with what has become a byword for futile vanity:

And on the pedestal these words appear:
“My name is Ozymandias, king of kings:
Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!”
Nothing beside remains. Round the decay
Of that colossal wreck, boundless and bare
The lone and level sands stretch far away.

Of all the priorities that governed ancient-Egyptian life, perhaps the hardest for us to fathom is the expenditure on the afterlife, not merely as a place of immaterial spiritual reward, but as a world of material goods. If “Treasures” glitters more than “Maverick Kings,” it’s because almost everything came out of tombs and cemeteries. Those tiny gold animal amulets were found in the necropolis at Naga ed-Deir; the gold toe coverings from the mummy of Psusennes I speak for themselves. These things endured because they were hidden away for use by their dead owners and the gods. Meanwhile, the great public efforts—the colossal statuary, the expansive propaganda programs, the image campaigns, the attempts to remake the world of living people—have been shattered, defaced, and refaced. The only unbroken funerary figure of Akhenaten to have come down to us is smaller than a Barbie doll, and isn’t gold.

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/public-monuments-egyptian-art-exhibits/688700/

# The Journalist and the Manipulator

**Janet Malcolm policed the literary ruses of others, but wasn't afraid to deploy them herself.**

by Thomas Mallon

Tue, 13 Oct 2026



At one point or another, *The New Yorker*'s Janet Malcolm construed each profession or art form she wrote about as a mug's game. She asserted that the "crowning paradox of psychoanalysis is the near-uselessness of its insights," though she filled her work with Freudian tropes and paradigms. (She herself spent eight years in analysis.) The presumption of innocence underlying criminal trials had a "hollowness" that called the whole judicial system into question. Biography was a genre that Malcolm practiced and investigated, and she has now become a subject of it with the publication of Eve Sneider's *The Absent Woman*. But all biography struck Malcolm as "transgressive," an "impertinence"; its readers would be better off accepting that "if anything is our own business, it is our pathetic native self." Which isn't to say that readers should favor autobiography. The "original sin" of that undertaking is to

wallow in “memories of conflict, resentment, blame, self-justification—and it is wrong, unfair, inexcusable to publish them.”

The quotations above come from five books produced over five decades, and this catalog of futility and ethical compromise does not even include Malcolm’s most famous animadversion, which she lobbed against her own craft and calling: “Every journalist who is not too stupid or too full of himself to notice what is going on knows that what he does is morally indefensible.” These words open *The Journalist and the Murderer* (1990), Malcolm’s account of the lawsuit brought by Jeffrey MacDonald (the murderer, an Army captain convicted of killing his wife and children) against Joe McGinniss (the journalist working on a book about him), who’d maintained MacDonald’s cooperation by writing him letters that conveyed the clear impression that McGinniss believed in his innocence. The book McGinniss finally published, *Fatal Vision*, squarely affirmed MacDonald’s guilt.

This literary treachery seemed to agitate Malcolm more than the slaughter of MacDonald’s family. It was all of a piece with her certainty that nonfiction writers made reality and fact as pliable as they are for attorneys facing off in a courtroom. Journalistic accounts of trials all impose falsely coherent plotlines on actuality. According to Malcolm, nonfiction is always aspiring to the authoritative “completeness” and seeming inevitability of fiction. (Notice that the notorious first line of *The Journalist and the Murderer*, which lays down a universal law, has a cadence similar to the opening sentence of *Pride and Prejudice*.) In *The Silent Woman* (1994), her study of the ever-multiplying biographical literature about Sylvia Plath and Ted Hughes, Malcolm took things further: “The ideal of unmediated reporting is regularly achieved only in fiction, where the writer faithfully reports on what is going on in his imagination.”

David A. Graham: Janet Malcolm the magician

Journalists were outraged by Malcolm's account of MacDonald versus McGinniss not just because of what she included in the long *New Yorker* articles where *The Journalist and the Murderer* first took form, but also because of what she omitted: the fact that she herself was then embroiled in litigation launched by Jeffrey Masson, a flamboyant psychoanalyst whose professional adventures she had chronicled while massaging and repositioning interview quotations from him beyond accepted norms. She could produce tape recordings of most of the quotations in their raw form, but a handful of the more inflammatory ones were in written notes that she couldn't locate; in the first of two trials, she was found guilty of libel.

Malcolm insisted that her adaptive techniques had once been "a commonplace of *New Yorker* nonfiction" composed by writers such as Joseph Mitchell, who brought his subjects to levels of articulateness they couldn't reach by themselves. In an afterword to *The Journalist and the Murderer*, an appendage necessitated by the uproar over the *New Yorker* articles, she argued that "when a journalist undertakes to quote a subject he has interviewed on tape, he owes it to the subject, no less than to the reader, to translate his speech into prose." This is at wild variance with all mainstream journalistic ethics. The written genre in which characters, for the reader's convenience, speak better than they would in real life is, of course, the novel.

However much Malcolm acknowledged the queasiness she felt about her own participation in journalism, she barreled ahead. She could not have pulled off her mental acrobatics and compelling portraiture without a brilliant mind and a wickedly piercing style. During John Roberts's Senate confirmation hearings in 2005, the "constant play of expression on his features put one in mind of nineteenth-century primers of acting in which emotions—pleasure, agreement, dismay, uncertainty, hope, fear—are illustrated on the face of a model." The best of her observations merit something beyond Alexander Pope's famous phrase: They're not things oft

thought but ne'er so well expressed; they're things probably never before thought at all. Consider these remarks about having really good seats at *Il Trovatore*:

> The inequality of audience experience is intrinsic to the performing arts and unique to them. Literature and painting and sculpture are mediums of equal opportunity. A rich reader's experience of *Anna Karenina* is no more intense than a poor one's. The hedge-fund owner and the secretary see exactly the same *Raft of the Medusa*. But only the hedge-fund owner gets to see the expression on Azucena's face when she relives throwing the wrong baby into the fire.

Malcolm had an aphorist's desire to turn anything she apprehended into an across-the-board truth. A steady snow of inclusivities —"every," "all," "we," "always"—falls upon her pages:

> Children are always feeling secretly ashamed or anxious.
>
> All families of suicides are alike.
>
> There is a law of human nature—let us call it the Confidant's Law—that dictates that no secret is ever told to only one person; there is always at least one other person to whom we feel compelled to spill the beans.

One usually waits in vain for a single example to support these ostensibly omnipresent phenomena. And yet, Malcolm's mordant power of tone makes a reader register and silently assent to a great deal of this ex cathedra stuff. Her style alone keeps her worthy of our attention. But the particular way she challenged assumptions of objectivity is what makes her a figure intriguing enough to merit her own biography. In her exposés of literary malpractice, she was unafraid to use some of the very manipulations she was decrying. The writs she issued to others were also blank checks made out to herself.

Sneider's subtitle, *The Genius of Janet Malcolm*, makes one fear a book of fangirl gush, probably the last thing Malcolm herself would have wanted. One flinches further upon learning that Malcolm had invited Sneider to tea after she, then still a Yale undergraduate, curated an exhibition of Malcolm's papers in the university's Beinecke Library. But seven years after that tea, Sneider, now a contributor to *The New York Review of Books*, has produced a book that assembles the biographical facts about Malcolm with admirable brevity, if not always precision. As for her subject's writing, Sneider more or less concurs with a widespread verdict: "Malcolm acolytes will tell you that she is everywhere and nowhere within her work." If traditional literary biography seeks to illuminate the work through the life, this one mostly reverses direction. *The Absent Woman* is a play on the title of Malcolm's Plath book, and a kind of challenge that Sneider issues to herself and to readers: Go find the person in the books she wrote.

Sneider's voice is a lot breezier than Malcolm's (whose isn't?). The casual coarseness of her texting generation's style ("pissing other people off," "a little fucked up") makes one imagine her blithely dropping crumbs on Malcolm's carpet during that tea. Sneider does share a few basic techniques with her subject, such as taking the reader along on her research, making the work on the book part of the book itself. She also breaks into the first person ("I would be remiss not to mention") when that seems useful.

Sneider tells us that Malcolm arrived in the United States, a Jewish Czech refugee, along with her parents in July 1939 (not a moment too soon), when she was almost 5 years old. Members of the Winn (originally Wiener) family assimilated with considerable speed and success, even as they remained closely tied to their fellow Czechs in Manhattan's Yorkville neighborhood; Jana, now Janet, continued to speak Czech with her parents. In 1951, she went off to the University of Michigan. The most surprisingly titled chapter in *The Absent Woman* is "The Humorist," which covers Malcolm's writing and editing for the school's frolicsome undergraduate magazine,

*The Gargoyle*. When Sneider mentions a later *New Yorker* colleague who said Malcolm "has not one drop of humor—not one," she interprets the comment as "ironic," but a reader of Malcolm's work will find little to support such an interpretation. Cold wit abounds, but precious little warmth and laughter.

Before leaving Ann Arbor, Janet Winn married Donald Malcolm, her editorial predecessor at *The Gargoyle*. After graduation, the two moved to Washington, D.C., where both wrote for *The New Republic*, and a few years later to Manhattan, where each began a long association with *The New Yorker*. Now the mother of a young daughter, Malcolm wrote about shopping and interior design before becoming the magazine's photography critic. Sneider observes that Malcolm's "writing on photography could be read as a commentary on her own craft. She was fascinated by the medium's quest for realism, by its murky relationship to truth-telling." Donald died young, in 1975, by which time Janet had already begun an affair with Gardner Botsford, another *New Yorker* editor. She insisted to William Shawn, the magazine's top editor, that Botsford continue to edit her stories even after she married him.

Sneider properly gives a great deal of attention to Malcolm's style, characterizing it as "terrifyingly sharp," "commanding," and "cutting." There is such a subzero severity to it that on the rare occasions when Malcolm uses an exclamation point, it's as if someone else has plunked an emoji onto the page. One friend of hers noted that "the impersonality of how she writes is really the personality." But Malcolm saw even the chilly projection of impersonality as just another self-interested construction. As she put it in *The Silent Woman*, "writing cannot be done in a state of desirelessness. The pose of fair-mindedness, the charade of evenhandedness, the striking of an attitude of detachment can never be more than rhetorical ruses."

Malcolm affected these postures herself, and on occasion she could be almost cruel in the pursuit of some small thematic end. In *The*

*Silent Woman*, she describes a visit to the home of one source, an elderly man who decades earlier had spoken with Plath the night before she died. Her prolonged description of the house's awful filth and hoardings is apparently justified by how it "stirred my imagination as a metaphor for the problem of writing"—namely, the need to rid one's "vastly overfilled mind" of all but the essential points before starting. One has to ask whether this famous scourge of nonfiction's distortions didn't sometimes use metaphor only to crush reality beneath the gallop of her own hobbyhorses.

From the April 2004 issue: Sylvia Plath, domesticated goddess

If Malcolm, who died in 2021, had a "late style," it was somewhat looser, less guarded. In her 70s, widowed and living by Manhattan's Gramercy Park, she continued to make and exhibit collages in which text and photographic images sometimes combined in a process vaguely akin to the one she uses in *Still Pictures* (2023), a posthumously published memoir that allowed Malcolm to approach her own memories obliquely, through family photographs. Those physical objects seem as if they should offer factuality, or at least clues that unassisted memory cannot. But like letters and trial transcripts and so many tools of the trades that Malcolm scrutinized, the pictures sometimes let her down. Examining one snapshot of her very young self, taken several years before her first conscious memory, she writes, "No feeling of identification stirs as I look at her round face and thin arms and her incongruously assertive pose."

The profile writing that she collected in *Nobody's Looking at You* (2019)—which includes portrayals of the pianist Yuja Wang, the clothing designer Eileen Fisher, and the three sisters running Manhattan's Argosy Book Store—tended toward the gentle and appreciative and even the self-mocking. (In the Fisher portrait, she hears herself "babbling about the ethical dilemmas of journalism.") These articles don't always go very deep; there's no mystery to solve or fraud to expose. They come from a writer whose

incandescent energy has subsided to a more ordinary professional level.

Sneider herself admits that Malcolm “threw a lot of spaghetti at the wall” when trying to justify her tampering with Jeffrey Masson’s interview quotes. Even admirers of Malcolm will concede this and likely wish that Sneider herself were more skeptical, less tolerant, than she appears to be of some of Malcolm’s peculiar behaviors and explanations. A year after the second trial, as Sneider summarizes it, “Malcolm’s two-year-old granddaughter Sophy pulled an inconspicuous red notebook off a bookshelf in her country home that, at long last, contained the handwritten notes she had been missing throughout the lawsuit. Three of the five quotes Masson took issue with were now more solidly on the record.” She seems to accept this story at face value, and perhaps it’s true. But if you had been involved in the fight of your life for what Sneider rightly describes as “twelve long, trying, tedious years,” wouldn’t you have at least run your hand along every bookshelf in your city apartment and country house to make sure that you hadn’t inadvertently put the crucial missing notes somewhere in your library? Without any expression of unease, Sneider informs us that Malcolm “opted not to part with the little red notebook” when she sent her papers to Yale; she instead supplied “photocopies of the relevant pages.”

Sneider correctly cites “control” as a core feature of Malcolm’s presentation, because at least the appearance of control (and its resultant authority) remains even when Malcolm is engaged in small fiddlings and concealments, or in her signature overstated generalizations. (Pronouncements that Sneider calls “bold” might better and more often be labeled “bald.”) Malcolm learned to discard one persona for another not only on the page but during her great legal crisis. Long after her courtroom troubles were over, she paid tribute to Sam Chwat, the acting-and-speech coach who helped her achieve a measure of vindication at the second Masson trial, in 1994, where she was cleared of libeling the psychoanalyst.

She regretted how, at the first trial, well trained in the “accustomed *New Yorker* manner”—reticent and remote—she “came across as arrogant, truculent, and incompetent.” For the second trial, Chwat got her to address the jury, instead of Masson’s lawyer, when she was being questioned. He also orchestrated a makeover of her wardrobe, moving her from “skirts or trousers with jackets in black or subdued colors” into “pastel-colored dresses and suits, silk stockings and high heels, and an array of pretty scarves.”

The metamorphosis didn’t just succeed legally; it appealed to Malcolm in a visceral way. Chwat’s “gentle correction of my self-presentation at trial,” she wrote in a *New York Review of Books* essay, “took me to unexpected places of self-knowledge.” It convinced her that she could perform the tricks whose exposure continued to be her life’s work.

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/absent-woman-janet-malcolm-eve-sneider/688701/

**Departments**

- **The Commons: What Song Is America’s True National Anthem?**
- **Look Closer: This Lizard Tells a Story**

# What Song Is America’s True National Anthem?

**Readers respond to our July 2026 issue and more.**

Tue, 13 Oct 2026
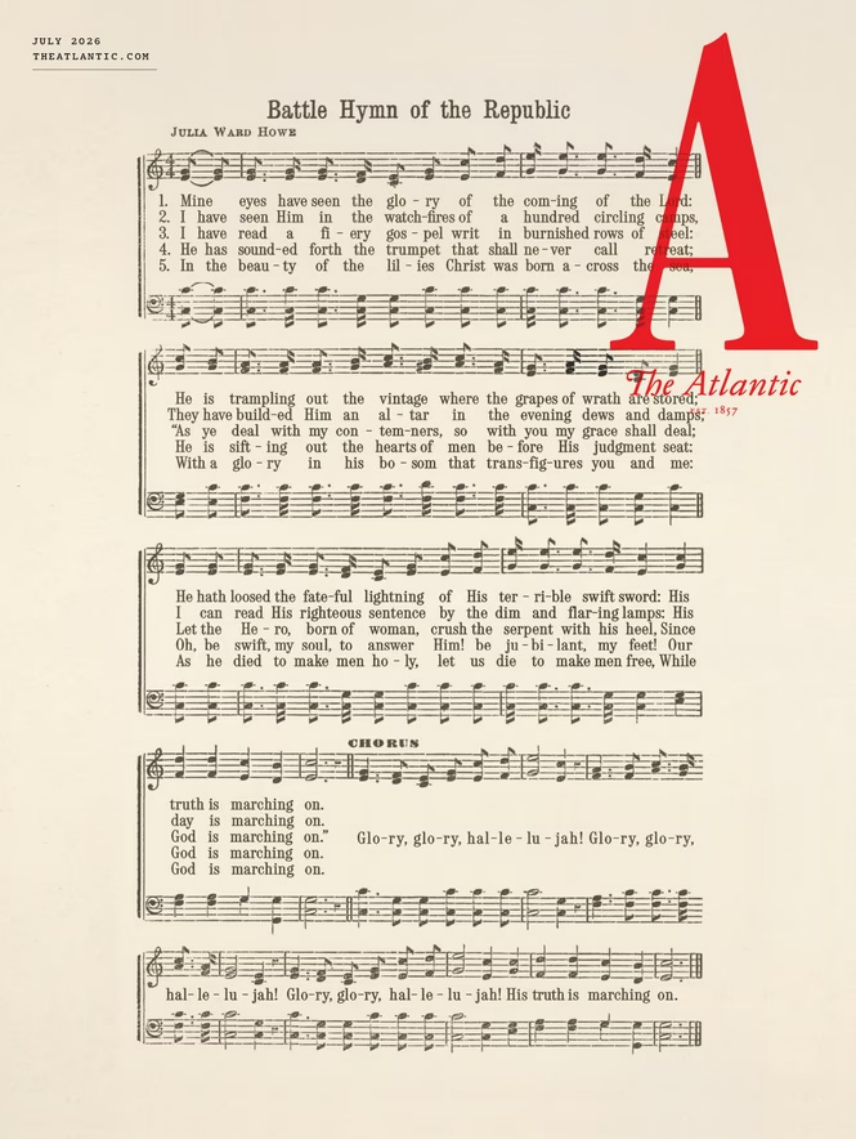



Never Call Retreat

*“Battle Hymn of the Republic,” first published in* The Atlantic *in 1862, still endures as a sacred national song, Jake Lundberg argued in the July issue. To mark the 250th anniversary of America’s founding, we featured the poem on that issue’s cover.*

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Sometimes it’s the cover of the magazine that gets me. The July issue, featuring the music for “Battle Hymn of the Republic” on the cover, sat on my piano and was played loudly and often.

**Laura Cardinal**
*Hereford, Ariz.*




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“Battle Hymn of the Republic” is a fitting choice for a celebration of America’s 250th anniversary. The literary scholar Elaine Showalter wrote a comprehensive biography of its author, *The Civil Wars of Julia Ward Howe*. The title is a reminder that Howe fought her own battle for equality and a public voice even as she gave the nation its most enduring hymn. In inscribing my copy of the book, Showalter wrote: “Julia’s motto was ‘Up to Date!’ Good words for us as well.” That *The Atlantic* has chosen to celebrate her again, 164 years after first publishing her poem, suggests that the motto belongs to this magazine as much as it did to her.

**Sandy Shapiro**
*Washington, D.C.*

Jake Lundberg's story, "Never Call Retreat," about the history and endurance of "Battle Hymn of the Republic," begins with the observation that we seem to have two national anthems: not only "The Star-Spangled Banner," but also the "Battle Hymn." To my mind, we actually have three, and I was surprised by the omission of "Lift Every Voice and Sing," often called the Black national anthem. It was composed in 1900 as a poem by James Weldon Johnson, and his brother, J. Rosamond Johnson, set it to music. The song, unlike the other two, makes no reference to war and embraces both the sorrow and the majesty of our shared life as Americans. In my church, we sing this beloved anthem as our opening hymn once a month.

**Donna Jane Krupkin**
*Nashville, Tenn.*

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Jake Lundberg argues that the United States has two national anthems—one official, "The Star-Spangled Banner," and another unofficial but sacred, Julia Ward Howe's "Battle Hymn of the Republic." I would add a third: John Newton's "Amazing Grace," a hymn that serves as a spiritual national anthem and provokes deeper introspection into our country's struggle to abolish slavery.

Newton wrote the words to "Amazing Grace" in 1772, 42 years before Francis Scott Key wrote "The Star-Spangled Banner." Whereas I see the "Battle Hymn" as the battle cry for action in the abolitionist cause, "Amazing Grace" was and remains the soulful anthem for those seeking freedom.

I pray that a resurgence of "Amazing Grace" and the "Battle Hymn" over the airwaves and in our communities may lead our nation down a new path toward real freedom for all Americans.

**Jerry Albritton**
*Brandenburg, Ky.*

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“Never Call Retreat” provides interesting historical background on the origins of “Battle Hymn of the Republic” and the song’s enduring place in American life. But I take issue with the suggestion that the “Battle Hymn” should be regarded as an unofficial national anthem.

Our official national anthem is already battle-themed. Do we need yet another war-inspired song, especially one that implies a specifically Christian God?

I would argue that “America the Beautiful,” which celebrates the grandeur of our country and evokes the principles of our founding documents, ought to be our national anthem.

**Owen Jansson**
*Ann Arbor, Mich.*

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The “Battle Hymn of the Republic” has been sung at many solemn occasions. I was introduced to it as a 15-year-old while watching Winston Churchill’s funeral on television on January 30, 1965, at St. Paul’s Cathedral in London. During the service, mourners listened to the glorious sound of the “Battle Hymn,” projected by a huge choir. It was a truly moving experience, and one I won’t forget. The hymn, I later learned, had been performed at Churchill’s request.

**Nigel Clements**
*Mississauga, Canada*

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My father, Richard P. Condie, directed the Mormon Tabernacle Choir from 1957 to 1974. “Battle Hymn of the Republic” always reminds me of his collaboration with Eugene Ormandy and the Philadelphia Orchestra. While my father was preparing for a recording with the orchestra for Columbia Records, he called Ormandy at 2 a.m. and asked him to look at the score of the “Battle Hymn.” Days later, Ormandy called back and said he wasn’t “excited” by the idea and wasn’t sure it would be good. However, at my father’s insistence, Ormandy relented and agreed to include the song on the recording.

In 1959, the Mormon Tabernacle Choir’s “Battle Hymn of the Republic” became an unlikely hit, reaching No. 13 on the *Billboard* Hot 100, where it remained for 16 weeks. My father won a Grammy for the performance the following year. The recording catapulted the choir and orchestra to prominence and forged a lifelong collaboration and friendship between my father and Ormandy.

The lyrics of the “Battle Hymn” speak to the eternal truths of the human soul. Perhaps that’s what my father realized when he called Ormandy that night. If only we as a nation would take Julia Ward Howe’s words to heart: Be transfigured; overcome hatred, evil, and vengeance with forgiveness, love, and charity; and embrace the divine potential of the human soul. Then, I think, we could say with confidence that “His truth is marching on.”

**Jeanette Condie Pearson**
*Salt Lake City, Utah*

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Jake Lundberg replies:

*I want to thank our readers for this thoughtful collection of letters. “Battle Hymn of the Republic” addressed the gravest crisis in our history in the dire biblical idiom that was familiar to many*

*northern tongues when Howe wrote it at the end of 1861, and to which Abraham Lincoln would give fullest expression in his second inaugural address four years later. In its many afterlives since its publication, the "Battle Hymn" has proved to be a capacious vessel for arguments over the American idea. It's true: Its imagery is stark and violent, and some of its strains through time have been dark. But in their best application, Julia Ward Howe's words—set to the thumping tune of a marching song about the militant abolitionist John Brown—call on us to stand up for our highest ideals, all the more so in moments of crisis.*

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Behind the Cover

In this month's cover story, "Choose Your Overlord," Josh Tyrangiel reports on the race between Jeff Bezos and Elon Musk to shape humanity's future beyond Earth. Because of their immense wealth, Tyrangiel writes, the two mercurial billionaires now wield a degree of power traditionally reserved for nation-states. For our cover image, the artist Thomas Burden rendered Bezos and Musk as dueling action figures hurtling into space.

— **Colin Hunter**, *Art Director*




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*This article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline "The Commons." When you buy a book using a link on this page, we receive a commission. Thank you for supporting* The Atlantic.

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/the-commons/688698/

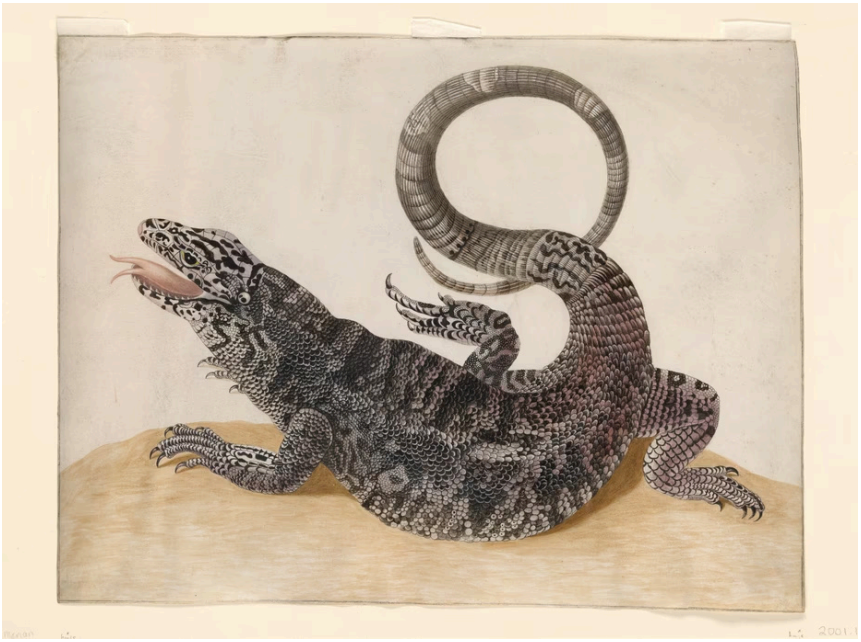
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# Look Closer: This Lizard Tells a Story

**Maria Sibylla Merian’s pioneering nature painting captured animals as they were.**

by Susan Tallman

Sun, 11 Oct 2026



*Black Tegu Lizard (Tupinambis teguixin)*, Maria Sibylla Merian, circa 1705–15. Pen and black ink, watercolor and opaque watercolor, on vellum. (The Morgan Library & Museum. 2001.10. Purchased on the Sunny Crawford von Bülow Fund 1978.)

In 1699, Maria Sibylla Merian and her daughter Dorothea set sail from Amsterdam for Suriname. Merian was 52 years old, a successful artist and pioneering entomologist, whose book on caterpillars had demonstrated their stages of transformation from egg to butterfly. Her nearly two years in South America resulted in a volume on the metamorphosis of Surinamese insects that made her Europe’s preeminent female biologist for a time. The book also provided some of the most captivating images in natural history.

Earlier artists had depicted various specimens, in isolation and usually dead, but Merian tells stories about life. Butterflies appear alongside their caterpillars and chrysalises; ants crawl up and down the leaves they've decimated; flying cockroaches besiege a pineapple. By showing an animal in its natural context and in multiple forms, Merian pioneered an approach that we now take for granted. Her work introduced many new creatures to European readers, and was later a vital resource for the great taxonomist Carl Linnaeus in designating species.

In Suriname, she and Dorothea brought that same observational precision and curiosity to bear on mammals, amphibians, and reptiles, such as the meter-long tegu lizard. The tegu lifespan is too extended for Merian to have fully observed it from egg to senescence. But she composed an image that manages to convey the lizard's scale (it barely fits on the page) and speed (caught mid-motion), along with minute details of its appearance (every scale has its own shape and pattern). Anatomical accuracy did not preclude a fabulous *S*-shaped calligraphic flourish of tail, a bit of squiggly biological extravagance that invites us to wonder at the real world.

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*This article appears in the November 2026 print edition with the headline "Black Tegu Lizard."*

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https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/2026/11/maria-sibylla-merian-black-tegu-lizard/688677/

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**Poetry**

- **Puffins**

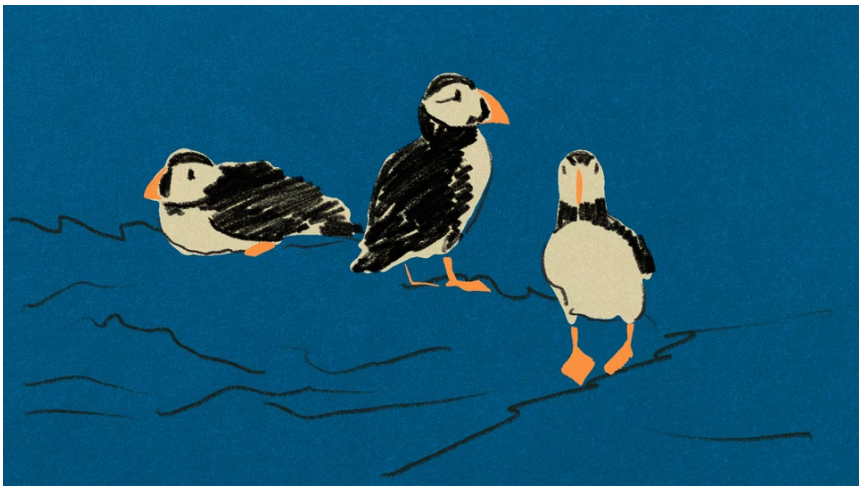
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# Puffins

**A poem**

by Ange Mlinko

Sun, 04 Oct 2026



The wind brings the circus
to a lonesome town upstate,
and puffins to the Isle of May,
        seagirt, desolate.

The wind brings spectators
by ferry to the docks.
Side by side like gravy boats
        seals loll on the rocks.

The throng swipes their shoes
on a disinfectant mat,
running down the gangplank
        to the puffins' habitat.

The main ring is the breeding ground
where lies their single egg

circled with a constant cry
echoed off the crag.

They circle, circle, swoop, and dive,
coming back with silver sprats
like spiny roses in the teeth
of undefeated acrobats.

The comic masks they wear belie
the effort it must take
to migrate all their lives in search
of a decent windbreak.

Clown-bright lichen clothes the rocks,
sea campion froths in grass.
Here’s the roofless abbey
on a speck in the atlas.

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*This poem appears in the November 2026 print edition.*

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